



CITY: Pg 3

'Daughters are architects of tomorrow': CM Gupta



NATION: Pg 5

Govt, Oppn slug it out on fuel situation



FILM: Pg 14

Kate Winslet in talks to star in the film

CLOSURE OF STRAIT OF HORMUZ SHOULD BE USED AS LEVERAGE: SUPREME LEADER

Shut US bases or face fire: Iran

Outlines 3 conditions to end war — rights, reparations, guarantees



Firefighters work at a residential building damaged last Monday during the U.S.-Israeli air campaign in Tehran, Iran, on Thursday

TEHRAN'S ULTIMATUM

- » The Iranian leader vowed to avenge those killed in the war and claimed that Iran would 'obtain compensation' from its enemy
- » He said that if it refuses to do so, Iran will 'take from its assets' or destroy them to the same extent
- » A limited amount of this revenge has so far taken concrete form, but until it is fully achieved, this case will remain among our priorities
- » In a post on social media platform X, Pezeshkian also demanded compensation for damages incurred during the war

» IRAN'S UNRELENTING ATTACKS ON SHIPPING TRAFFIC AND ENERGY INFRASTRUCTURE IN THE PERSIAN GULF PUSHED OIL BACK ABOVE \$100 A BARREL

ASSOCIATED PRESS

TEHRAN/DUBAI: Iran's new Supreme Leader, Mojtaba Khamenei, has issued his first statement since being appointed, saying Iran will con-

tinue attacking US bases in the region and the Strait of Hormuz will remain closed.

He said that the Strait of Hormuz must remain closed as leverage against the US and that the attacks on Middle East

neighbours will continue.

Khamenei's statement was read on state television on Thursday by a news anchor, and he did not appear on camera.

He warned that US military bases could be attacked if

they remain operational in the region.

"I recommend that they close those bases as soon as possible, because they must have realised by now that the claim of establishing security and peace by America

Continued on P4

'Markets down' for second day

MUMBAI: Benchmark equity indices ended with deep cuts on Thursday, with the Sensex tumbling over 800 points amid a sharp rise in crude oil prices due to the heightening crisis in West Asia.

Besides, sluggish global market trends, weakness in the rupee and persistent foreign capital outflows also rattled investors' sentiment, analysts said. The 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 829.29 points, or 1.08 per cent, to settle at 76,034.42. During the day, it plunged 992.53 points or 1.29 per cent to 75,871.18.

Similarly, the 50-share NSE Nifty fell 227.70 points, or 0.95 per cent, to close at 23,639.15. See P10

AMID WEST ASIA TENSIONS

No fuel worry, Puri tells LS

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: Union Minister of Petroleum and Natural Gas Hardeep Singh Puri on Thursday assured Parliament that India's energy supplies remain robust despite global disruptions caused by the conflict in West Asia, emphasising that strategic diversification and emergency measures have kept fuel availability normal nationwide.

During his address in the Lok Sabha, Puri highlighted that the world is facing an unprecedented energy crisis, triggered by the disruption of commercial shipping through the Strait of Hormuz—a first in recorded history—due to military tensions involving Iran, Israel, and the United States. With nearly 20 per cent of global crude, natural gas, and LPG flowing through the strait, this situation poses serious challenges for energy-importing nations like India.

Continued on P4



Union Minister for Petroleum and Natural Gas Hardeep Singh Puri speaks in the Lok Sabha

KEY POINTS

- » Puri reassured that India's crude oil supply remains comfortable, with imports now exceeding volumes previously passing through Hormuz thanks to alternative routes
- » Before the crisis, 45 per cent of India's crude imports came via the strait; now, over 70 per cent are sourced from other regions

Delhi in touch with Tehran on ships

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: The government informed on Thursday that India is actively collaborating with Iran to ensure the safe passage of Indian ships through the Strait of Hormuz amid rising regional tensions. In

response to inquiries, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) shared that Minister S. Jaishankar has had three conversations with Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi over the past few days. These discussions focused on maritime and energy

Continued on P4

Om Birla returns to the Speaker's chair

'No MP enjoys privilege, will preserve LS dignity'

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Speaker Om Birla on Thursday said Lok Sabha functions strictly according to rules and no member has the privilege to speak whenever he or she wishes and warned that if anyone behaves contrary to the decorum of the House, he would be compelled to take strict action to preserve its dignity.

A day after a resolution seeking his removal from office was defeated, Birla also said that members may personally agree or disagree with the decision of the Chair, but it remains his duty to enforce the rules, procedures and traditions of the House.

He said the Chair does not belong to any individual, it is a symbol of India's democratic traditions, the spirit of the Constitution, and the prestige of this great institution.

The speaker said whether it is the Leader of the House (Prime Minister), the Leader of the Opposition (LoP), or any other member - they can speak only by following the procedures laid down in the rules of the House.

Thursday was the first time Birla came to the House to conduct the proceedings since the notice of no confidence was given against him by the opposition on February 10 during the first part of the Budget session, which ended on February 13. The second part of the session began on March 9.

Continued on P4



CHAIR DOES NOT BELONG TO ANY INDIVIDUAL, IT IS A SYMBOL OF INDIA'S DEMOCRATIC TRADITIONS, THE SPIRIT OF THE CONSTITUTION, AND THE PRESTIGE OF THIS GREAT INSTITUTION

MPs vs CEC: 193 demand ouster

Notice may hit LS or RS today

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A total of 130 Lok Sabha MPs and 63 Rajya Sabha MPs have signed notices seeking the removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, a source has said.

According to the source, the notice is likely to be submitted in at least one House on Friday, though it was not clear it would be brought first in which House.

An Opposition leader, meanwhile, said MPs have shown great enthusiasm in signing the notice, and several

Continued on P4

RAINY STROLL



People walk with umbrellas during a rain shower at Mall Road, in Manali, on Thursday

PTI

SOME PEOPLE TRYING TO CREATE PANIC: PM MODI

Panic: Fuel fears fuel queues

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: People queued up at petrol stations and domestic LPG outlets amid panic buying across the country over a perceived paucity of fuel, even as the government told Parliament on Thursday that there was no shortage of petrol, diesel and kerosene due to the West Asia crisis and it was not the time for rumour-mongering.

Oil minister Hardeep Singh Puri said in the Lok Sabha there was no shortage of LPG, crude, petrol, diesel, ATF and Kerosene even as videos showed people standing in queue outside gas station in several parts of the country.

Hardeep Singh Puri said the "field reports" indicate that hoarding and panic-buying at the distributor and retail level are "driven by consumer anxi-



» 'SOME PEOPLE ARE TRYING TO CREATE PANIC AND PURSUE THEIR OWN AGENDAS. I DON'T WANT TO COMMENT ON THEM POLITICALLY AT THIS TIME'

ety rather than any actual supply shortage."

India is in its fourth consecutive day of LPG shortages, with disruptions being reported across major cities including Mumbai, Bengaluru, and Kolkata.

In his address at the NXT Summit on late Thursday evening, Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged state governments to enhance monitoring to stop black-marketers and hoarders in such times. "Our resolve is

clear - citizens should not face any problems due to wars in different parts of the world," he said.

"Some people are trying to create panic and pursue their own agendas. I don't want to comment on

Continued on P4

CLOSER LOOK

» In his address at the NXT Summit on late Thursday evening, Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged state governments to enhance monitoring to stop black-marketers and hoarders in such times

» 'Our resolve is clear - citizens should not face any problems due to wars in different parts of the world'



REPRESENTATIVE IMAGE

released by the National Statistics Office (NSO).

The major items that witnessed a high pace of price

THE UPTICK IN INFLATION WAS ALMOST ENTIRELY LED BY THE FOOD AND BEVERAGES (F&B) SEGMENT

hike were 'silver, gold, diamond, platinum jewellery', coconut-copra, tomato, and cauliflower.

On the other hand, there was disinflation in garlic, onion, potato, arhar, and litchi.

Inflation rates for rural and urban areas were at 3.37 per cent and 3.02 per cent, respectively.

Aditi Nayar, Chief Economist, ICRA, said that the uptick in inflation was almost entirely led by the food and beverages (F&B) segment, which accounted for as much

as 44 bps of the 47 bps rise in the headline print between these months.

Core inflation (CPI excluding F&B and electricity, gas and other fuels) remained unchanged at 3.4 per cent between January and February.

Nayar further said the ongoing geopolitical tensions in West Asia pose upside risks to the CPI inflation trajectory, if sustained

Continued on P4

Advertisement for Har Payment Digital, featuring a man scanning a QR code and text: "Scanning an unknown QR? THODA DHYAN SE!"

BLACK MARKET FEARS

Police keep close watch on LPG agencies during supply crunch

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Senior Delhi Police officials have directed their officers to prepare a list of gas agencies in their respective jurisdictions and deploy personnel to maintain law and order in view of the ongoing problem of LPG supply in the city. The move aims to ensure smooth distribution of cooking gas cylinders and prevent any attempt at black marketing during the supply crunch, police said on Thursday.

A senior police officer stated that Station House Officers (SHOs) have been directed to maintain a visible police presence around gas agencies in their areas.

"The SHOs will deploy police personnel along with PCR vans and motorcycle patrol riders near gas agencies to maintain law and order and ensure that the distribution process remains smooth," the officer said. He said the primary objective of the measure is to deter any attempt to hoard or illegally sell LPG cylinders at inflated prices.

"The sole motive is to maintain law and order and avoid



any kind of black marketing. We want to ensure that people receive LPG cylinders through the proper distribution system," the officer added. He further explained that beat staff and motorcycle patrol units will monitor gas agencies and their surrounding areas regularly.

Another officer mentioned that the police are also compiling a list of shopkeepers who allegedly refill small LPG cylinders at excessively high prices, which constitutes black marketing.

"Such shopkeepers will be identified, and strict action will be taken against them. No one will be permitted to engage in gas black marketing,"

the officer asserted.

He added that illegally filling LPG cylinders poses a serious safety hazard. "Filling cylinders illegally can pose a risk of fire incidents and blasts. Apart from being illegal, it can also endanger lives and property," he said.

Police teams, including plain-clothes personnel, have been instructed to remain vigilant and gather information on such illegal activities.

"Motorcycle riders and plain-clothes police personnel will keep checking their areas and contact local sources to find out if anyone is involved in illegal refilling or black marketing of LPG," the officer said.

These directives come at a time when irregular LPG supplies have begun to affect households and businesses across Delhi. Industry representatives report that the shortage is impacting restaurants and cafes, many of which rely heavily on LPG for their daily operations.

With LPG supplies becoming irregular, several eateries have allegedly run out of their fuel stock, forcing them to make operational adjust-

Wedding planners warn catering costs might rise

NEW DELHI: Delhi-NCR's lavish wedding feasts, known for large biryani cauldrons and live cooking stations, rely heavily on commercial LPG cylinders.

However, recent supply disruptions have raised concerns among planners and caterers, who warn that catering costs could rise by around 10 to 20 per cent if the situation persists.

Mohsin Khan of Vivah Luxury Weddings said large events require a steady supply of cylinders for bulk cooking and live counters. "Many vendors say their stock lasts only two to four days. We are already seeing discussions about simpler menus,

fewer live stations and price hikes of around 10 to 15 per cent," he said.

Sangeeta, a South Delhi wedding planner, said catering makes up a major share of wedding budgets. "If the issue continues, catering costs could rise by 10 to 20 per cent," she noted.

Another planner said outdoor weddings may be affected more as caterers depend almost entirely on LPG cylinders, unlike hotels that often have piped gas. Vendors said rising commercial LPG prices—from around Rs 1,700–1,800 earlier to nearly Rs 3,000 in some cases—could push per-plate costs higher if supplies remain irregular. **MP05T**

ments, including limiting menu options and switching to alternative cooking methods. Some establishments have begun shifting to piped natural gas or induction-based cooking

Burari tutor accused of abusing 3 minor students over 2 years

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A private tutor in north Delhi's Burari allegedly sexually assaulted three minor students over nearly two years, threatening them with dire consequences including circulating AI-generated obscene images and killing their family members if they spoke about the abuse, police said on Thursday.

The girls, Class 12 students of a private school and residents of Burari area, had been attending tuition classes at a coaching institute for past three years. One of the girls, aged 17, alleged that the teacher frequently touched the students inappropriately during classes, police said.

Based on a complaint by one of the girls on Monday, an FIR was lodged against the accused tutor at Burari police station under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, along with Section 6 of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act which deals with aggravated penetrative sexual assault.

The accused is currently absconding and police teams have been formed to trace him, police said.

The complainants told police that whenever they

objected to the accused's behaviour, he would threaten to kill them and their family members, instilling fear and dissuading them from reporting the incidents earlier.

The complaint further stated that in October 2024, the accused organised a birthday gathering at the coaching centre. During the gathering, he allegedly assaulted the three students while under the influence of alcohol after learning that they had gone out with friends.

In another incident reported by the girls, the accused allegedly called two of them to the coaching centre in August last year, where he beat them with a belt and sexually assaulted them. Two days later, he allegedly assaulted the third student at the same location.

When one of the students threatened to reveal the incidents to her family, the accused allegedly warned that he would circulate AI-generated obscene photographs and videos of the girls on social media, police said.

The case surfaced after the accused allegedly tried to defame the girls at one victim's home, prompting her to reveal the abuse. Police said the tutor fled and efforts are underway to arrest him.

Blaze at Noida factory leaves 37 workers injured



DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: A major fire broke out early on Thursday at a power meter manufacturing unit in Sector 4 under Phase-1 Police Station limits in Noida, injuring at least 37 workers, officials said.

The blaze erupted around 5.30 am at B-40 in the factory premises of Capital Power System Limited while a night shift was underway. About 341 employees were present in the building at the time.

Preliminary investigations suggest the fire may have been caused by a short circuit. Flames and thick smoke spread rapidly through the unit, triggering panic among workers as they attempted to escape. Police and fire department teams rushed to the spot and evacuated workers from the building. The injured were taken to the District Hospital in Sector 39 for treatment. Some were discharged after first aid, while others remain under medical observation.

Several workers reportedly broke window panels to escape the smoke-filled building, while local residents helped rescue trapped employees by placing ladders against the structure. Firefighters faced difficulty controlling the blaze as large quantities of plastic materials and electrical wiring stored inside the factory fuelled the flames.

Police personnel smashes window, moves CNG car to avert explosion in Matiala slum

NEW DELHI: A major explosion was averted in southwest Delhi's Matiala area when a Delhi Police head constable smashed the window of a locked CNG-fitted car and moved it away from a raging fire that destroyed over 400 shanties, officials said on Thursday.

The fire broke out in a slum cluster in the Mansaram Park area late on Wednesday night.

According to Deputy Commissioner of Police (PCR) Pawan Kumar, the Bindapur police station received a call regarding the blaze at 11.57 pm. Local police teams and PCR units reached the spot to assist in the evacuation of residents.

During the rescue operation, Head Constable Ramratan Saran spotted a locked car parked in close proximity to the spreading flames.

Realising the vehicle was



equipped with a CNG kit and the risk of explosion due to intense heat, the officer smashed the car window with a stone and moved it to a safer location.

"The fire had reached very close to the vehicle. It was a new CNG car with a gas cylinder inside. Since it was locked, I broke the window and moved it away," Saran said.

Deputy Commissioner of Police (Dwarka) Kushal Pal Singh said the officer's timely intervention prevented a major incident. Visuals of the incident were later shared by the Delhi Police on their official X handle, praising the head constable's "prudent action".

"During the fire that broke out in the slums of the Bindapur. Head Constable Ramratan

Saran deployed in the PCR unit present at the scene, spotted a car parked extremely close to the fire and, sensing the possibility of an explosion, broke the car's window and had the vehicle moved away in time. This prudent action averted a major disaster," the Delhi Police wrote in its post.

According to officials, the fire destroyed over 400 huts, another 300 structures were saved due to the combined efforts of the police and the Delhi Fire Services. More than 28 fire tenders were pressed into service to bring the situation under control.

No injuries or casualties were reported. Residents were safely evacuated before the fire spread to nearby shops and houses. Firefighters continued cooling operations for several hours before the blaze was fully extinguished. **MP05T**

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Thursday refused to stay a blanket ban on processions, demonstrations and protests on the Delhi University campus but said it is of the clear opinion that such a ban cannot exist.

The court asked the university and Delhi Police to respond to a law student's petition against the prohibition.

"Since when has this order been operating? Let it operate for 10 more days," a bench of Chief Justice D K Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia said, underscoring that a balance has to be struck in the matter.

"Let replies be filed within a week" the bench ordered, listing the matter for hearing on March 25. The court also issued notices to the central government and two colleges under Delhi University in the matter.

The counsel for Delhi Uni-



versity said the proctor's decision was based on a prohibitory order issued by the Delhi Police against the assembly of five or more persons in the north campus area. During the hearing, the court questioned the police as well as the university on their decision to impose the restriction, stating that it was of a "clear opinion" that a blanket ban cannot exist.

It, however, called upon the students to "behave," remarking that they cannot misuse their liberty.

"This liberty can't be mis-

2020 riots: Court denies bail to Shahrukh Pathan

'No change in circumstances'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A court here on Thursday dismissed a bail application filed by Shahrukh Pathan, an accused in a case linked to the 2020 riots in north-east Delhi, saying there had been no change in circumstances since the Delhi High Court denied him relief last year.

Additional Sessions Judge Sameer Bajpai, who was hearing the regular bail application moved by Pathan, said he cannot be granted bail because of his incarceration for the last six years.

"This court is of the view that when the high court declined bail to the applicant/accused on October 22, 2024, and the circumstances have not changed, except the fact that almost one-and-a-half years have passed, this court should not grant bail to him even now," the order said.

Pathan, who has been in judicial custody since March 3, 2020, is facing trial in a case registered at the Jafrabad police station under several IPC provisions, including attempt to murder and charges related to rioting, assault on public servants, and offences under the Arms Act.

Presently lodged in Tihar



Jail, Pathan is also accused of pointing a pistol at a constable during the riots in 2020.

The court noted that the accused had already spent more than six years in custody and had completed over half of the maximum possible sentence of 10 years prescribed for the offence under Section 307 of the IPC.

"The record shows that although initially it took a considerable time to examine the complainant and other witnesses, most of the time, the delay has been caused on the part of the accused persons only, especially the present applicant (Pathan)," the judge said. The court noted delays were caused by the accused's conduct and absence of his counsel. With prosecution evidence still underway, it found no change in circumstances and rejected bail. The accused was arrested in March 2020 in connection with the 2020 northeast Delhi riots.

STP site collapse in Gurugram raises accountability questions

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GURUGRAM: The death of seven construction workers after a wall collapsed at a STP site in Gurugram has raised serious questions about accountability and whether those ultimately responsible for the tragedy will face action.

The incident occurred earlier this week at a construction site in Sidhravali village, where labourers were working on an under-construction STP linked to a residential project by real estate developer Signature

Global. According to police and eyewitness accounts, about 15–20 labourers were present when a massive wall collapsed, triggering a soil cave-in that buried workers under debris and iron rods. Seven workers died and several others were injured. Most of the labourers were migrant workers, many from Nepal, who were staying in labour camps near the site.

Recalling the moment of the collapse, an injured worker said the accident happened suddenly. "The lights went out and it became pitch dark. We

started running when iron rods fell from above," he said while undergoing treatment at a hospital in Bhiwadi.

Following the incident, an FIR was registered at Bilaspur police station against the developer, the contractor and several site officials over alleged safety lapses. Two site-level officials, including a project manager and a structural engineer, have been detained.

Labour groups warn of systemic negligence as families question whether accountability will extend beyond site staff.

BSF jawan's 12-yr-old daughter kidnapped outside society gate

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The 12-year-old daughter of a Border Security Force (BSF) personnel was allegedly kidnapped from outside her residential society in Delhi's Rohini on Thursday, an official said.

The girl had left for school in the morning and was returning home when she allegedly went missing from outside the gate of her residential society in Rohini's Sector 28, he said.

Family members said the girl was on her way home when she disappeared from outside the society gate.

When she did not return,



the family began searching for her in the neighbourhood but failed to trace her.

A case has been registered under relevant sections in this connection and a probe has been initiated, police said, adding that CCTV footage from nearby

“A case has been registered under relevant sections in this connection and a probe has been initiated”

areas is being scanned and teams have been deployed to trace the minor.

"The matter is under investigation and all possible angles are being examined. Efforts are on to locate the child at the earliest," a senior police officer said.

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

GURUGRAM: Gurugram Police have arrested a 66-year-old shopkeeper for allegedly supplying the acid-based toilet cleaner used in an attack on a 30-year-old woman outside Civil Hospital in Sector 10 earlier this week.

Police said the victim had reached the hospital on March 8 after being assaulted by a man she lived with. While there, a woman allegedly threw a corrosive liquid at her, burning her clothes.

Investigators later arrested Sakshi (25) of Rewari, who told police she had intended to target her husband's friend Meenakshi but mistakenly identified the victim by the colour of her scarf.

Further investigation led to the arrest of Lajpat Rai Sharma (66), a grocery shop owner in Sector 5, who allegedly sold the cleaner to Sakshi. Police also seized chemical liquids from a Sadar Bazar-based firm for alleged storage and repackaging without proper licence. The probe is ongoing.

DUST-FREE DELHI DRIVE

MCD clears 149 tonnes of waste

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi carried out a night-time sanitation drive in the Karol Bagh zone as part of its ongoing 10-day "Dust-Free Delhi" campaign, removing large quantities of legacy waste from railway tracks. Officials said the cleaning operation was conducted along the railway track near Naraina Vihar railway track, where sanitation teams undertook intensive waste removal to improve environmental conditions and prevent dust pollution in the surrounding areas.

Deputy Commissioner Dilkhus Meena said around 149 metric tonnes of legacy



waste were lifted during the night operation. He added that a total of 228 metric tonnes of waste has been cleared from railway tracks across the zone so far under the special drive.

The civic body also carried out removal of construction and demolition (C&D) waste from various wards. According to officials, nearly 48 metric tonnes of debris were cleared on March 11 using zonal resources, taking the

total to 273 metric tonnes over the last five days.

In addition, about 201 metric tonnes of C&D waste were lifted by an agency hired by the civic body from designated collection points on the same day. This has taken the total quantity of such waste removed to around 550 metric tonnes during the past five days.

Officials said the drive is part of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi's broader efforts to improve sanitation, remove accumulated waste and control dust pollution. Similar campaigns will continue across zones with stricter monitoring to ensure cleaner surroundings and improved environmental conditions.

CM ENCOURAGES WOMEN GRADUATES TO LEAD CHANGE

‘Daughters are architects of tomorrow’: CM Gupta at IGDTUW’s 8th convocation

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Calling young women the “architects of tomorrow,” Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday urged graduating students of Indira Gandhi Delhi Technical University for Women (IGDTUW) to use their knowledge and technical skills to shape the nation’s future. Addressing the university’s 8th convocation ceremony, she said women empowered with education and innovation will play a defining role in building a developed India.

Congratulating the graduating students, Gupta said a convocation is not merely the end of academic life but the beginning of a new journey filled with opportunities and responsibilities. Encouraging the students to move forward with confidence and curiosity, she said, “Daughters are not just degree holders, they are the architects of tomorrow.”

The Chief Minister said the



1,181 graduating students were stepping into a new phase of life as future leaders, innovators and change-makers. “Empowered by technical education, women will shape the nation’s future,” she said, urging the students to apply their learning for the greater good of society and the country.

Highlighting India’s growth focus on innovation and

entrepreneurship, Gupta said initiatives under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi such as Digital India, Atmanirbhar Bharat, Startup India and Skill India have opened new avenues for young people. She noted that institutions like IGDTUW are playing a key role in preparing women for leadership in technology, science, architecture

HIGHLIGHTS

» Congratulating the graduating students, Gupta said a convocation is not merely the end of academic life but the beginning of a new journey filled with opportunities and responsibilities

» Encouraging the students to move forward with confidence and curiosity, she said, ‘Daughters are not just degree holders, they are the architects of tomorrow’

and management.

Emphasising the concept of women-led development, Gupta said women today are not just participants in development but are increasingly leading change across sectors. She added that when women are empowered through education, skills and technology, it brings transformative progress not only to individuals but also

to society and the nation.

Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood, who was also present at the ceremony, said the convocation symbolised the growing role of women in shaping India’s future. “Women’s participation is the greatest strength of the country in Amrit Kaal,” he said.

Sood added that the graduating students were not only receiving degrees but also taking on the responsibility of contributing to society. He expressed confidence that their knowledge and determination would play an important role in building a developed Delhi and a developed India. During the ceremony, the university awarded a total of 1,181 degrees, including 938 undergraduate, 212 postgraduate and 31 PhD degrees. The university also conferred two Chancellor’s Medals, 15 Vice-Chancellor’s Medals and 26 awards for academic excellence in recognition of outstanding academic achievements and leadership.

Capital’s peak power demand set to cross 9,000 MW: SLDC

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi’s peak power demand is expected to cross the 9,000 MW mark this summer, marking another sharp rise in electricity consumption in the national capital. According to estimates by the State Load Dispatch Centre (SLDC), the city’s peak demand had reached 8,442 MW last year and is projected to exceed 9,000 MW in 2026.

Power distribution companies of the BSES have said they are fully prepared to meet the increased demand and ensure uninterrupted electricity supply to more than 53 lakh consumers and nearly 2.25 crore residents across South, West, East and Central Delhi.

Officials said that about 2,670 MW of green power from multiple renewable sources will support electricity supply during the summer months. “Around 2,670 MW of green power will play a key role in ensuring reliable electricity supply during the summer months in BSES areas,” a BSES official said.

Solar energy is expected to contribute around 840 MW,



“Around 2,670 MW of green power will play a key role in ensuring reliable electricity supply”

hydro power about 572 MW and wind power nearly 500 MW. In addition, pumped storage plants will supply around 312 MW, while rooftop solar installations across various parts of Delhi will contribute nearly 250 MW. Hybrid renewable sources will add about 137 MW and waste-to-energy plants around 41 MW. The 20 MW Battery Energy Storage System at Kilokri will also support grid stability during peak demand periods.

Officials said the power distribution companies have strengthened their network through extensive predic-

tive and preventive checks ahead of the summer season. “Extensive predictive and preventive checks, including thermo-scanning, are being conducted to identify potential hot-spots in the network,” the official said.

The discoms have also made power banking arrangements with utilities in other states to meet peak demand. Agreements have been finalised with electricity utilities in Kerala, Chhattisgarh, Manipur and Mumbai, which could provide up to around 470 MW support during high-demand periods.

To manage fluctuations in renewable energy and ensure grid stability, BSES has started using the real-time market on power exchanges. “We are actively utilising the Real Time Market on the power exchanges to balance renewable supply and maintain grid stability,” the official said.

Officials added that with the current growth trend, Delhi’s peak power demand could cross the 10,000 MW mark by 2028–29, depending on weather conditions and rising electricity consumption.

Govt, NGOs must work together to eradicate begging: Min Singh

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indraj Singh on Thursday stressed the need for coordinated efforts between the government and civil society organisations to eliminate begging and rehabilitate vulnerable individuals, while reviewing the implementation of the SMILE Scheme at the Delhi Secretariat. Chairing a review meeting with NGOs working under the scheme, Singh said, “Joint efforts of the government and social organizations are necessary for the eradication of begging.” The meeting focused on assessing rehabilitation work, connecting individuals involved in begging with livelihood opportunities, and integrating them into mainstream society.

During the meeting, several organisations presented detailed reports on their fieldwork. They informed the minister that surveys conducted across different parts of the capital had identified hundreds of individuals engaged in begging. Many of them were pro-



vided counselling and shifted to shelter homes, while efforts were made to link them with employment and self-employment opportunities.

NGOs also shared that beneficiaries were being connected with multiple government welfare schemes. These included facilitating Aadhaar cards, opening bank accounts, enrolling individuals in insurance programmes, registering street vendors with the Municipal Corporation, and assisting them in applying for ration cards. Steps were also taken to enrol children in schools and Anganwadi centres and to provide skill development training to women. Singh said the SMILE initiative was aimed

at ensuring a dignified life for destitute individuals. “The government expects all organisations to work with honesty and dedication so that assistance reaches the truly needy,” he said, adding that transparency and accountability would be ensured in the programme.

He also noted that the work carried out by NGOs would be regularly reviewed and verified. “Officials may conduct surprise inspections whenever required,” he said. The minister said begging affects India’s global image, especially for tourists. He added that rehabilitation efforts would also focus on the transgender community to ensure dignified livelihood opportunities.

Delhi govt directs departments to spare BLOs from add’l duties

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Thursday directed officials not to assign additional work to staff deployed as booth-level officers for the special intensive revision of electoral rolls, and stressed the need to complete the exercise on time. A circular issued by the Department of Social Welfare directed all district social welfare officers and heads of institutions to ensure that officials deployed as BLOs perform their election-related duties daily after office or school hours.

The circular said that the direction follows communication from the Election Commission authorities regarding preparatory work for the special intensive revision of electoral rolls expected to begin in April this year.

The preparatory phase includes verification and mapping of electoral rolls, which officials described as a crucial exercise ahead of the revision.

“The officials assigned as BLOs should not be burdened with any additional work after

KEY POINTS

» The direction follows communication from the Election Commission authorities regarding prep work for the SIR of electoral rolls expected to begin in April this yr

» The preparatory phase includes verification and mapping of electoral rolls, which officials described as a crucial exercise ahead of the revision

office hours so that election-related duties are carried out without disruption and in strict compliance with guidelines,” the circular said.

Meanwhile, the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) has also written to the Delhi government seeking exemption for around 7,500 school teachers deployed as BLOs from Census-related duties.

In a communication to the divisional commissioner, the CEO’s office said the Election Commission of India had

informed that the SIR of electoral rolls is expected to begin from April this year, and preparatory work for the exercise needs to be completed at the earliest.

As part of the preparation, mapping of electors in the last year’s electoral roll with records from 2002 is currently underway. Officials said this is a crucial step before the start of the revision process and needs to be completed in a time-bound manner.

At the same time, Census-related work is also likely to begin in the national capital shortly. Officials said the Delhi government is preparing for the house-listing and housing phase of Census 2027, which is scheduled to begin from April 15. Over 40,000 employees are expected to undergo field training for the Census exercise in the coming days, officials said.

A senior official said the house-listing phase is expected to conclude by June and cover the entire Capital. Delhi has 13,033 polling stations and around 7,500 teachers deployed as BLOs and supervisors.

Delhi govt to work on denotification of nomadic communities

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government is working towards recognising and promoting Denotified, Nomadic and Semi-Nomadic communities and will organise a grand programme on April 8 to mark World Banjara Day, Tourism Minister Kapil Mishra said on Thursday.

Mishra has met a delegation of the Banjara Vimukt Ghumantu Kalyan Sangh, Delhi Pradesh, at the Delhi Secretariat, according to a statement.

The minister said the event will highlight the history, culture and contribution of the Banjara community and introduce the younger generation to its rich legacy. “The Banjara community has played an important role in the history, culture and trading traditions of India. At a time when modern transport systems were not developed, the community helped supply essential goods to different parts of the country, strengthening trade and social life,” he said.

The minister said the Delhi government aims to showcase the community’s cultural heritage and folk traditions through the programme and provide a platform to recognise its contribution to nation-building.

Mishra also said that for the first time in Delhi, serious efforts are being made under the leadership of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta to promote Denotified, Nomadic and Semi-Nomadic communities.

MCD extends CGHS-rate medical treatment to councillors, families

NEW DELHI: The Municipal Corporation of Delhi has extended the facility of medical treatment at Central Government Health Scheme rates to its sitting councillors and their eligible dependents in empanelled private healthcare institutions.

Announcing the decision, Raja Iqbal Singh said the initiative aims to strengthen healthcare support for elected representatives who remain actively engaged in addressing civic issues across the Capital.

Under the new provision, councillors will be able to avail medical consultations, diagnostic tests and treatment

at CGHS-approved rates in empanelled private hospitals, eye centres, dental clinics and diagnostic laboratories. The facility will also extend to their eligible dependents, enabling them to access healthcare services at regulated and affordable rates.

Singh said councillors perform an important role in resolving local civic concerns and maintaining constant engagement with residents. “Ensuring reliable and affordable medical care for councillors and their families is an important step toward supporting their well-being,” he said.

Officials said the move

would streamline the process of availing medical services through recognised healthcare providers and ensure access to standardised treatment costs in private institutions.

The Mayor added that the civic body remains committed to improving welfare measures for its elected representatives and employees. Officials said the move aims to strengthen institutional support while ensuring councillors receive timely medical care. The MCD said CGHS-rate treatment will help councillors and their families access quality healthcare through empanelled providers.

MP05T

Sirsa chairs meeting with experts to discuss city’s air pollution mitigation plan for ‘26-27

NEW DELHI: Delhi Environment Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa on Thursday chaired a meeting with environment experts, researchers and senior officials from various government departments to discuss strategies and suggestions to be incorporated in the Delhi government’s comprehensive air pollution mitigation plan for 2026-27.

“We are focusing on major pollution sources through targeted actions in every area,” Sirsa said, emphasising on a balanced approach across transport, industry, waste management, dust control, and community awareness.



The meeting reviewed pollution from various sources, prioritising solutions that tackle issues at the root, in which transport has emerged as a key area, officials said.

“Our government is committed to demonstrating strong action on vehicles to reduce emissions effectively, while

improving options for public transport,” Sirsa said.

Officials said deliberations also focused on industry practices, waste burning, and construction activities, with extensive discussion on scrapping facilities, charging infrastructure for electric vehicles, and better waste handling.

The meeting was attended by experts from the Council on Energy, Environment and Water (CEEW), Envirocatalysts, Climate Trends, and other institutions, besides officials from the Delhi State Industrial and Infrastructure Development Corporation (DSIIDC), transport and environment

departments. “Many of the expert suggestions align closely with our ongoing policies and implementation plans, several are already advancing through pilots, studies, and ground-level actions. For those needing further research, we are prioritising rigorous assessments to ensure their effectiveness, while comprehensively tackling air pollution so its impact can be measured, and seen in the coming times,” Sirsa said. Officials stressed stronger compliance monitoring. Experts proposed congestion pricing, staggered institutional timings, construction planning, and better EV charging networks.

MP05T

WATER SUPPLY TO BE MONITORED THROUGH GPS AND MOBILE APP

CM Rekha Gupta reviews ‘Summer Action Plan 2026’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has stepped up preparations to tackle the rising demand for water during the summer months, with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday reviewing the ‘Summer Action Plan 2026’ aimed at ensuring uninterrupted water supply across the national capital.

Chairing a high-level meeting at the Delhi Secretariat, Gupta said the plan focuses on strengthening supply systems, improving monitoring mechanisms and ensuring swift response to complaints.

The meeting was attended by Water Minister Parvesh



Sahib Singh, Chief Secretary Rajiv Verma and Delhi Jal Board CEO Kaushal Raj Sharma, among other senior officials.

Officials informed the meeting that Delhi, with a

population of around 2.5 crore, requires nearly 1,250 million gallons of water per day (MGD) as per standard norms, while the city currently receives about 1,000 MGD. The Summer Action

Under the plan, max production will be ensured at water treatment plants, while underground, surface reservoirs have been cleaned and pumping stations repaired

Plan has been designed to manage this gap more efficiently during peak demand.

Gupta said the government has taken several preventive measures to avoid supply disruptions. “Water demand in

the city rises significantly during the summer months, while overall production remains almost the same. Keeping this in mind, the government has prepared the ‘Summer Action Plan-2026’ to ensure adequate water supply across Delhi,” she said.

Under the plan, maximum production will be ensured at water treatment plants, while underground and surface reservoirs have been cleaned and pumping stations repaired. Pipeline leakages are also being monitored and fixed.

To address shortages in some areas, the tanker system has been strengthened. The Delhi Jal Board has deployed 168 departmental tankers and

819 hired tankers, with plans to hire around 200 additional tankers if required.

Gupta said tanker operations will now be monitored digitally. “Water supply to be monitored through GPS and mobile app; strict watch will be kept to curb leakages,” she said.

The chief minister added that grievance redressal systems have also been strengthened. “A 24x7 helpline and 28 emergency centres have been set up to ensure water reaches every household,” she said.

Authorities are also increasing water quality monitoring, with around 1,600–1,700 samples being tested daily across treatment plants and zonal laboratories.

Sanjay Singh alleges attack on party councillor

NEW DELHI: AAP MP Sanjay Singh on Thursday alleged that a party councillor and a worker were assaulted in west Delhi and demanded that police register an FIR and take action against those responsible.

At a press conference, Singh said the incident occurred on Wednesday when councillor Jyoti Gautam visited her ward to inspect road work along with party worker Sanjay Bhairava in the Rajendra Nagar constituency.

He alleged that individuals linked to BJP MLA Umang Bajaj attacked the worker and misbehaved with the councillor. There was no immediate response from the BJP.

MP05T

STATES TOLD TO MONITOR BLACK MARKETERS, HOARDERS

PM hits out at those creating panic on LPG

MPOST BUREAU

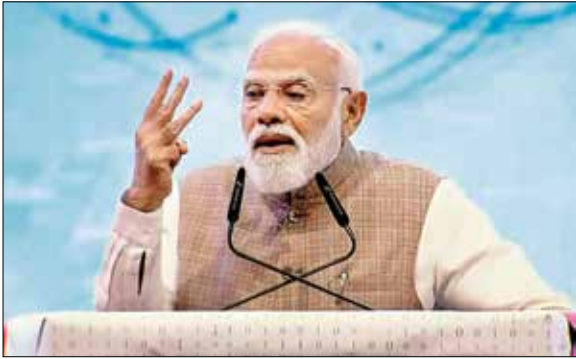
NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday hit out at those trying to create panic on the LPG situation in India, and said they are not only exposing themselves before the people but also hurting the country.

Addressing the NXT Summit here, Modi also said that due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia, no nation has remained unaffected, but India is fully committed to addressing this challenge and is leaving no stone unturned to safeguard its energy security.

He also said that some people are trying to black-market certain products by taking advantage of the present situation, and warned that action will be taken against such unscrupulous elements.

“I request the state governments to enhance monitoring to stop black-marketers and hoarders in such times,” he said.

On the LPG issue, the prime



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addresses the NXT Summit at Bharat Mandapam, in New Delhi

Highlights

- » The PM said that due to the ongoing conflict in West Asia, no nation has remained unaffected, but India is leaving no stone unturned to safeguard its energy security
- » He also said that some people are trying to black-market certain products by taking advantage of the present situation

minister said there is currently a lot of discussion surrounding LPG, with some individuals “spreading unnecessary panic.” “I do not wish to make any political statements at this moment. Those who are causing alarm are not only exposing their own intentions to the public but also causing harm to the country,” Modi said.

The prime minister also said the government is actively working on multiple

fronts, and in the past few days, he spoke with the leaders of several countries about the developments in West Asia.

“We are making continuous efforts to overcome the obstacles in the supply chain,” he said, adding, “The government will make every effort to ensure that its farmers and citizens are protected from the burden of global challenges.”

The prime minister also said that everyone has a key role to

play in dealing with the present crisis arising out of the conflict in West Asia – be it political parties, media, youth, cities or villages.

He said everyone is well aware that global circumstances can change abruptly, as people have seen in recent years – be it the onset of the Covid-19 pandemic, the Russia-Ukraine crisis, and now the escalation of a major conflict closer to home. “This war has driven the

world into a significant energy crisis. In such challenging times, our response is crucial. Difficult periods serve as a test for any nation. We must address these circumstances with patience and a commitment to peace,” Modi said.

He added that despite many global crises, world leaders and experts look to India with great hope, which raises India’s responsibilities too.

“The entire world knows today that if you want to be part of the future, you must connect with and be in India,” Modi said.

The prime minister also said that there is one goal, one destination, which is a developed India, and the country is not just progressing, it is moving to the next level.

The world is passing through a difficult phase, but India is moving ahead at a fast and steady pace, he said.

“Several global leaders are saying that India is becoming the centre of gravity for the entire world,” Modi said.

FLIGHTS GRADUALLY RESUME

Civil Aviation ministry ‘closely monitoring’ situation in West Asia

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Ministry of Civil Aviation is closely monitoring the situation in West Asia and its impact on flights operating between India and several countries in the region, officials said on Thursday.

In view of the prevailing developments, Indian airlines have begun taking steps to gradually resume services to and from key destinations in West Asia. According to officials, flight services between India and Riyadh resumed on March 12.

On the first day of the resumption of services from Riyadh to India, three flights were scheduled to operate to Mumbai by Air India and IndiGo. In addition, Air India Express operated a flight from Riyadh to Kozhikode.

Official sources said that between February 28 and March 11, a total of 1,50,457 passengers travelled from Gulf countries to India amid



REPRESENTATIVE PIC

Flight services between India and Riyadh resumed on March 12

the evolving situation in the region.

For March 12, Indian carriers have scheduled 57 flights from several West Asian destinations, including Abu Dhabi, Dubai, Fujairah, Jeddah, Muscat, Ras Al Khaimah, Riyadh and Sharjah. However, officials said the operation of these flights will depend on operational feasibility and prevailing conditions.

The ministry said it is

maintaining close coordination with airlines to ensure smooth passenger movement and minimise disruptions to travel plans. Authorities are also keeping a close watch on airfares to ensure that ticket prices remain reasonable for travellers.

Passengers have been advised to stay in touch with their respective airlines for the latest updates regarding flight schedules and travel arrangements.

Officials said the government is continuously reviewing the situation and will issue further updates as necessary to ensure safe and efficient air travel between India and the West Asian region.

From Page 1

Iran

was nothing more than a lie,” he said.

The Iranian leader vowed to avenge those killed in the war and claimed that Iran would “obtain compensation” from its enemy. He said that if it refuses to do so, Iran will “take from its assets” or destroy them to the same extent.

“A limited amount of this revenge has so far taken concrete form, but until it is fully achieved, this case will remain among our priorities,” he said.

On His Father Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, he said that Iran will never retreat and will resist with “full force” and will avenge not just the late Ayatollah Ali Khamenei but every citizen who lost their life in the war.

Tehran also outlined the three conditions for ending Iran’s ongoing conflict with the United States and Israel. Laying out the terms, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian said any resolution must recognise Iran’s legitimate rights and guarantee that the country will not face future attacks.

In a post on social media platform X, Pezeshkian also demanded compensation for damages incurred during the war.

“Talking to leaders of Russia and Pakistan, I reaffirmed Iran’s commitment to peace in the region. The only way to end this war-ignited by the Zionist regime and US- is recognising Iran’s legitimate rights, payment of reparations, and firm international guarantees against future aggression,” he wrote.

The Iranian President’s offer for a truce came after Abolfazl Shekarchi, spokesperson for Iran’s armed forces, told state-run IRIB TV that no port, economic centre or location in the Persian Gulf would be beyond Iran’s reach if Washington attacked Iranian port facilities.

“If our ports and docks are threatened, all ports and docks in the region will be our legitimate targets,” armed forces spokesman Abolfazl Shekarchi said, according to state TV.

He warned that the armed forces “will carry out a heavier operation than what we have done so far” if Iranian ports were to come under attack.

Iran’s unrelenting attacks on shipping traffic and energy infrastructure in the Persian Gulf pushed oil back above USD 100 a barrel on Thursday, as American and Israeli strikes pounded the Islamic Republic with no sign of an end to the war in sight.

Iran is trying to inflict enough global economic pain to pressure the United States and Israel to halt their bombardment, which started the war on February 28.

Iran’s president said its attacks would continue until Iran gets security guarantees against another assault, indicating that even a ceasefire or US declaration of victory might not halt the conflict.

US President Donald Trump, speaking at a Wednesday event in Kentucky, promised to “finish the job,” even though he claimed Iran is “virtually destroyed.”

Iran hit a container ship off the coast of Dubai, caused a blaze near Bahrain’s international airport, targeted a major Saudi oil field with a drone and forced Iraq to halt operations at all of its oil terminals after attacking its port of Basra on the

Persian Gulf.

With the latest attacks, Iran flouted a UN Security Council resolution from the previous day demanding that it halt strikes on its Gulf neighbours, with new attacks also reported in Kuwait and the United Arab Emirates.

Sirens wailed after midnight in Jerusalem as Israel intercepted incoming Iranian missiles, and loud booms were heard later in the day in another attack on the city, while Iran-backed Hezbollah militants launched some 200 rockets from Lebanon at the country’s north.

Israel responded with what the military described as a “wide-scale wave of strikes” on Tehran and in Lebanon, where 11 people were killed in two early morning strikes.

No fuel worry, Puri tells LS

“This is a historic moment in modern energy history... Despite India’s non-involvement in the conflict, we must navigate its repercussions,” he stated.

Puri reassured that India’s crude oil supply remains comfortable, with imports now exceeding volumes previously passing through Hormuz thanks to alternative routes. Before the crisis, 45 per cent of India’s crude imports came via the strait; now, over 70 per cent are sourced from other regions. He credited sustained diplomatic efforts and a long-term diversification policy that has expanded India’s sourcing from around 40 countries, compared to 27 in 2006-07.

Refineries are operating at high capacity, some even above 100 per cent, with no shortages of petrol, diesel, aviation fuel, kerosene, or fuel oil. Retail outlets across the country are fully stocked, and supply chains remain smooth. For natural gas, domestic production of about 90 MMSCMD is complemented by imports and alternative procurement, especially after supplies from a Gulf facility were affected.

A recent Natural Gas Control Order issued on March 9 places high priority on ensuring that households and transportation sectors have an uninterrupted supply of piped gas and CNG. Meanwhile, the industrial and fertiliser sectors are receiving regulated but sufficient allocations. Puri expressed confidence, stating, “I am pleased to report that shortages have been largely offset through alternative sourcing. India’s gas production and supply arrangements are resilient enough to withstand prolonged conflict,” assuring that power for homes and industries remains secure.

Addressing fears about cooking gas shortages, Puri highlighted that India, which once imported nearly 60 per cent of its LPG from Gulf countries, has diversified its sources to include the United States, Norway, Canada, Algeria, and Russia. In just five days, refineries increased LPG production by 28 per cent, emphasising a focus on domestic output.

“Our top priority is that no household—especially India’s 33 crore families—faces LPG shortages. Domestic supply is fully protected, and delivery schedules are unchanged,” he emphasised.

Commercial LPG supply is carefully managed, with a coordination committee of oil marketing companies working with state governments to prioritise genuine users.

Puri further announced that the supply of commercial cylinders will begin from Thursday, while addressing the Lok Sabha.

Puri also cautioned against panic buying, noting that demand spikes are driven more by anxiety than actual shortages, based on field reports. To curb hoarding and diversion, measures such as stricter delivery checks, minimum booking gaps, and enforcement actions have been put in place.

To ease LPG pressure, the government has temporarily authorised alternative fuels like kerosene, biomass, RDF pellets, and coal for specific sectors. Additional kerosene has been allocated through the public distribution system.

Despite volatile international LPG prices, consumer prices have remained stable, thanks to government absorption of much of the cost increase. “For a PMUY household, the additional expense is less than 80 paise per day,” Puri stated, noting that oil marketing companies are compensated to maintain steady retail prices.

State governments are vigilantly monitoring supplies, conducting anti-diversion raids, and ensuring smooth distribution. “This is not a moment for rumours. India is facing the most severe global energy disruption in history. Crude oil flows are steady, gas is prioritised for homes and farms, LPG production is up, and prices are protected,” Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said, urging citizens to avoid panic and conserve fuel. She further stressed while addressing press persons here in the national capital that despite the crisis, India’s crude oil supply remains stable. Thanks to proactive government efforts, nearly 70 per cent of imports now arrive through alternative routes.

MEA

security, although officials noted it’s too early to disclose further details.

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal highlighted that around 9,000 Indian citizens—students, seafarers, businesspeople, and pilgrims—are in Iran. Many recent advisories prompted a significant number of Indians, including students, to leave Iran, while others have been relocated to safer areas within the country. Indians seeking to depart can travel by land to Azerbaijan and Armenia for commercial flights back home, as advised in the latest March 9 alert.

Addressing the press, Jaiswal covered various topics, including Iran’s current situation, the safety of Indian nationals, maritime travel through the Strait of Hormuz, and ongoing diplomatic efforts amidst West Asia’s volatile environment.

On diplomatic fronts, the official confirmed that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has been actively engaging with Gulf leaders and others in response to recent escalations. “All these conversations underscore the importance of dialogue, the need to prevent harm to innocent people, respect sovereignty, and ensure the security of Indians abroad,” he emphasised. The MEA also stated that India maintains steady diplomatic contact with Iran, citing multiple recent exchanges between the foreign ministers of both nations.

Regarding recent discussions with Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov, the spokesperson stated that the details have already been shared, affirming that several global

issues were on the agenda.

The impact of the ongoing conflict on regional initiatives, such as the India-Middle East-Europe corridor announced in 2023, was also touched upon. While acknowledging that global stability has been affected, the MEA chose not to comment further.

Jaiswal also noted that Bangladesh has requested diesel supplies from India, which has been ongoing since 2017 through rail, waterways, and the India-Bangladesh Friendship Pipeline, per existing agreements. Other nations, including Sri Lanka, have also expressed energy needs that India has considered carefully.

India’s stance at the United Nations remains clear: prioritising civilian safety, promoting dialogue, voicing concern over escalation, and respecting sovereignty remain central to its position.

Addressing rumours about the condolence book at the Iranian Embassy, the spokesperson affirmed that it was signed by the Foreign Secretary on March 5, the first day it was available, countering incorrect claims circulating publicly.

On the topic of Iranian vessels in India, the MEA referenced a statement by the External Affairs Minister in Parliament on March 9. Iran requested docking for three vessels on February 28. While IRIS Lavan arrived on March 4, the vessels are currently at Indian naval facilities in Kochi. Further updates are expected soon.

Regarding reports of countries sending military vessels to escort tankers, the MEA stated, “We are monitoring the situation and will respond appropriately.” When asked about Gulf airspace disruptions affecting flights, the spokesperson clarified, “There has been no discussion with Pakistan about opening airspace.”

Finally, the MEA emphasised that, although direct talks between the Indian leadership and Iran’s President haven’t occurred recently, communication remains open. The External Affairs Minister has spoken multiple times with his Iranian counterpart, and the Foreign Secretary has maintained contact as well.

Retail inflation

for an extended period. As per ICRA’s analysis, every 10 per cent increase in average crude oil prices increases the CPI inflation by 40-60 bps, assuming that a full transition into retail selling prices (RSPs) of auto fuels takes place.

“Heightened uncertainty transmitting from geopolitics into India’s growth and inflation outlook supports the case for a (interest rate cut) pause in the upcoming April 2026 Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) meeting,” Nayar said.

The next meeting of the MPC is scheduled for April 6-8.

Vivek Rathi, National Director-Research, Knight Frank India, said that CPI inflation reflects a mix of statistical adjustments and underlying price pressures.

“The revision of the CPI base year and the reduced weight of the food basket have altered the composition of the headline print. Meanwhile, firm price pressures in non-food and fuel categories, alongside rising precious metal prices, have contributed to inflation,” Rathi said.

The NSO data further showed that highest inflation was in Telangana at 5.02 per cent and lowest in Mizoram at 0.1 per cent.

NSO said that the real-time price data were collected from selected 1,407 urban markets (including online platforms) and 1,465 villages.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Om Birla

Birla said MPs always must remember that disagreements and intense exchanges of ideas are natural in parliamentary debate but there is a clear line between democratic discourse and disorder. “Waving placards, shouting slogans, tearing papers, or climbing on desks are contrary to our great parliamentary traditions. Such behaviour not only disrupts proceedings but also diminishes the prestige of the House,” he said, adding whether there is praise or criticism, his resolve remains the same: to protect the dignity of the House and uphold its rules.

Referring to remarks by some members that the Leader of the Opposition (Rahul Gandhi) was disallowed to table a magazine article based on the unpublished memoir of former Army chief M M Naravane on the India-China conflict of 2020, Birla cited rulings by past speakers when members were not allowed to table documents by the Chair.

The speaker said some members believe that the LoP may rise at any time and speak on any subject of their choosing, they consider this to be a special privilege.

“Whenever the prime minister or any minister wishes to make a statement in the House, prior permission of the speaker is required. No member in this House possesses any privilege to speak outside the framework of these rules,” he said and cited a few past examples when chair did not allow to lay photographs, government documents and quote letters in the House.

Therefore, he said, while MPs indeed enjoy freedom of speech in Parliament, it is subject to the rules and procedures approved by the House.

“I have always endeavoured to conduct the proceedings of the House with impartiality, discipline, balance, and in accordance with the rules. The primary responsibility of the speaker is to maintain harmony, order, and efficiency in the House while carrying everyone together. My constant effort has been to ensure that the dignity, decorum, and prestige of the House continue to grow,” he said.

Birla said he has always maintained cordial personal relations with members across party lines and never wishes for any action to be taken against any member.

“Whenever certain members behave in a manner contrary to the decorum of the House, I am compelled to take strict decisions in order to preserve the dignity of this institution,” he said.

He added that whenever disciplinary action becomes necessary to maintain order in the House, “it causes me deep sadness.”

Referring to concerns expressed by some MPs during the two-day debate regarding respect for women MPs, Birla said he has always held the highest respect for all women members.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

MPs vs CEC

lawmakers came forward to sign the notice on Thursday as well, even as the requisite numbers had already been achieved.

According to rules, at least 100

MPs must sign a notice seeking the removal of the CEC in the Lok Sabha, and the required strength in the Rajya Sabha is 50.

The notice has been signed by members from all INDIA bloc parties, the source said. MPs from the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), which is no longer officially part of the bloc, have also signed the notice, another source said.

This is the first time a notice has been given seeking the removal of the CEC.

According to a highly placed source, seven charges are listed against the CEC in the notice, ranging from “partisan and discriminatory conduct in office” to “deliberate obstruction of investigation of electoral fraud” and “mass disenfranchisement.”

Opposition parties have accused the CEC of aiding the ruling BJP on several occasions, especially with the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR), which they have alleged is aimed at helping the party at the Centre.

Concerns have especially been expressed over the conduct of the SIR in West Bengal, with Trinamool Congress (TMC) supremo and Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee accusing the poll panel of deleting genuine voters.

The process for removing the CEC is similar to that for the removal of a Supreme Court or a high court judge, meaning an impeachment can be effected only on the ground of proven misbehaviour or incapacity.

A motion for removal may be introduced in either House of Parliament and must be passed by a special majority -- a majority of the total membership of the House and a two-thirds majority of the members present and voting.

According to the law on the appointment of CEC and election commissioners, “CEC shall not be removed from his office except in the like manner and on the like grounds as a judge of the Supreme Court,” and the other election commissioners shall not be removed from office “except on the recommendation of the CEC.”

According to the Judges (Inquiry) Act, 1968, if the notices for the motion are given on the same day in both Houses of Parliament, no committee shall be constituted unless the motion has been admitted in both Houses.

After the motion has been admitted in both Houses, a committee shall be constituted jointly by the speaker and the chairman.

WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Panic: Fuel

them politically at this time. But I will definitely say that by doing so, they are not only exposing themselves to the public but also causing significant harm to the country,” PM Modi said on LPG crisis.

He said that no country is untouched by the impact of this global crisis brought on by war, adding that his government, too, is leaving no stone unturned to address this crisis. “I have had discussions with top leaders from several countries around the world regarding this issue. Continuous efforts are also underway to address the disruptions to the supply chain,” he said.

The Prime Minister said that promoting diverse energy sources has been a constant necessity for India’s rapid development. To strengthen this, the government has worked on two levels – first to develop infrastructure to increase

energy access in the country and secondly, to ensure that we do not have to depend solely on foreign countries for energy with emphasis was laid on self-reliance in the energy sector.

“Till 2014, there were only 14 crore LPG connections in the country. This means that only about half the families in the country had an LPG connection. Today, there are more than double that, i.e., around 33 crore domestic LPG connections. In the last 11 years, we have doubled our bottling capacity. Distribution centers have also increased from 13,000 to more than 25,000. In 2014, there were only four LNG terminals in the country, today their number has also doubled. The gas pipeline, which used to be about 3,500 kilometers, has been expanded to 10,000 kilometers. Since about 60 percent of LPG comes from abroad, the import terminal capacity at the country’s major ports has also been greatly increased,” PM Modi said.

Restaurant associations say commercial LG cylinder supply have stopped or become irregular over the past several days, raising concerns about the hospitality sector’s ability to continue operations.

The US-Israel attacks on Iran and Tehran’s retaliation have shut the Strait of Hormuz, a key sea route through which India gets 85-90 per cent of its LPG imports from West Asian nations, including Saudi Arabia and Qatar. The shutdown of Qatar’s LNG exports has rattled global gas markets.

On the procurement front, India has been steadily reducing its dependence on the Strait of Hormuz. Roughly 70% of crude oil imports now arrive via alternative routes, up from 55% previously — a shift that offers some buffer against regional disruptions.

The government said that consumers in rural India will be able to book LPG cylinders after 45 days, while consumers in urban India will be able to book after 25 days.

The government further asked consumers not to make bookings in a panic.

Addressing a question on the problems in booking LPG cylinders, Petroleum Ministry spokesperson Sujata Sharma said that some families are facing problems booking LPG cylinders as they are trying to book before the booking period of 25 days. She urged the consumers not to do any panic booking by paying heed to any rumour.

Eateries and quick-service restaurant chains, which rely heavily on commercial LPG cylinders to run kitchen operations, fear that restrictions on fuel supply to them could disrupt operations and drive input cost inflation.

Several eateries across the country have been forced to trim their operations.

The Tamil Nadu Hotels Association said small and medium-sized restaurants in the southern state were badly hit, with many iconic establishments in Chennai forced to stop serving fuel-intensive dishes such as dosas and fried rice to conserve their dwindling gas stocks.

A restaurant owner in Delhi said, “There is a shortage of cylinders. Even double the price, around Rs 1,500 to Rs 2,000, is not enough.” He added that his eatery requires at least three cylinders every day.

In West Bengal, officials said the “shortage” of cooking gas cylinders had begun to affect midday meals in schools across the state, forcing authorities to adopt alternative fuels such as firewood or serving limited food items to students.

GOVT, OPPN SLUG IT OUT ON FUEL SITUATION AMID WEST ASIA CRISIS

‘Epstein’ chants in LS as Rahul references Puri, raises concerns over ‘LPG crisis’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government on Thursday said there was no shortage of petrol, diesel, kerosene or aviation turbine fuel in India after the Opposition criticised it over the handling of the fallout of the West Asia crisis by citing instances of scarcity and panic buying across the country. Responding to concerns raised by Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi in the Lok Sabha, Union Petroleum Minister Hardeep Puri said it was the foremost priority of the government that the kitchens of over 33 crore families, especially the poor and the underprivileged, did not face any shortage of gas. Domestic supply was fully protected and the delivery cycle unchanged, he said. "There is no shortage of petrol, diesel, kerosene, aviation turbine fuel or fuel oil. The availability of petrol, diesel, aviation turbine fuel, kerosene, and fuel



Congress leaders stage a protest over LPG shortage at the Parliament complex, New Delhi, on Thursday

oil is fully assured," Puri said. He said retail outlets across the country were well stocked, supply chains were functioning normally. Gandhi alleged that the government "bartered" to the US India's right to determine its relationships with different oil suppliers due to a "compromise", adding that the war between the

US-Israel and Iran was going to have far-reaching consequences. "The central artery from where 20 per cent of global oil flows, the Strait of Hormuz, has been closed and this is going to have tremendous repercussions, particularly for us because a very large portion of our oil and natural gas comes through the Strait of Hormuz," Gandhi said.

Highlights

- » Gandhi alleged that the PM is panicked because of the Epstein files issue and the Adani Case in the US
- » Gandhi alleged that the government has "bartered" to the US India's right to determine its relationships with different oil suppliers due to a "compromise"

"The pain has just started -- restaurants are closing, there is widespread panic about LPG, street vendors are affected and, as I said, this is only the beginning," the former Congress president said. The foundation of every single nation is its energy security, Gandhi asserted. "I do not say this lightly, but allowing the US to decide who we buy oil, gas

from... whether we buy oil from Russia or not, whether our relationship with different oil suppliers can be decided by us, this is what has been bartered," the Congress leader said. Earlier, Gandhi triggered an uproar in the treasury benches by alleging that the fuel crisis had to do with Puri's friendship with deceased American financier Jeffrey Epstein. "This is a very puzzling fact as to why a nation the size of India would allow the president of any other nation to give us permission to buy Russian oil, to decide who our relationships are with," Gandhi said. "I have figured the puzzle out. The puzzle is about compromise. We have a gentleman sitting here who is the oil minister (Hardeep Puri), he himself has said that he is a friend of Mr Epstein," Gandhi said, adding, "I have a document which shows his (Puri's) daughter has received money from George Soros."

KOLKATA: The Election Commission is all set to significantly scale up the deployment of observers, security measures and technological monitoring mechanisms across the state to ensure that the upcoming assembly elections are conducted in a free, fair and intimidation-free manner. According to sources in the office of the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) in West Bengal, a proposal has been sent to the apex poll body seeking a sharp increase in the number of general, police and expenditure observers for the elections. During the 2021 Assembly polls, around 160 general observers were deployed across the state. However, officials said the number could increase substantially this time. "We have proposed at least one general observer for every Assembly constituency, and in some constituencies we have recommended more than one observer. We hope the Commission will approve the proposal," a senior official in the CEO office said.

Highlights

- » The number of police observers is also expected to rise significantly.
- » In the last Assembly elections, 37 police observers were deployed across West Bengal.

The number of police observers is also expected to rise significantly. In the last Assembly elections, 37 police observers were deployed across West Bengal. This time, the Commission is planning a much larger deployment, particularly in sensitive districts, where more than one police observer will be assigned to oversee security arrangements. Similarly, the number of expenditure observers, who monitor election spending and financial irregularities, is also likely to increase. In the 2021 Assembly polls, 84 expenditure

observers were deployed. While the Commission has not yet finalised the exact number for the upcoming elections but the number will go upto at least 100. Meanwhile, the Commission has already begun deploying Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) across the state ahead of the polls. Around 480 companies of central forces have been deployed to maintain law and order and ensure peaceful polling. A significant number of these personnel have already been stationed in various districts, and more contingents are expected to arrive once the election schedule is formally announced. Technology will also play a key role in the monitoring process. The Commission has decided to introduce 100 per cent webcasting in all polling stations across the state and for the first time this year the facility will be extended outside polling stations too. Meanwhile, the EC appointed returning officers for all the 294 Assembly constituencies. MPOST

Kejriwal visits Golden Temple; praises Pb CM

NEW DELHI: After the court dismissed all allegations in the so-called Delhi liquor case and effectively affirmed his integrity as 'kattar Imaandar' (staunchly honest), Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convener Arvind Kejriwal visited Sachkhand Sri Harmandir Sahib with his wife to offer prayers and express gratitude to Waheguru. Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Singh Mann and his wife, along with other dignitaries, also paid obeisance at the Darbar Sahib on the occasion. Reflecting on the development, the AAP supremo said that the leadership of the AAP had been subjected to a sustained campaign of false allegations and political mudslinging,

under which five of the party's top leaders were imprisoned on fabricated charges. During a media interaction, Kejriwal said: "This could not have happened without the grace and blessings of Waheguru." Kejriwal further asserted: "A lot still remains to be done in Punjab. If we make four promises and deliver seven or eight works, that reflects greatness. But making eight promises and delivering only four does not reflect greatness. All the promises we made have been fulfilled. In the next one year, Mann and his entire team have prepared a very big plan. Now Punjab has to be taken to the next level. A lot work has to be done at many levels." MPOST

Govt has no plans to change Taj Mahal's name

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government has no proposal under its consideration to change the name of Taj Mahal, Minister of Culture Gajendra Singh Shekhawat told the Rajya Sabha on Thursday. Responding to a supplementary query by CPI-M member John Brittas on whether the government had any plans to change the name of Taj Mahal as has been reported in the media, Shekhawat said: "There is no such idea of changing any name under consideration of the ministry." Replying to another supplementary question during the question hour, the minister informed the House that the Modi government in the last

Key Points

- » Culture minister Shekhawat said "there is no such idea of changing any name under consideration of the ministry"
- » TMC MP Sukhendu Sekhar Ray also asked whether the government plans to excavate more historical sites in West Bengal, the minister

10 years has spent double the amount on excavation of historical sites against that spent during the previous 10 years. Asked by TMC MP Sukhendu Sekhar Ray on whether the government plans



said: "Excavations are a continuous process, based on available human resources"

to excavate more historical sites in West Bengal, the minister said: "Excavations are a continuous process, based on available human resources." "The Modi government is very serious about excavations.

In the last 10 years, nearly double funds have been spent on excavation activities as compared to the 10 years prior to that," he said. Shekhawat, however, said the support of the state government will certainly help in speeding up the excavation activities. "As far as conservation activities are concerned, work has been carried out seriously. Against an expenditure of only Rs 1,310 crore from 2004 to 2014, as much as Rs 3,713 crore has been spent in the last 10 years on conservation activities," Shekhawat said. "There are 135 monuments and archaeological sites and remains declared as of national importance in the State of West Bengal, which are maintained by the ASI."

Akhilesh meets top priest, slams 'fake saints'

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav on Thursday met Shankaracharya Avimukteshwaranand in Lucknow and said he had come to seek blessings and guidance from a "true saint". Speaking to reporters after the meeting, Yadav said that meeting genuine saints would eventually expose those he described as "fake saints". "We came here to seek blessings. When people meet real saints, the influence of fake saints will come to an end," he said. During the interaction, Yadav also launched a sharp



Akhilesh Yadav with Swami Avimukteshwaranand Saraswati on Thursday

attack on the Bharatiya Janata Party, alleging that the party opposes every good initiative. Referring to policies during the Samajwadi Party government, he said his government had set up dairy infrastructure to benefit poor families and ensure proper care of cows.

Chhattisgarh

BUILDING THE INDUSTRIES OF TOMORROW

Rapidly Diversifying into New-age Sectors; Grounding Investments and Creating Jobs

₹ 7.83 Lakh Crore
Investment Commitments Till Date

1.5 Lakh+ Jobs
Expected

50% Thrust
Sector Projects

Diversification in Action

- India's First AI Data center Park in Nava Raipur
- Central India's Largest Pharma Park
- State's First ₹18,000+ Cr Semiconductor Plant in Nava Raipur
- Manufacturing base of India's largest pet food brand
- A Flagship Multi-Speciality Hospital by a 70-year-old National Healthcare Institution

#CGBusinessEasy

Invest Chhattisgarh

"Chhattisgarh is no longer defined only by what it extracts from the ground, but by what it is building for the future, real projects, real jobs and a diversified, modern economy."
- Vishnu Deo Sai, Chief Minister, Chhattisgarh

— ACCUSED SENT TO 5-DAY POLICE REMAND —

Political leaders across J&K condemn attack on ex-CM Farooq Abdullah

MPOST BUREAU

JAMMU: Cutting across party lines, political leaders in Kashmir on Thursday condemned the attack on National Conference president and former chief minister Farooq Abdullah in Jammu and demanded a thorough probe into the incident.

Leaders from the BJP, Congress and PDP demanded accountability from those responsible for security, while the National Conference termed the incident a “major security lapse” and sought a detailed investigation.

An attempt on the life of Abdullah while he was attending a marriage ceremony here was thwarted by alert security personnel, police said, adding that the accused was arrested and the pistol used in the incident has been seized.

According to police, the incident took place at the Royal Park wedding venue in the posh Greater Kailash locality of Jammu late Wednesday when Abdullah was leaving the function after attending the ceremony along with Jammu and Kashmir Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Choudhary.

“The security deployed with the protectee immediately swung into action, thwarted the attempt and took the accused into custody, who was later identified as Kamal Singh Jamwal, a resident of Purani Mandi in Jammu,” police said in a statement.

Officials said the accused was waiting outside the venue and attempted to fire at Abdullah as he stepped out after attending the function. Two police personnel — an inspector and a sub-inspector — quickly overpowered him, but the accused managed to fire one shot before he was disarmed and taken into custody.

Abdullah and Choudhary



Accused Kamal Singh Jamwal is produced in a court in connection with the attack on Farooq Abdullah

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The incident took place in the posh Greater Kailash locality late Wednesday when Abdullah was leaving a wedding function
- » ‘I am fine and God has saved me,’ Abdullah said

had attended the wedding to greet party leader B S Chouhan on the marriage of his son, officials said.

Meanwhile, a court here remanded the accused to five-day police custody for questioning. The 63-year-old accused, Jamwal, was produced before the city court amid tight security. Investigators said the accused reportedly told them he had been waiting nearly two decades for an opportunity to kill Abdullah as he had a “personal motive”.

Abdullah described his narrow escape from the assassination attempt as an act of divine intervention while raising serious questions over the “total absence” of police deployment at the high-profile wedding where the incident occurred.

“I am fine and God has saved me,” Abdullah said.

He said he did not know the accused and was unaware of any motive behind the alleged attack.

Recounting the moments of the attack, Abdullah said he initially mistook the gunshot for the sound of firecrackers, which are commonly burst during wedding celebrations.

“I had just stepped out of the wedding pavilion (mandap) and was walking when I heard a sound like a firecracker. I thought someone must have burst a firecracker, because people often burst them at weddings,” he said.

Abdullah said he later felt a burning sensation but did not immediately realise that it was a gunshot. “...In the meantime, they (security personnel) quickly pushed me into a car, and when they were seated, they told me, ‘Sir, it was actually a pistol.’ They said that the person had fired two shots at me,” Abdullah said.

Asked about a possible security lapse, Abdullah said it would be premature to draw conclusions but noted that several prominent people were present at the function.

Following the incident, Union Home minister Amit Shah spoke with Abdullah to enquire about his well-being and assured a thorough investigation into the attack.

Abdullah credited his survival to the swift reactions of his Special Security Group and NSG cover. “They stood in front of me and showed immense courage.”

CBI raids 15 locations in four states in Rs 900 cr online investment fraud case

Agency identifies chartered accountant Ashok Kumar Sharma as mastermind

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) conducted raids at 15 locations in Delhi, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, and Punjab in an online investment fraud and part-time job scam. These raids are a part of a large-scale online investment fraud and part-time job scams involving offshore transactions and fintech platforms in foreign countries, including Dubai-based fintech firm Pyypl.

The raids were conducted by the CBI based on a complaint from the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) under the Ministry of Home Affairs. Thousands of Indian citizens have been duped of crores of rupees through an online investment fraud scheme by a transnational fraud network.

The investigation revealed that the fraud network used

INSIGHT

» Raids were conducted at 15 locations in Delhi, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, and Punjab based on a complaint from the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre

» The investigation revealed that the fraud network used social

media platforms, mobile apps, and messaging apps to lure people with the promise of high returns through online investments and part-time jobs. Initially, people were asked to invest a small amount in these fraud schemes. Later, after gaining their trust with the promise of high returns on investment, people were asked to invest a larger amount in these fraud schemes.



media platforms, mobile apps, and messaging apps to lure people

The fraudulent funds were quickly transferred through several mule accounts, thereby concealing the money trail. The money was further transferred through offshore ATM transactions using debit cards that facilitate international transactions. The investigators have further stated that the money was transferred through top-ups made on offshore fintech platforms, primarily Pyypl, using Visa

MP: 4 minor sisters found dead in well

Their mother kills herself at home

MPOST BUREAU

SAGAR (MP): Four minor sisters aged between five months and seven years were found dead in a well on Thursday, while their mother who allegedly threw them into the water body, was found hanging at her home in a village in Sagar district of Madhya Pradesh, police said.

Prima facie it appears that the woman, Savita Lodhi (30), threw her four daughters into the well and later hanged herself at her house in Khamaria village, about 50km from the district headquarters, City Superintendent of Police (CSP) Lalit Kashyap told reporters.

The sisters, aged between five months and seven years, drowned in the well located in an agriculture field belonging to a local farmer, he said, adding three of the bod-

It appears that the woman threw her four daughters into the well and later hanged herself

ies have been fished out so far with the help of villagers.

On receiving information about the incident, which created panic in the village, personnel from the Kesli police station reached the spot and began an investigation.

The reason behind the suicide-murders was not yet known, according to police.

Police are questioning family members of the deceased and local residents to ascertain the circumstances leading to the incident, the CSP said.

‘Namaz inside house’: High Court orders 24/7 security for Bareilly man

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Allahabad High Court has directed authorities to provide round-the-clock police protection to a Muslim man from Bareilly who alleged that he was stopped from offering Namaz inside his private residence.

A division bench of Justice Atul Sreedharan and Justice Siddharth Nandan ordered that two armed police personnel be deployed for the protection of Haseen Khan at all times.

The court said the guards must remain with Khan wherever he goes. It also observed that if any incident of violence occurs against him or his property, it would prima facie be treated as having occurred at the instance of the state.

Khan had earlier approached the court seeking permission to hold a religious congregation to offer Namaz at his house. Dur-

‘If any incident of violence occurs against him, it would prima facie be treated as having occurred at the instance of the state’

ing the earlier hearing, the state government had informed the court that offering prayers inside one’s private property does not require permission under the law as it falls within the fundamental right to freedom of religion guaranteed under Article 25 of the Constitution.

However, it was later alleged that Khan was taken into custody from his house by the police while offering Namaz and was challenged. He also alleged that he was threatened with the demolition of

his property and was forced to sign blank papers.

Following these allegations, a contempt petition was filed against the state authorities for alleged violation of the court’s earlier orders.

During the hearing, the court asked whether permission had been sought for offering Namaz inside the private house. The Additional Advocate General representing the state told the bench that permission had been obtained from all persons present in the house.

Taking note of the circumstances, the court ordered immediate police protection for Khan.

The bench has also summoned the District Magistrate and the Senior Superintendent of Police of Bareilly, who have been named as alleged contemnors in the case. They have been directed to appear before the court on March 23 for further orders in the matter.

Agra: Minor girl slips through broken school bus floor, dies

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

AGRA: A nine-year-old girl died after falling through the broken floor of a moving school bus in Agra’s Etmadpur area on Wednesday, raising serious questions about the safety of school transport vehicles. The incident comes days after a similar tragedy in Aligarh on February 28, in which a seven-year-old girl lost her life.

Police said the victim, identified as Naina, a Class 1 student, slipped through the damaged floor of the bus and fell onto the road while it was in motion. The wheel of the bus then ran over her before the driver could stop the vehicle.

The accident occurred near Biharipura under the Etmadpur police station limits. Naina was a student of RBS School in Bhagupur village and a resident of Nagla Lale village in Agra district.

According to family members, the school bus was in a dilapidated condition. They alleged that instead of proper seats, children were made to sit on wooden planks placed over broken portions of the floor. When the bus crossed a speed breaker with a strong jolt, one of the planks slipped, causing Naina to lose her balance and fall through the damaged section.

Other children on the bus raised an alarm after the incident, prompting the driver to stop the vehicle. The girl was rushed to a hospital but doctors declared her dead on arrival.

Naina had left for school in the morning with her elder sister Pari, a Class 5 student in the same school. The two sisters were returning home around 3 pm when the accident took place.

Naina’s father Brahmajet alleged that the school management did not immediately inform the family about the incident. He said he came to know about the accident only after contacting the school authorities.

‘DAWAT-E-IFTAR’



Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren attends the ‘Dawat-e-Iftar’ hosted by Health minister Irfan Ansari at his residence in Ranchi on Thursday

LPG consumers report delays, queues

UP govt says there is adequate stock of petrol, diesel & LPG

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government has said that there is adequate stock of petrol, diesel and domestic LPG cylinders across the state and urged people not to pay attention to rumours about shortages.

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has directed the administration to take strict action against those spreading rumours about shortages and engaging in hoarding or black marketing of petroleum products and cooking gas.

The Chief Minister has asked officials to keep a constant watch on the fuel supply chain and ensure that the distribution system functions smoothly. Authorities have been instructed to take immediate action if any irregularities are detected.

Following these directions, district officials have started inspections of petrol pumps and LPG agencies to ensure proper supply and prevent any malpractice.

The state government has also appealed to residents to ignore rumours and rely only on official information. It



Samajwadi Party workers in Lucknow protest against the LPG price hike and shortage on Thursday

warned that strict action will be taken against anyone spreading misleading information.

However, reports from several parts of the state suggest that the shortage of LPG cylinders has begun to affect daily life. In many cities, consumers said they are not receiving cylinders even four to five days after booking. Long queues have been reported outside gas agencies.

Cases of alleged black marketing have also surfaced. In Gorakhpur, authorities sealed two gas agencies over allegations of black marketing of LPG cylinders and arrested the owner.

In Lucknow, workers of the Samajwadi Party staged a protest over the alleged shortage of LPG cylinders. During the demonstration, protesters raised slogans targeting the central government. When police tried to disperse them, several protesters lay down on the road. Police later dragged them into vehicles and took them to Eco Garden. Some workers were also seen climbing on police vehicles during the protest.

The shortage has also affected institutions. At King George’s Medical University in Lucknow, authorities said the

KEY POINTS

- » CM Yogi directed the administration to take strict action against those spreading rumours
- » He asked officials to keep a constant watch on the fuel supply chain and ensure that the distribution system functions smoothly
- » Reports from several parts of the state suggest that the shortage of LPG cylinders has begun to affect daily life

supply disruption has impacted food preparation for patients. The hospital, which serves food to around 2,500 patients, has started reducing breakfast items and rotis and is currently managing with smaller five kilogram commercial cylinders.

In Kanpur, residents created a ruckus at a gas agency after failing to get LPG cylinders. Police reached the spot and supervised the distribution of cylinders. An announcement was made through loudspeakers assuring people that there was no shortage and urging them not to pay attention to rumours.

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Cabinet minister and AAP state president Aman Arora on Thursday launched a sharp attack on the BJP-led Central government, accusing it of a “comprehensive failure” on both foreign and domestic fronts and claiming that its promises of making India a “Vishwa Guru” and “Aatmanirbhar” now stand exposed.

Speaking on a resolution moved by Food and Civil Supplies minister Lal Chand Katarachak in the Assembly, Arora contrasted government claims with what he described as the grim situation faced by ordinary citizens.

The Assembly passed the resolution stating that the “failure of Centre’s foreign policy has led to a shortage and increase in price of LPG, caus-

Punjab Assembly passed a resolution stating that the ‘failure of Centre’s foreign policy has led to a shortage’

ing hardships to people across the country.”

Referring to newspaper reports, Arora said there were stories about kilometre-long queues outside gas agencies, hotels on the verge of closure and weddings facing uncertainty due to the shortage of cooking gas. At the same time, he pointed out, a full-page advertisement by the Government of India carried the slogan “Your Home Our First Priority”.

Fuel supply normal in Haryana: MoS Nagar

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Minister of State for Food and Civil Supplies Rajesh Nagar said on Thursday that the supply of petrol, diesel and domestic LPG in the state is completely normal.

He also warned that strict action will be taken against mischievous elements spreading rumours and attempting black marketing.

Nagar said that the general public should not pay attention to rumours. In a letter issued on March 9, the Union Petroleum ministry provided necessary guidelines regarding ensuring adequate supply, proper and equitable distribution and availability of domestic LPG for priority sectors. In compliance with these directions, the Haryana government has taken all necessary steps with immediate effect, he said.

At present, the supply of petrol, diesel and domestic LPG across Haryana is running smoothly. Major oil companies — IOCL, BPCL and HPCL — have adequate stock available.

Arora argued that such messaging itself indicated that the situation was serious. He also recalled speeches made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi before 2014, when he had spoken about India leading the world and becoming self-reliant.

According to Arora, after more than a decade in power, the Central government has not been able to achieve either of those goals. He also criticised what he termed as weaknesses in India’s foreign policy, claiming that several neighbouring countries had drifted away from New Delhi and moved closer to China.

Citing official data, the AAP leader said India’s natural gas production had declined from 40.68 billion cubic metres (BCM) in 2012 to about 35

BCM in 2024, while consumption increased from 47 BCM to 69 BCM. Similarly, he said domestic crude oil production dropped from 37 million metric tonnes in 2013-14 to about 29 million metric tonnes in 2023-24, while consumption rose from 158 million metric tonnes to 233 million metric tonnes.

He also claimed that India’s dependence on imported liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) had risen significantly over the past decade, increasing from around 45 per cent in 2014 to nearly 66 per cent in 2025.

Arora further referred to reports about a refinery investment in the United States involving Reliance Industries and cited remarks by former US president Donald Trump praising the investment.

Haryana to lead ‘Viksit Bharat’ vision: CM Saini

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday said that the state would play a leading role in realising the vision of Viksit Bharat by 2047 and is aligning its development priorities with Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s roadmap for building a strong and prosperous nation.

Addressing a summit at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi, Saini expressed gratitude to the Prime Minister for setting the ambitious goal of Viksit Bharat and said Haryana was steadily advancing policies and initiatives that would contribute significantly to the national mission.

The Chief Minister said the PM had emphasised development based on four key pillars — farmers, women empowerment, employment for youth and upliftment of the poor — and the Haryana government was working rapidly across all these areas.

He said farmers in the state were excelling not only in traditional agriculture but also in natural farming and horticulture. The government, he added, was also implementing several initiatives to strengthen women’s participation in various sectors.



Haryana CM Nayab Singh Saini speaks during the NXT Summit held at Bharat Mandapam in New Delhi

“Today, women are making significant contributions across sectors such as agriculture, health, education and other fields,” Saini said. Highlighting efforts towards youth development, the chief minister said the state government had introduced a Startup Policy to promote entrepreneurship among young people. At the same time, schemes such as Ayushman Bharat, Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana and Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi were being implemented to support economically weaker sections.



EDITORIAL

TRADE CROSSROADS

The latest move by the United States to launch a fresh round of Section 301 investigations against sixteen major trading partners marks a new phase in global trade tensions. Announced by the Office of the United States Trade Representative (USTR) on March 11, the probe targets policies and industrial practices in economies ranging from India and China to Japan and the European Union. The investigation comes at a moment when the global trading system is already under stress from rising protectionism, supply-chain realignments and geopolitical competition. By invoking Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974 — a powerful instrument designed to counter what Washington considers unfair foreign trade practices — the United States is signalling that it is prepared to scrutinise and potentially retaliate against manufacturing policies it believes disadvantage American industry. The sectors under review are extensive, covering steel, aluminium, automobiles, batteries, semiconductors, solar modules, electronics, machinery and chemicals. Together, they represent the very industries that are shaping the technological and economic balance of the twenty-first century.

The investigation is not an isolated development but part of a broader recalibration of American trade policy following a legal setback. Earlier, the US Supreme Court struck down sweeping tariffs imposed by the Trump administration, ruling that the President could not rely on the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) of 1977 to impose such broad trade restrictions. In response, President Donald Trump announced a temporary 10 per cent tariff on imports from all countries for 150 days beginning February 24, invoking Section 122 of the Trade Act of 1974 as an interim measure. The new Section 301 probe therefore represents Washington's attempt to re-establish a legal and policy pathway for imposing targeted trade measures. The White House has argued that global manufacturing overcapacity — fuelled by subsidies, state-supported production and export-oriented policies in several countries — is undermining American industry. By examining issues such as industrial subsidies, the role of state-owned enterprises, market-access barriers and currency practices, the investigation aims to determine whether these policies unfairly burden US commerce. If the findings support Washington's concerns, retaliatory actions ranging from additional tariffs to quantitative restrictions could follow.

The scope of the probe is unusually broad. It includes fifteen countries — China, Singapore, Switzerland, Norway, Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Thailand, South Korea, Vietnam, Taiwan, Bangladesh, Mexico, Japan and India — along with the 27-member European Union. The inclusion of both advanced economies and emerging manufacturing hubs highlights Washington's belief that structural overcapacity in global industry is no longer confined to a single country. The investigation process itself will unfold over several months. Public submissions will begin on March 17, allowing companies, trade associations and governments to present their views. Requests to participate in hearings must be filed by April 15, with public hearings scheduled between May 5 and May 8 at the US International Trade Commission in Washington. After the hearings, rebuttal submissions will follow, and the USTR will consult with the governments concerned before deciding whether retaliatory action is warranted. While the process appears procedural, its political implications are significant. Section 301 investigations were famously used during the earlier US-China trade confrontation, leading to billions of dollars in tariffs and counter-tariffs that reshaped global supply chains.

For India, the investigation presents both a challenge and an opportunity. According to the Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI), the US notice identifies several sectors where India may have structural excess capacity or export surpluses, including solar modules, petrochemicals, steel, textiles, health-related goods, construction materials and automotive products. The solar-module sector, in particular, has drawn attention because India's manufacturing capacity is estimated to be nearly three times domestic demand, suggesting that export markets will play a crucial role in absorbing production. Similar concerns have been raised about expanding capacities in petrochemicals and steel. Yet Indian exporters remain cautiously optimistic. The Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO) has argued that India's export growth is largely diversified and driven by global demand rather than by excessive state subsidies or artificial expansion. Consequently, many industry observers believe that while the probe may lead to heightened scrutiny, it is unlikely to produce immediate punitive measures against India. Nevertheless, the situation will require careful diplomatic and policy engagement to ensure that India's industrial policies are not mischaracterised in Washington.

Beyond the immediate implications for specific countries, the Section 301 investigation underscores a deeper transformation in the global trading system. For decades, the World Trade Organization (WTO) provided the principal forum for resolving trade disputes, with multilateral rules shaping how countries responded to perceived unfair practices. Today, however, major powers are increasingly resorting to unilateral trade instruments to defend domestic industries and strategic sectors. The United States' willingness to employ multiple legal tools — including Section 301, Section 232 of the Trade Expansion Act of 1962 on national-security grounds, and temporary tariffs under Section 122 — reflects a broader shift towards economic statecraft. In an era defined by technological rivalry, supply-chain resilience and strategic competition, trade policy has become inseparable from industrial and geopolitical strategy. For countries like India, navigating this environment will require balancing domestic industrial expansion with careful engagement in global trade diplomacy. The outcome of the US investigation will therefore be watched closely, not merely as a trade dispute but as an indicator of how the next phase of global economic competition will unfold.

BASE BETRAYAL



SANJAY AGARWAL

THE WRITER IS FORMER SECURITY ADVISOR, MINISTRY OF HOME AFFAIRS, GOI

What began as a decolonisation question has evolved into a test case for the credibility of the global rules-based order

PLANET WATCH



SINGARAM KULANDAIVEL

THE WRITER IS THE CHIEF CONSERVATOR OF FORESTS, GOVERNMENT OF WEST BENGAL

Governance becomes stronger when communities cooperate with authorities. Local vigilance and timely reporting of illegal activities significantly enhance forest protection

Chagos Dispute and World Order

From ICJ rulings to power politics, the Chagos dispute exposes contradictions in the global rules-based order and reshapes strategic dynamics in the Indian Ocean

Diego Garcia, the largest island in the Chagos Archipelago, sits astride crucial sea-lanes in the central Indian Ocean and hosts one of Washington's most important overseas bases. The struggle over its sovereignty is not just a local decolonisation dispute; it goes to the heart of who sets and who obeys the "rules-based order," and it now offers a precedent for other colonial-era boundary questions. This article outlines the historical background, the 2019 International Court of Justice (ICJ) advisory opinion, the subsequent binding maritime ruling in favour of Mauritius, the recent UK-Mauritius-US triangular diplomacy, the Trump-Starmer controversy, the West's double standards, and an India-centred assessment.

From Detachment to Dispossession

In 1965, as Britain prepared to grant Mauritius independence, it unilaterally detached the Chagos Archipelago from the colony and created the British Indian Ocean Territory (BIOT). Soon after, London agreed to lease Diego Garcia to the United States, leading to the construction of a major air and naval facility. Between 1968-1973, the indigenous Chagossian population was forcibly removed to Mauritius and the Seychelles to clear the islands for the American military base. This combination of partition, strategic leasing and expulsion laid the seeds of a sovereignty and human-rights dispute that would last decades.

The 2019 ICJ Advisory Opinion and UNGA Resolution 73/295

On 25 February 2019, the ICJ issued its advisory opinion in the case "Legal Consequences of the Sepa-

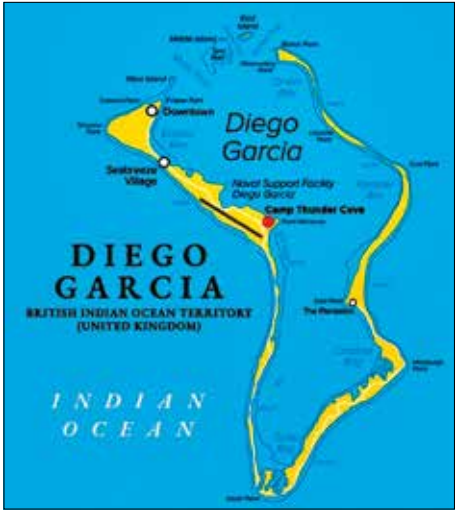
ration of the Chagos Archipelago from Mauritius in 1965." The Court held, by 13 votes to 1, that the detachment of Chagos meant "the decolonisation of Mauritius was not lawfully completed." It concluded that the UK is "under an obligation to bring to an end its administration of the Chagos Archipelago as rapidly as possible."

Because this was an advisory opinion requested by the UN General Assembly (UNGA), it was not a binding judgment in a contentious case. Under the ICJ Statute, only judgments in disputes between consenting states are binding between the parties, and even then only under Article 59. Advisory opinions are formally non-binding, though they carry considerable legal weight and are often treated as authoritative statements of international law.

On 22 May 2019, the UNGA adopted Resolution 73/295 by 116 votes to 6. It affirmed that "the Chagos Archipelago forms an integral part of the territory of Mauritius" and demanded that the United Kingdom withdraw its colonial administration from the archipelago within six months of the resolution's adoption. The six-month deadline implied a date of 22 November 2019 for ending British administration. London rejected both the advisory opinion and the resolution's implications, insisting that it retained sovereignty and that the ICJ's view was merely advisory.

From Advisory Logic to Binding Law: The ITLOS Special Chamber

After the UK dismissed the ICJ opinion as non-binding, Mauritius sought a forum where the legal logic of Chagos could crystallise into a binding decision. The opportunity came via



a maritime boundary dispute with the Maldives in the same region. The case was brought under the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) and submitted to a Special Chamber of the International Tribunal for the Law of the Sea (ITLOS).

In its judgment on preliminary objections on 28 January 2021, the Special Chamber rejected the Maldives' argument that it lacked jurisdiction because of an unresolved sovereignty dispute between Mauritius and the UK. Relying heavily on the ICJ advisory opinion and UNGA Resolution 73/295, the Special Chamber held that it had a sufficient basis to treat Mauritius as the coastal State in respect of the Chagos Archipelago. In effect, it accepted that the United Kingdom could not rely on a claim to sovereignty over Chagos for maritime delimitation.

On 28 April 2023, in its judgment on the merits, the Special Chamber went on to delimit the maritime boundary between Mauritius and the Maldives. In doing so, it drew a binding line premised on Mauritius being the sole coastal State for Chagos. Under Article 296 of UNCLOS and the

ITLOS Statute, these decisions are final and binding between Mauritius and the Maldives. They are not formally binding on the UK, which was not a party, but they transformed the ICJ's "non-binding" opinion into an applied, binding outcome in a concrete case and sharply undermined Britain's legal position.

The 2024-25 UK-Mauritius Agreement and the Trump-Starmer Row

Cumulatively, the 2019 ICJ advisory opinion, UNGA Resolution 73/295, and the 2021/2023 ITLOS judgments created intense legal and diplomatic pressure on the UK. By late 2022, the UK entered negotiations with Mauritius on the future of the archipelago. These talks culminated in a 2025 agreement under which sovereignty over the Chagos Archipelago, including Diego Garcia, is to be transferred to Mauritius. In parallel, Mauritius undertakes to grant a long-term (reportedly 99-year) arrangement preserving the UK-US military presence on Diego Garcia. The deal also sets a framework for acknowledging past wrongs and enabling some form of Chagossian return. This legal and diplo-

matic trajectory recently intersected with domestic politics in both London and Washington. The US base on Diego Garcia is crucial for its power projection and operations. In 2026, the agreement became the focus of a public row between US President Donald Trump and UK PM Keir Starmer, with Trump oscillating between tacit support and strong criticism. At various points, he has described the arrangement as a mistake that might weaken a vital strategic asset and hinted he could withhold or complicate US assent to the deal.

Supporters of the agreement argue that it finally completes the decolonisation of Mauritius in line with ICJ and UNGA guidance, restores legal credibility to the UK, preserves the operational value of Diego Garcia under Mauritian sovereignty, and creates space for a more just treatment of the Chagossians. Critics, especially in some US and UK security circles, respond that advisory opinions and Assembly resolutions are not binding, that surrendering British sovereignty under pressure sets a bad precedent, and that relying on a long lease from Mauritius could inject uncertainty if domestic politics in Mauritius change or if external powers (read China) gain influence.

Confusion Compounded by Maldives

On 4-5 February 2026, Maldives defied the ITLOS ruling against Mauritius (not the UK) through rhetoric and limited EEZ patrols. On 5 February 2026, President Mohamed Muizzu addressed Parliament, formally rejecting the 28 April 2023 ITLOS maritime boundary ruling and asserting Maldives' superior historical and geographical claim, citing 16th-century documents and traditional

fishing rights.

Rules-Based Order and Western Credibility

Chagos has become a case study in Western inconsistency on the "rules-based order." The UK and its allies have been vocal in condemning other states for ignoring international courts and UN resolutions, yet London initially shrugged off a near-unanimous ICJ advisory opinion and blatantly ignored the UN-imposed deadline of 22 November 2019. It then took binding UNCLOS litigation and mounting diplomatic isolation before Britain moved decisively towards implementing the Court's view through negotiations. This gap between rhetoric and practice weakens Western claims to normative leadership, especially in the Global South.

An India-Centric Conclusion

For India, the Diego Garcia and Chagos settlements sit at the intersection of decolonisation, Indian Ocean security and major-power competition. New Delhi has backed Mauritius' claim as part of a broader anti-colonial and Global South posture, while also quietly valuing a strong US presence on Diego Garcia as a counterweight to China's expanding footprint in the region. A Mauritian-sovereign Chagos under a long, secure security arrangement with the US and UK potentially aligns these interests: it vindicates decolonisation while maintaining a stabilising military presence in the central Indian Ocean. The main risk for India lies not in the settlement itself, but in prolonged political wrangling in London and Washington that could erode Western cohesion and open fresh space for extra-regional actors in the Indian Ocean.

Views expressed are personal

India's Green Development Path

India's forests underpin climate stability, water security and rural livelihoods — making community-led conservation essential for achieving the Sustainable Development Goals by 2030

In 2015, the global community adopted the United Nations Sustainable Development Agenda, outlining 17 Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) to be achieved by 2030. These goals represent humanity's collective commitment to end poverty, protect the planet, and ensure prosperity for future generations. While many sectors contribute to these goals, forests occupy a uniquely central position. They sustain water systems, regulate climate, support biodiversity, and provide livelihoods to millions.

India, with nearly 24.62 per cent of its geographical area under forest and tree cover according to the Forest Survey of India, stands at a critical juncture. The nation's forests support the livelihoods of over 275 million forest-dependent people, many of whom live in remote and economically vulnerable regions. From the perspective of a forest administrator working closely with field realities, it is clear that forest departments are not merely custodians of trees; they are institutions that connect environmental stewardship with human welfare. Achieving the SDGs in India will require the integration of scientific forest management with the participation and awareness of local communities.

Biodiversity and Ecosystem Protection

At the heart of forestry lies the mission of conserving life on land, directly aligned with SDG 15: Life on Land. India is among the world's 17 megadiverse countries, hosting nearly 8 per cent of the world's recorded biodiversity. Forest departments safeguard this wealth through protected areas such as national parks, wildlife sanctuaries, conservation reserves, and community reserves.

Yet biodiversity protection cannot be achieved through government action alone. Across



Forest ecosystems regulate climate, sustain biodiversity and support millions of livelihoods across India

India, forest-fringe communities possess deep ecological knowledge passed down through generations. Their understanding of seasonal cycles, wildlife movement, and forest regeneration often complements modern scientific approaches.

The role of the forest department is therefore evolving from enforcement to partnership. Community-based protection committees, local monitoring groups, and participatory forest management have demonstrated success in reducing illegal logging, forest fires, and wildlife poaching. When communities recognise that a thriving forest secures water, soil fertility, and cultural identity, conservation becomes a shared responsibility.

Climate Change Mitigation

Climate change is one of the greatest challenges of the 21st century. Forests act as natural climate regulators by absorbing carbon dioxide from the atmosphere and storing it as biomass, directly contributing to SDG 13: Climate Action. India's forests currently store an estimated 7,204 million tonnes of carbon, and the country has committed under the Paris Agreement to create an additional carbon sink of 2.5-3 billion tonnes of CO₂ equivalent through forest and tree cover by 2030.

Forest-fringe communities are often the first to observe changes

in rainfall patterns, rising temperatures, and declining water sources. When they participate in afforestation programs, protect plantations, and prevent forest fires, they become frontline actors in climate action. Forest departments can strengthen these efforts by integrating local participation in afforestation drives, climate-resilient species selection, and landscape restoration initiatives.

Water Security

Forests function as natural water towers. They capture rainfall, recharge groundwater, regulate stream flows, and prevent soil erosion. In a country where water scarcity is becoming a critical challenge, these ecological services are invaluable.

This directly supports SDG 6: Clean Water and Sanitation. Studies indicate that over 70 per cent of India's major rivers originate in forested watersheds. The health of rivers such as the Ganga, Brahmaputra, Godavari, and Cauvery is closely linked to the integrity of forest ecosystems in their catchments.

Villagers living near forests play a crucial role in maintaining these watersheds. Preventing forest fires, avoiding overgrazing, and protecting vegetation along stream banks can significantly improve water availability. Awareness programs conducted by forest departments help com-

munities understand the connection between forests and drinking water security.

Poverty Reduction and Rural Livelihoods

For millions of rural families, forests represent more than ecological assets; they are a source of daily survival. Collection of fuelwood, fodder, honey, medicinal plants, and other non-timber forest products forms a significant part of the rural economy. Sustainable forest management therefore contributes directly to SDG 1: No Poverty and SDG 2: Zero Hunger.

In many tribal and forest-fringe regions, income from forest products supplements agricultural earnings, particularly during lean seasons. Forest departments can strengthen this relationship by promoting value addition, training communities in sustainable harvesting techniques, and facilitating market access. When villagers see forests as a sustainable source of livelihood, conservation becomes economically meaningful.

Green Economy and Employment

The concept of a green economy is gaining importance in national development strategies. Forests offer opportunities for sustainable growth through eco-tourism, bamboo-based industries, herbal medicine production, and nature-based enterprises.

These activities contribute to SDG 8: Decent Work and Economic Growth. Across India, eco-tourism initiatives managed jointly by forest departments and local communities have generated employment while promoting environmental awareness. Young people from forest-fringe villages are increasingly finding employment as nature guides, wildlife trackers, eco-tourism operators, and conservation volunteers, creating a generation that views forests as assets to be protected.

Gender Inclusion and Community Participation

Women have traditionally been at the forefront of forest resource management in rural India. From collecting fuelwood and fodder to managing household water needs, women share an intimate relationship with forests. Programs such as Joint Forest Management have shown that involving women in decision-making significantly improves forest protection outcomes, aligning with SDG 5: Gender Equality.

Women's self-help groups across several states are now actively participating in plantation drives, forest fire prevention, nursery development, and sustainable harvesting of forest produce. Empowering these groups through training, financial support, and leadership opportunities can transform forest governance at the grassroots level.

Sustainable Futures

Rapid urbanisation and changing land-use patterns are placing growing pressure on natural ecosystems, making sustainable landscape planning essential. Integrating forests, agriculture and urban development through urban forestry, agroforestry, green belts and restoration of degraded landscapes helps maintain ecological balance while supporting sustainable cities. Effective environmental governance by forest departments plays a crucial role in enforcing laws against illegal logging, wildlife trafficking and encroachment. Equally important is community participation, which strengthens monitoring and protection efforts. Collaborative partnerships among governments, academic institutions, civil society organisations and local communities further enhance conservation initiatives. Ultimately, safeguarding forests depends on collective responsibility, informed citizens and committed institutions working together to advance the Sustainable Development Goals.

Views expressed are personal

IRANIAN ATTACKS ON SHIPS AND OIL INFRA HAVE PUSHED OIL PRICES

Stopping Iran of greater importance than oil prices, says Donald Trump

WASHINGTON: US President Donald Trump on Thursday said stopping the “evil empire” in Iran was of greater importance to him than oil prices, which have been ruling high since the US and Israel launched a war on Iran on February 28.

Iranian attacks on ships and oil infrastructure in West Asia have pushed crude prices above USD 100 a barrel.

“The United States is the largest Oil Producer in the World, by far, so when oil prices go up, we make a lot of money. BUT, of far greater interest and importance to me, as President, is stopping an evil Empire, Iran, from having Nuclear Weapons, and destroying the Middle East and, indeed, the World. I won't ever let that happen,” Trump said in a post on Truth Social.

Launched on February 28, Operation Epic Fury against Iran has divided political opinion in the US, with Democrats demanding public hearings with testimony from top Trump administration officials.

White House officials, including Secretary of State Marco Rubio, have held clas-



US President Donald Trump

sified briefings with lawmakers since the attacks on Iran began. However, there have been claims that Trump has been sending mixed signals on the progress achieved in the war.

“Here we are well into the second week, and it is still the

case that the Trump administration cannot explain the reasons that we entered this war, the goals we're trying to accomplish, and the methods for doing that,” Democrat senator Elizabeth Warren was quoted as saying after a classified briefing.

White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt, in a post on X, accused the “left-wing media” of pushing a “fake narrative” about mixed messaging about the objectives of Operation Epic Fury.

“From the beginning, President Trump and his entire

Highlights

- » Operation Epic Fury against Iran has divided political opinion in the US, with Democrats demanding public hearings
- » Trump has meanwhile promised to ‘finish the job,’ even though he claimed Iran is “virtually destroyed”

team have consistently laid out clear objectives to the American people about what the US Military seeks to accomplish through these ongoing successful major combat operations,” Leavitt said.

“Destroy the terrorist Iranian regime's missiles and raze their missile industry to the ground. Annihilate the terrorist Iranian regime's navy. Ensure the regime's fellow terrorist proxies can no longer destabilise the region and attack our forces; Guarantee the terrorist Iranian regime cannot obtain a nuclear weapon,” Leavitt said.

AGENCIES

Ukraine awaits WH sign-off on US drone production deal: Zelenskyy



Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy

“WE HAVE NOT YET HAD THE OPPORTUNITY TO SIGN THIS DOCUMENT”

KYIV: Ukraine is awaiting White House approval for a major drone production agreement proposed by Kyiv last year, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Thursday, as countries scramble to modernise their air defences after the Iran war exposed shortcomings.

The proposed US-Ukraine deal would cover various types of drones and air defences that operate as a single system capable of protecting against swarms of hundreds or even thousands of Iranian-designed Shahed drones and missiles, Zelenskyy said in a message on social media. “We have not yet had the opportunity to sign this document,” he said.

Russia has fired tens of thousands of Iranian-designed Shahed drones at Ukraine since it invaded its neighbour just over four years ago. It launched a swarm of more than 800 drones and decoys in its biggest nighttime barrage. Iran has responded to joint US-Israeli strikes by firing the same type of drones at targets in the Middle East. Ukraine has pioneered the development of cut-price drone killers, some of which cost a few thousand dollars, that have rewritten the air defence rule book. The conflict unfolding in the Middle East

due to the Iran war.

Zelenskyy arrived in NATO member Romania on Thursday, a day before he visits French President Emmanuel Macron in Paris, as new research indicated Russian oil revenue that helps drive its invasion of Ukraine has risen since the Iran war began.

Russia's daily revenue from oil sales during the Middle East conflict, which has brought a sharp increase in the price of crude, has been on average 14 per cent higher than in February, according to the nonprofit Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air. Oil revenue is crucial for Moscow's war effort.

Macron's office said his talks with the Ukrainian leader will focus on efforts to counter Russia's so-called shadow fleet of tankers that are shipping oil in violation of international sanctions but are hard to stop.

Zelenskyy was to meet in Bucharest with Romanian President Nicuor Dan, Prime Minister Ilie Bolojan and visit a training centre for Ukraine's F-16 pilots.

Ukraine has exported a significant amount of its grain through Romania during the war, and Bucharest has provided energy support to Kyiv as Moscow's forces blast Ukraine's power grid.

AGENCIES

US to permanently close consulate in Peshawar

WASHINGTON: The State Department will permanently close the US consulate in Peshawar, Pakistan, which has been America's closest diplomatic mission to the Afghan border and was a primary operations and logistics point before, during and after the 2001 invasion of Afghanistan.

The department notified Congress this week of its intent to close the consulate and said it would save USD 7.5 million per year, while not adversely affecting its ability to advance US national interests in Pakistan, according to a copy of the notification obtained by The Associated

Administration's cuts to the State Department last year included the dismissal of several thousand personnel

Press on Wednesday.

The move has been under consideration for more than a year since the Trump administration began downsizing nearly all federal agencies and is not related to the Iran war, which has sparked protests in various Pakistani cities., including Karachi and Peshawar.AGENCIES

Ex-PM Manmohan Singh, Khaleda Zia among those included in B'desh parliament's condolence motion

DHAKA: Bangladesh parliament on Thursday condoned the deaths of several national and international leaders, including former Indian prime minister Manmohan Singh, Bangladesh's Khaleda Zia and slain Iranian leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei.

The maiden session of the 13th parliament adopted a motion to condole the deaths initially included 31 names, including late Pope Francis and Matia Chowdhury, a former parliamentarian and leader of deposed premier Sheikh Hasina's Awami League.

However, after the main opposition Jamaat-e-Islami insisted, names of executed 1971 war criminals, tried as hardened collaborators of Pakistani troops during the

Key Points

- » Maiden session of the 13th parliament adopted a motion to condole deaths initially included 31 names
- » The motion also included names of those killed during the July-August mass protests that toppled the Sheikh Hasina government in August 2024

BNP LAWMAKER AND PARLIAMENTARY CHIEF WHIP NURUL ISLAM MONI ENDORSED THE NAMES

country's Liberation War, were also included in it. The motion also included names of those killed during the July-August mass protests that toppled the Sheikh Hasina government in August 2024. The newly elected speaker Hafiz Uddin Ahmed, a veteran 1971 freedom fighter, agreed to incorporate the names of the executed war

criminals as Jamaat claimed the initial list of names were “one sided.”

The motion with proposed expanded list included Jamaat's hanged former chief Matiur Rahman Nizami, its senior leaders Ali Ahsan Mohammad Mujahid, Delwar Hosain Sayeedi, Maulana Abdus Subhan, Abdul Quader Mollah,

Mir Quasem Ali, and Muhammad Kamaruzzaman. Sayeedi, however, died in prison while serving a prison term until his death while Subhan died a natural death.\ A separate condolence proposal was raised for hanged Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) leader Salahuddin Qader Chowdhury, who too was tried for 1971 war crimes siding with Pakistani troops to prevent Bangladesh's 1971 independence. BNP lawmaker and parliamentary Chief Whip Nurul Islam Moni endorsed the names. The first day of the parliament also saw a walkout and demonstration by the opposition over the president's address even when his speech was, in line with the practice, prepared by the government.

AGENCIES

Pope Leo XIV appoints trusted fellow Augustinian to run Vatican's charity office

ROME: Pope Leo XIV on Thursday entrusted the Vatican's charity works to a fellow Augustinian, signalling a line of continuity with Pope Francis who had elevated the centuries-old job to a position of action and prominence that helped define his legacy.

Leo named Archbishop Luis Marin de San Martin, a Spanish member of Leo's religious order and an undersecretary in the Vatican's synd

Marin replaces Polish Cardinal Konrad Krajewski, who becomes the Archbishop of Lodz, in Poland, his home archdiocese that has been without an archbishop for a year

office, as his chief almsgiver and prefect of the Vatican's charity office.

Marin replaces Polish Cardinal Konrad Krajewski, 62, who becomes the Archbishop of Lodz, in Poland, his home

archdiocese that has been without an archbishop for a year.

Francis had redefined the role of the Vatican's chief almsgiver and had asked Krajewski to essentially be the hands-on extension of his own personal acts of charity that he could no longer do himself as pope.

Krajewski became one of Francis' most visible officials. He installed showers for homeless people around St Peter's Square, sat at Francis' side at public audiences and spearheaded Vatican donations of everything from ambulances for Ukraine to COVID-19 vaccines for a group of transgender prostitutes.

AGENCIES

International court drops probe into US sanctions on Venezuela

THE HAGUE: The ICC is dropping an investigation into whether US sanctions against Venezuela qualified as crimes against humanity, prosecutors said Thursday.

Venezuela asked the ICC in 2020 to look into what it called “unlawful coercive measures,” arguing the asset freezes and travel bans targeting Venezuelan officials, first imposed by the United States under President Barack Obama, had

caused “widespread suffering.”

Following an initial investigation, prosecutors declined to move forward, citing a lack of evidence. In a statement, the international court's prosecutor's office said that while it was “generally accepted” that sanctions “may have exacerbated an existing dire humanitarian situation,” there was not enough evidence of “necessary intent” to pursue criminal charges.

AGENCIES

Australia may ban infant formula advertising

MELBOURNE: Recently, the federal government released a consultation paper seeking input on whether it should introduce legislation to prevent or restrict infant formula marketing in Australia. The consultation is open for submissions until April 10.

Until February 2025, Australian formula brands were under a voluntary agreement not to advertise formula products for babies aged 0 to 12 months, in order to support and protect breastfeeding.

With recent data revealing lower-than-desired rates of breastfeeding in Australia, the government has chosen not to renew the voluntary arrangement and is exploring tougher measures.

These moves don't explicitly promote breastfeeding. Rather, they aim to curtail marketing practices that position formula as an equivalent or preferable alternative. Our analysis of online formula ads targeting parents in Australia reveals how companies prey on parents' anxiety – and the problems with having a voluntary agreement.

What's wrong with adver-

Only 37% of babies were reported to have been exclusively breastfed by six months in 2022

Breastfeeding has extensive health benefits for both mother and child.

These include protection against gastrointestinal and respiratory infections for newborns, reduced risk of obesity and type 2 diabetes later in life, and reduced risk of mothers developing ovarian and breast cancer.

Because of this, Australian guidelines recommend exclusive breastfeeding for the first six months.

The World Health Organization recommends continued breastfeeding for the first two years. However, while breastfeeding rates are high at birth in Australia, they quickly drop. Only 37% of babies were reported to have been exclusively breastfed by six months in 2022.

AGENCIES

Damage to historical sites in Iran raises alarm about war's impact

UNESCO confirmed that it has verified damage to Qajar-era Golestan Palace

UNITED NATIONS: US and Israeli strikes on Iran have damaged at least four cultural and historical sites, including palaces and an ancient mosque, raising alarms about the impact of the widening war on protected landmarks that are important to Iranian identity and world history.

The speed and extent of the damage have so concerned Iran and Lebanon that they sent a request to the United Nations' cultural agency, UNESCO, this week to add more sites to its enhanced protection list.

UNESCO confirmed that it has verified damage to the lavish Qajar-era Golestan Palace in Tehran as well as the 17th century Chehel Sotoun palace and the Masjed-e Jame, the country's oldest Friday mosque, both in Isfahan. There also was verified damage at buildings close to the Khorramabad Valley, which includes five prehistoric caves and one rock shelter providing evidence of human occupation dating to 63,000 B.C.



Damage caused by US and Israeli strikes on Iran being seen at the Qajar-era Golestan Palace in Tehran

At Golestan Palace, shattered glass from the mirrored ceilings blanketed the floors alongside broken archways, blown-out windows and damaged molding scattered below its glass-mosaic walls, according to Associated Press video taken March 3.

UNESCO said it provided all parties to the conflict with the geographical coordinates of the heritage sites ahead of time,

“to take all feasible precautions to avoid damage.”

The impact to cultural sites has not been isolated to Iran but has been felt across the Middle East and beyond, with UNESCO tracking damage to the White City in Israel, Tyre in Lebanon and elsewhere.

Collateral damage to such places has been part of the fabric of war for decades, including in conflicts between Russia

Takeaways

- » There also was verified damage at buildings close to the Khorramabad Valley, which includes five prehistoric
- » The impact to cultural sites has not been isolated to Iran but has been felt across the Middle East and beyond

and Ukraine as well as Israel and Hamas, in which dozens of sites have been damaged or destroyed.

“What is happening is clear to all: In these increasingly modern conflicts, it's civilians who pay the price, it's civilian infrastructure that pays the price, and we've all seen the destruction of priceless historical heritage,” U.N. spokesperson Stephane Dujarric said this week.

AGENCIES

AT ANNUAL CONGRESS China positions itself as force for global stability



Chinese President Xi Jinping (left), with Premier Li Qiang and other delegates during the closing session of the National People's Congress (NPC) in China on Thursday

BEIJING: While much of the world's attention is on the Iran war, that hasn't stopped China from moving ahead with national priorities with global repercussions.

Not that China doesn't care about the war and its impact on energy supplies and geopolitics. But for the world's second largest economy, its growing rivalry with the United States revolves around a different battle: the development of the cutting-edge technologies shaping the 21st century.

That message came through in a five-year plan formally endorsed Thursday by the National People's Congress at the end of its annual meeting, the nation's biggest political event of the year. If anything, China is doubling down on a

push to transform its economy and be at the forefront of technology. State media described China's determination to stay the course on economic development as a force for stability in an uncertain world.

“A stable and developing China injects more stability and certainty into a world fraught with change and turbulence,” the official People's Daily newspaper said in a front-page column on Wednesday. Other state-media echoed that view.

The commentaries and official statements didn't mention U.S. President Donald Trump, whose tariffs and use of military force from Venezuela to Iran are shaking up the global order that has governed international relations in the post-World War II era.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

PAKISTAN PM SHARIF VISITS SAUDI

ISLAMABAD: Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Thursday left for a brief official visit to Saudi Arabia with Pakistan's role coming under scanner due to its defence agreement with the kingdom. The two countries signed a mutual defence pact in September last year with the commitment to come to the defence of each other in case of attack by a third country. The agreement was signed when Israel had attacked Hamas leaders in Qatar. However, the situation changed after US and Israel launched coordinated attacks on Iran and it hit back but pounding targets in the Gulf. There is a growing unease if Pakistan would fulfill its obligation towards Saudi Arabia given its good ties and geographical proximity with Iran.

NEPAL SC ORDERS REMOVAL OF RSP CANDIDATE FROM FINANCIAL BLACKLIST

KATHMANDU: Nepal's Supreme Court on Thursday issued an order to remove from a financial blacklist a Rastriya Swatantra Party candidate from a Madhesh province constituency. Kishori Sah's candidature in the March 5 polls from the Dhanusha 1 constituency was cancelled by the Election Commission two days before the elections as his name was included on the blacklist. Sah filed a writ petition against the decision, to which the court issued an interim order removing him from the blacklist, according to Arjun Prasad Koirala, spokesperson of the top court. The EC on Wednesday declared Matrika Yadav of Nepali Communist Party the winner from the Dhanusha 1.

IN A BID TO AVOID ATTACKS

Ships identify themselves as Chinese around Strait of Hormuz

HONG KONG: Some commercial ships near or in the Strait of Hormuz and Persian Gulf have declared themselves as China-linked since the Iran war began, marine traffic data show, as their operators apparently try to reduce risks of being targeted in attacks.

At least eight vessels in or near the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman changed their declared destination signals to short messages such as “CHINA OWNER” or “CHINA OWNER & CREW,” according to data on the ship tracking platform MarineTraffic analysed by The Associated Press.

“The main goal of vessels publicly identifying themselves as Chinese while transiting the Gulf or the Strait of Hormuz is primarily to reduce the risk of being attacked rather than to facilitate passage through the strait itself,” said Ana Subasic, a trade risk analyst at data and analytics firm Kpler, which owns MarineTraffic.

Some of the vessels passed through the strait and headed for their destinations. Others



Representational Image

were still in the area.

Iran and affiliated groups have generally avoided targeting ships linked to China, Subasic said, given China's relatively neutral stance and stronger economic ties with Iran.

“The message is more like

do not mistake me for the kind of ship you said you would hit,” said Kun Cao, client director at consulting firm Reddal.

Iranian attacks on vessels in the Persian Gulf and the wider region have particularly raised concerns among shippers.

At least 19 commercial

ships around the region had been damaged in the war as of Thursday.

Most of the eight vessels identified by MarineTraffic were not China flagged. Their flag states included Panama and the Marshall Islands, although Reddal's Cao noted

Highlights

» At least eight vessels in or near the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman changed their declared destination signals to short messages such as CHINA OWNER or CHINA OWNER & CREW

» Some of the vessels possessed through the strait and headed for their destinations

that a vessel's flag often “has little to do with the ship owner's nationality” in commercial shipping.

While many bulk carriers have strong links with China in terms of ownership, operation and cargo, the actual effectiveness of declaring themselves as China-linked in avoiding attacks is unclear, said Rico Luman, a senior economist at the Dutch bank ING who focuses on transport and logistics.

AGENCIES

Trump visa changes squeeze rural schools relying on int'l teachers



US President Donald Trump

hire local teachers to fill the gaps left by several teachers' impending departures. If she can't, she may expand the district's use of online teachers. Elsewhere, districts are considering hiring uncertified instructors, combining classes or dropping course offerings.

In September, the White House announced a \$100,000 fee on H-1B visas, which allow highly skilled foreign workers to be employed in the US. The Trump administration argued American employees were being replaced, particularly in highly paid roles at tech companies. Critics have argued the fee will worsen labor shortages outside of tech. More than 2,300 people with H-1B visas work as educators across 500

school districts, according to an analysis by the National Education Association teachers union. In a December lawsuit challenging the fee, a coalition of 20 states argued that the fees would effectively prevent school districts from hiring international teachers.

The Trump administration has provided a form to request exemptions on the fee, and educators and advocacy groups have argued it's in the public's interest for teachers to be exempted. Teachers also can come to the US on the more common J-1 visa, which allows short-term stays for cultural exchange programs and is not subject to the new fee.

In rural Oregon, the Umatilla School District recruited two teachers from Spain for math and science instruction. The teachers were “phenomenal,” Superintendent Heidi Sipe said, but they returned home in the summer.

“Unfortunately, due to some things at home and then the stress of the unknown, they did choose to go back,” Sipe said. The district did not look for international candidates to replace them because of the cost and uncertainty, but it was able to advertise early and found local candidates for the openings, Sipe said.

AGENCIES

Russian court convicts 19 people over Moscow concert hall attack

MOSCOW: A court in Moscow in Thursday convicted 19 people of involvement in the 2024 shooting rampage in a Moscow concert hall that killed 149 people and wounded over 600 in one of the deadliest attacks in the capital in years.

A faction of the Islamic State group claimed responsibility for the March 22, 2024, massacre at the Crocus City Hall concert venue in which four gunmen shot people who were waiting for a show by a popular rock band and then set the building on fire.

All 19 defendants were handed lengthy prison terms: 15 were sentenced to life in prison, one was handed 22 1/2 years in prison, and three others were given 19 years and 11 months each.

The trial began in August 2025 in a military court, as is customary for terrorism charges, and took place behind closed doors, with the authorities citing security concerns.

President Vladimir Putin and other Russian officials have claimed, without pre-

All 19 defendants were handed lengthy prison terms: 15 were sentenced to life in prison, one was handed 22 1/2 years in prison, and three others were given 19 years and 11 months

senting evidence, that Ukraine had a role in the attack. Kyiv has strongly denied any involvement.

The Investigative Committee, Russia's top criminal investigation agency, has said that the attack had been “planned and carried out in the interests of the current leadership of Ukraine in order to destabilize political situation in our country.” It also noted the four suspected gunmen tried to flee to Ukraine afterward.

AGENCIES

Pak court rejects plea to shift Imran Khan to private hospital

ISLAMABAD: A high court in Pakistan on Thursday rejected a petition to shift jailed former premier Imran Khan to a private medical hospital and ordered the constitution of a team of doctors to medically examine him.

Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf on March 2 filed the petition in Islamabad High Court (IHC) through lawyer Latif Khosa to transfer Khan from Adiala Jail, Rawalpindi, to Shifa International Hospital in Islamabad for treatment of his eyes.

Justice Arbab Muhammad Tahir and Justice Khadim Hussain Soomro heard the case. Khosa presented his arguments while Islamabad Advocate General Ayaz Shaukat and Additional Attorney General Rashid Hafeez appeared on behalf of the government.

Khosa told the court that Khan had been complaining of deteriorating vision in his right eye. Though he was treated at the Pakistan Institute of Medical Sciences (PIMS), his family and legal team were not informed about his medical



Former Pakistan PM Imran Khan

process.

After hearing arguments, the court refused to grant the petition to shift Khan to a private hospital. It, however, directed Islamabad Chief Commissioner Muhammad Ali Randhawa to constitute a medical board to check Khan.

It ordered that Dr Muhammad Arif, who is the head of the ophthalmology department at PIMS and Dr Nadeem Qureshi, who is a retina specialist from Al-Shifa Eye Hospital, Rawalpindi, be on the board.

Khan is believed to be suffering from an ailment in the right eye since October last year and is under treatment.

AGENCIES

‘Pak making efforts to de-escalate tensions in West Asia’

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan on Thursday said that it was playing the role of a bridge builder to help de-escalate the current tensions in West Asia.

“Our principled position on issues with respect to sovereignty, international law and the UN charter and dialogue and diplomacy is

respected in all regional capitals,” Foreign Office Spokesperson Tahir Andrabi told reporters his weekly press briefing here.

“This allows us to exercise a channel of communication between the relevant capitals,” he added.

When asked about

remarks by Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar, who talked of the “shuttling communications” by Pakistan between Tehran and Riyadh to ease tensions, Andrabi responded affirmatively.

“As regards the communication that we may have between Iran, Saudi Arabia,

and other Gulf countries – yes, we have had an open channel of communication,” he said.

“We are playing the role of a bridge builder,” he added. He also said that apart from the exchanges with other countries, Pakistan was also engaging with the US.

AGENCIES

SEEKS ‘SWIFT RESOLUTION’ TO CONFLICT

UK condemns Iran’s ‘reckless’ strikes on neighbours

LONDON: The UK on Thursday strongly condemned Iran for conducting “reckless” strikes on its neighbours in the Gulf, as Foreign Secretary Yvette Cooper landed in Saudi Arabia in a show of solidarity with regional allies in West Asia. The Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) described Saudi Arabia as one of the UK's oldest partners in the region, with established British businesses and tourism.

It condemned the Saudis being subject to attacks from Iranian missiles and drones, with oil facilities and the US Embassy in Riyadh among the targets since the US-Israeli strikes in the region began earlier this month.

“The situation in the Middle East remains highly volatile, and our priority is the safety and security of British people, alongside supporting our partners across the region

who face continuing strikes,” said Cooper. “This is why it is so important for me to be here in Saudi Arabia – an essential partner for the UK in the Gulf, who have been targeted by reckless attacks by the Iranian regime, and who have supported British nationals to come home and is working to maintain energy security and supply. “Everyone wants to see a swift resolution that

brings security and stability back to the region and stops this Iranian threat to its neighbours,” she said. The FCDO said the ministerial visit comes as the British government continues an “intensive, round the clock effort” to support its nationals in the region and safeguard UK interests, including with military support across a volatile and fast-moving situation.

AGENCIES

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice No. 18 of Year 2025-26
Sealed open tenders are invited by Divisional Railway Manager (S&T), N.E. Railway, Izatnagar for and on behalf of the President of India for the following works :- Description of works : 1. Provision of Electronic Interlocking and associated S&T work in connection with provision of Running Line No. 3 at ALJ station of IZN Division. Approx. value : ₹ 3,57,88,711.02, Earnest Money : ₹ 3,29,00,00, Completion Period : 6 Months, Date & Time of closing of e-tender : 06/04/2026 at 11:00 Hrs.
• The tender can be viewed at website <http://www.ireps.gov.in> • All relevant papers must be uploaded at the time of participating in e-tendering.
Sr. Div. Signal & Telecom Engineer CPRO/Sig-114 N.E. Railway, Izatnagar
“Never travel on roof and foot boards”

MP POORV KSHETRA VIDYUT VITARAN CO. LTD.
BLOCK NO.7, SHAKTI BHAWAN, RAMPUR, JABALPUR (M.P.)
Telephone No:0761-2997711,2667808, Extn.270-2473, 270-2541
CIN: U40109MP200255G015120
Jabalpur dtd:- 10.03.2026
TENDER NOTICE
Online Tenders are invited for supply of following item from manufacturers only as per tender specifications by the date indicated below:-

S. No.	T.S. No. DISCOM/EZ/PUR	NAME OF ITEMS	APPROX. VALUE (Rs. in Lakhs)	TENDER FEE	Due date of Opening of Tender online from 17.30 Hrs (*)
1	1668 (Tender Id:- 2026_PKVVC_488741_1)	Differential Protection Relay And Master Trip Relay	57.37	2,360.00	25.03.2026

* For updated/extended due dates for opening of tender (EMD in Cover -1 & Techno-commercial bid in Cover-2) please refer to the online key dates. Other details can be seen in the complete tender documents available on e-portal <https://mptenders.gov.in>.
SAVE ENERGY FOR BETTER TOMORROW C.G.M. (S&P)
“ विद्युत अनियमितता संबंधी शिकायत के लिए वी सिंग ऐप डाउनलोड करें और पाएं ₹. 50,000 तक का इनाम ! ”

सेंट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
Central Bank of India
1911 से आपके लिए “केंद्रित” “CENTRAL” TO YOU SINCE 1911
DWARKA BRANCH, PLOT NO.3, POCKET 2, SECTOR 17, DWARKA, NEW DELHI-110078
POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immoveable Property)
(Under Rule 8(1) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002)
Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the Central Bank of India, Dwarka Branch, New Delhi under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002, and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(2) and 13(12) read with the Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002 issued a Demand Notice dated 20/09/2025, calling upon the **BORROWER:- MR. ABHISHEK SINGH S/O MR. KULBIR KUMAR SINGH**, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being **Rs.19,10,721/- (Rupees Nineteen Lakh Ten Thousand Seven Hundred Twenty One Only)** (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 20/09/2025) plus interest and other charges from 21.09.2025 to till date within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice.
The Borrower having failed to pay the entire dues of the bank, notice is hereby given to the borrower, the Guarantor and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under section 13(4) of the said act, read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule 2002 on this **12th Day of March 2026**.
The borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to charge of **Central Bank of India, Dwarka Branch, New Delhi** for the amount of **Rs.19,10,721/- (Rupees Nineteen Lakh Ten Thousand Seven Hundred Twenty One Only)** (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 20/09/2025), plus interest and other charges from 21.09.2025.
The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.
DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
LIG DDA Flat No.34, Fourth Floor, Block A-6, Pocket - 3, Sector-34, Rohini in DDA Housing Scheme 2014.
DATE: 12/03/2026 **Sd/- (Authorised Officer),**
PLACE: NEW DELHI **Central Bank of India**

GOVERNMENT OF MAHARASHTRA
PUBLIC WORKS DEPARTMENT
Executive Engineer Public Works Division Bhokar, Dist Nanded
E-TENDER NOTICE NO. 26/ 2025-26
Online Tender (e-tender) in B-1 form for the in Nanded District total 05 works are invited by the Executive Engineer, Public Works Division Bhokar, Dist Nanded (Phone No.02467-222658) on Government of Maharashtra Electronic Tender Management System. From the registered contractor in appropriate class of Public works Department of Maharashtra State. The details can be viewed and downloaded online directly from the Government of Maharashtra e-tender portal <https://mahatenders.gov.in> on sub portal www.mahapwd.gov.in as under.
Note: 1) Details of the tender documents are available on e-tendering <https://mahatenders.gov.in/> and www.mahapwd.gov.in website of the Government of Maharashtra.
2) If there are any changes in the tender notice, then the information will be display on the website.
3) Executive Engineer, Public Works Division Bhokar, Dist Nanded has reserved the right to accept or reject tenders.
Executive Engineer Public Works Division Bhokar Dist. Nanded
DGIPR/2025/26/6521

म.प्र. राज्य बीज एवं फार्म विकास निगम
(मध्यप्रदेश शासन का उपक्रम)
(ISO 9001:2015 प्रमाणित संस्था)
बीज भवन, 36, मंदर टोरेसा मार्ग, अंशु हिल्स, भोपाल-462011
फोन : 0755-4137190, E-mail : beejnigamktg@gmail.com
Website : www.mppsfdc.org, GST-23AABCM0088Q1Z8
S.No. HO/MKTG/P.M/01/2026/4958 **Dated : 12.03.2026**
NOTICE INVITING E-TENDER (Second Call)
E-Tenders are invited for supply of following items as per specifications given on the website www.mptenders.gov.in.

S. No.	Description of Goods	Quantity	EMD (In INR)
1.	SBT Jute Bags (Capacity -50 kg)	1,95,000 Nos.	4,25,000/-
2.	Cloth Bags (Capacity-2 Kg)	20,000 Nos.	7000/-
3.	Thiurum 75% DS	130.00 Qtl	97,000/-
4.	Thiurum 75% WS	230.00 Qtl	1,75,000/-
5.	Lead seal	22.00 Qtl	20,000/-

For complete information terms and condition, key dateds and other details please visit our website www.mptenders.gov.in please refer to Tender documents, before participating.
M.P. Madhyam/124886/2026 **MANAGING DIRECTOR**

← KIND ATTENTION RAIL PASSENGERS! →
SPECIAL TRAIN-2026
In order to clear extra rush of rail passengers, Northern Railway has decided to run the Special Train no. 04432 Anand Vihar (T) - Tatanagar Jn. Express as per details given below:-

Train No. 04432 Anand Vihar (T) - Tatanagar Jn. Express Special Train	01 Trip																																																															
<table border="1"><thead><tr><th>STATIONS</th><th>ARR.</th><th>DEP.</th></tr></thead><tbody><tr><td>Anand Vihar (T)</td><td>---</td><td>05:00</td></tr><tr><td>Moradabad</td><td>08:15</td><td>08:25</td></tr><tr><td>Bareilly</td><td>10:10</td><td>10:15</td></tr><tr><td>Lucknow Jn.</td><td>14:20</td><td>14:30</td></tr><tr><td>Sultanpur</td><td>17:10</td><td>17:20</td></tr><tr><td>Varanasi</td><td>21:40</td><td>21:50</td></tr><tr><td>Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Jn.</td><td>22:40</td><td>22:45</td></tr><tr><td>Bhabua Road</td><td>23:24</td><td>23:26</td></tr><tr><td>Sasaram</td><td>23:53</td><td>23:55</td></tr><tr><td>Dehri On Sone</td><td>00:08</td><td>00:10</td></tr><tr><td>Japla</td><td>00:55</td><td>00:57</td></tr><tr><td>Garhwa Road Jn.</td><td>02:30</td><td>02:35</td></tr><tr><td>Daltonganj</td><td>03:13</td><td>03:15</td></tr><tr><td>Barwadih Jn.</td><td>03:43</td><td>03:45</td></tr><tr><td>Latehar</td><td>04:20</td><td>04:22</td></tr><tr><td>Tori</td><td>05:15</td><td>05:17</td></tr><tr><td>Barkakana Jn.</td><td>07:48</td><td>07:50</td></tr><tr><td>Muri Jn.</td><td>08:55</td><td>09:00</td></tr><tr><td>Chandil Jn.</td><td>11:50</td><td>11:55</td></tr><tr><td>Tatanagar Jn.</td><td>13:00</td><td>---</td></tr></tbody></table>	STATIONS	ARR.	DEP.	Anand Vihar (T)	---	05:00	Moradabad	08:15	08:25	Bareilly	10:10	10:15	Lucknow Jn.	14:20	14:30	Sultanpur	17:10	17:20	Varanasi	21:40	21:50	Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Jn.	22:40	22:45	Bhabua Road	23:24	23:26	Sasaram	23:53	23:55	Dehri On Sone	00:08	00:10	Japla	00:55	00:57	Garhwa Road Jn.	02:30	02:35	Daltonganj	03:13	03:15	Barwadih Jn.	03:43	03:45	Latehar	04:20	04:22	Tori	05:15	05:17	Barkakana Jn.	07:48	07:50	Muri Jn.	08:55	09:00	Chandil Jn.	11:50	11:55	Tatanagar Jn.	13:00	---	
STATIONS	ARR.	DEP.																																																														
Anand Vihar (T)	---	05:00																																																														
Moradabad	08:15	08:25																																																														
Bareilly	10:10	10:15																																																														
Lucknow Jn.	14:20	14:30																																																														
Sultanpur	17:10	17:20																																																														
Varanasi	21:40	21:50																																																														
Pt. Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Jn.	22:40	22:45																																																														
Bhabua Road	23:24	23:26																																																														
Sasaram	23:53	23:55																																																														
Dehri On Sone	00:08	00:10																																																														
Japla	00:55	00:57																																																														
Garhwa Road Jn.	02:30	02:35																																																														
Daltonganj	03:13	03:15																																																														
Barwadih Jn.	03:43	03:45																																																														
Latehar	04:20	04:22																																																														
Tori	05:15	05:17																																																														
Barkakana Jn.	07:48	07:50																																																														
Muri Jn.	08:55	09:00																																																														
Chandil Jn.	11:50	11:55																																																														
Tatanagar Jn.	13:00	---																																																														

DAY OF RUN: 04432 Ex. Anand Vihar (T) on 16.03.2026 (Monday).
ACCOMMODATION: AC 2 Tier, AC 3 Tier, AC 3 Tier Economy, Sleeper & General.
For any kind of information, passengers are requested to contact RailMadad Helpline No. 139 or visit Indian Railways website <https://enquiry.indianrail.gov.in> or NTES App.
837/2026 Please join us on
NORTHERN RAILWAY
Your Convenience - Our Concern
Visit us at : www.nr.indianrailways.gov.in
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

GOVERNMENT OF WEST BENGAL
NEW TOWN KOLKATA DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
NOTICE INVITING e-TENDER
Nle-Q No. WBNKDA/01/EE-(WD and S)/NKDA OF 2025-26
Tr. ID No. 2026_NKDA_1021642_1
The Executive Engineer – (W&D&S), New Town Kolkata Development Authority invites online Item Rate e-Quotation, from the eligible contractors for the work “Supply and delivery of various items of Stationeries, execution of printing jobs and other items for Office use of NKDA for 1 (One) year.”. For details please visit websites : <http://wbenders.gov.in> and www.nkdamar.org
Sd/- Executive Engineer – (WD&S) N. K. D. A.

महाप्रदेश शासन
उपसंचालक, क्रीडा व युवक सेवा, कोल्हापूर विभाग, कोल्हापूर कार्यालय
श्री.छत्रपती संभाजी महाराज, विभागीय क्रीडा संकुल, कोल्हापूर-४१६०१२
शुटींग रेंज खोली क्र १, रस्सकोई नाका संभाजी नगर, कोल्हापूर * फोन : ०२३१-२९५११०८, ईमेल : dyckop@gmail.com**
ई-निविदा सूचना
विभागीय उपसंचालक, क्रीडा व युवक सेवा, कोल्हापूर विभाग यांचेद्वारे विभागीय स्पोर्ट्स एक्सलन्स सेंटर तसेच जिल्हास्तरावर जिल्हास्तर अनिवासी क्रीडा प्रतिभा विकास केंद्र यांजर्तर्गत खालील प्रमाणे निविदा मागविण्यात येत आहेत.
१. विभागीय स्पोर्ट्स एक्सलन्स सेंटर तसेच जिल्हास्तरावर जिल्हास्तर अनिवासी क्रीडा प्रतिभा विकास केंद्र प्रशिक्षणार्थींना क्रीडा प्रशिक्षण देण्यासाठी ब्राह्मचर्य एजन्सीद्वारे क्रीडा मार्गदर्शक, नेटान सेवक व कार्यालयीन कर्मचारी पुरविणे २.विभागीय स्पोर्ट्स एक्सलन्स सेंटर अंतर्गत प्रशिक्षणार्थींच्या भोजन पुरवठा करणे
बरील दोन स्वतंत्र निविदा खुल्या स्पर्धात्मक पद्धतीने ऑनलाईन ई-निविदा मागविण्यात येत असून निविदा कायदपत्र शासनाच्या संकेतस्थळावर <http://mahatenders.gov.in> येथून डाऊनलोड करण्यात यावी. तसेच निविदा स्वीकारण्याचा अथवा नाकारण्याचा अधिकार विभागीय उपसंचालक, क्रीडा व युवक सेवा, कोल्हापूर विभाग यांनी राखून ठेवला आहे. निविदा ऑनलाईन सादर करवयाची आहे आणि निविदा सादर करणाऱ्या कालावधि दि.१३ ते दि. ३० मार्च, २०२६ रोजी सायं ५.०० वाजेपर्यंत आहे.
(सुहास पाटील)
उपसंचालक
क्रीडा व युवक सेवा, कोल्हापूर विभाग
दि. ६.३.२०२६
क्र.उपसं/मिशनलस्वथेच/निविदा/२०२५-२६/
DGIPR/2025/26/6504

AMID SHARP RISE IN CRUDE OIL PRICES

Markets tumble for 2nd day in row, Sensex falls over 800 pts

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: Benchmark equity indices ended with deep cuts on Thursday, with the Sensex tumbling over 800 points amid a sharp rise in crude oil prices due to the heightening crisis in West Asia.

Besides, sluggish global market trends, weakness in the rupee and persistent foreign capital outflows also rattled investor sentiment, analysts said.

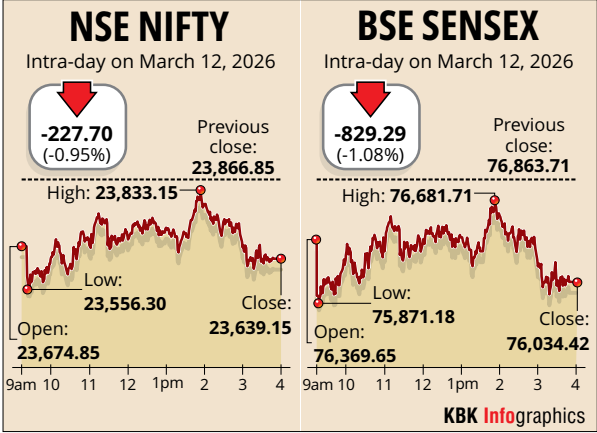
In a volatile session, the 30-share BSE Sensex tanked 829.29 points, or 1.08 per cent, to settle at 76,034.42. During the day, it plunged 992.53 points or 1.29 per cent to 75,871.18.

A total of 2,516 stocks declined, while 1,713 advanced and 175 remained unchanged on the BSE.

Similarly, the 50-share NSE Nifty fell 227.70 points, or 0.95 per cent, to close at 23,639.15.

The market capitalisation of BSE-listed companies eroded by Rs 23,44,237.26 crore to Rs 4,40,06,434.01 crore (\$4.77 trillion).

Mahindra & Mahindra was the biggest loser among the Sensex constituents, dropping 4.23 per cent, followed by Maruti, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, UltraTech Cement and Trent.



Among BSE sectoral indices, auto tanked 2.92%, FMCG (1.62%), consumer discretionary (1.59%), realty (1.53%), pvt banks (1.45%) and top 10 banks (1.29%)

In contrast, NTPC, Power Grid, Tech Mahindra, HCL Tech and Reliance Industries were the winners.

The BSE smallcap select index declined 0.65 per cent, and the midcap select index dipped 0.55 per cent.

Among BSE sectoral indices, auto tanked 2.92 per cent, FMCG (1.62 per cent), consumer discretionary (1.59 per cent), realty (1.53 per cent), private banks index (1.45 per cent) and top 10 banks (1.29 per cent).

On the other hand, utilities jumped 3.31 per cent, power (2.51 per cent), energy (1.06 per cent), capital goods (0.55 per cent), oil & gas (0.52 per cent) and metal (0.45 per cent).

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, jumped 4.78 per cent to \$96.47 per barrel.

In Asian markets, South Korea's Kospi, Japan's Nikkei 225, Shanghai's SSE Composite index and Hong Kong's Hang Seng index ended lower.

European markets were quoting in negative territory.

Key Points

- » A total of 2,516 stocks fell, 1,713 advanced and 175 remained unchanged on the BSE
- » The mcap of BSE-listed cos eroded by Rs 23,44,237.26 crore to Rs 4,40,06,434.01 crore (\$4.77 trillion)
- » From Sensex pack, M&M was biggest loser, followed by Maruti, Bajaj Finance, L&T, UltraTech & Trent
- » NTPC, Power Grid, Tech Mahindra, HCL Tech and Reliance Industries were among the winners

The US market ended mostly lower on Wednesday. Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 6,267.31 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

Domestic Institutional Investors (DII) bought stocks worth Rs 4,965.53 crore.

On Wednesday, the Sensex tumbled 1,342.27 points or 1.72 per cent to settle at 76,863.71. The Nifty tanked 394.75 points or 1.63 per cent to end at 23,866.85.

Rupee falls 24 paise to 92.25 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee touched a fresh intra-day low on Thursday and closed the session 24 paise down at its lowest level of 92.25 against the US dollar, dragged down by elevated crude oil prices and massive withdrawal of foreign capital.

The rupee, caught in the crossfire amid the raging West Asia war, was weighed down by heavy selling in domestic equity markets and a strengthening greenback, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the local unit opened at 92.25 and hit its lowest intra-day level of 92.36 against the greenback.

The unit ended the session at its lowest level of 92.25 against the dollar, registering a loss of 24 paise.

The dollar index, which gauges the greenback's strength against a basket of six currencies, was trading 0.15 per cent higher at 99.38.

NSE appoints 8 law firms & 20 merchant bankers for its IPO

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) has appointed 20 merchant bankers, along with several law firms and other intermediaries, to manage its initial public offering (IPO), making a step towards its much-awaited listing.

The exchange's IPO committee, chaired by Srinivas Injeti, approved the appointments at a meeting held on Thursday.

The development follows the NSE board's decision in February to proceed with its long-pending public listing. The proposed IPO will consist entirely of an offer-for-sale (OFS) by existing shareholders, with no fresh issue of shares.

In a statement, NSE said the selection of intermediaries was carried out through a "structured, transparent and competitive process" based on an evaluation framework approved by the IPO committee.

The 20 merchant bankers appointed include Kotak Mahindra Capital Company, JM Financial, Axis Capital, IIFL Capital Services, Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors, ICICI Securities, SBI Capital Markets, Nuvama Wealth Management, HDFC Bank, Avendus Capital, Morgan Stanley India Company, Citigroup Global Markets India, J.P. Morgan India, HSBC Securities and Capital Markets (India), IDBI Capital Markets & Securities, 360 ONE WAM, Anand Rath Advisors, DAM Capital Advisors, Pantomath



The exchange's IPO committee, chaired by Srinivas Injeti, approved the appointments at a meeting held on Thursday

Capital Advisors and Equirus Capital.

Eight law firms have also been selected for the issue — Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas, Khaitan & Co, Latham & Watkins LLP, Sidley Austin Singapore Pte. Ltd., AZB & Partners, S&R Associates, Shardul Amarchand Mangaldas & Co and Trilegal.

Other intermediaries appointed include MUFG Intime India, Makarand M Joshi & Company, Manian & Rao, RBSA Advisors, Concept Communication and Redseer Strategy Consultants.

According to the exchange, these intermediaries will assist in regulatory filings, due diligence, documentation, marketing and execution of the proposed public issue, in line with applicable regulations.

Highlights

- » The development follows the NSE board's decision in February to proceed with its long-pending public listing
- » The proposed IPO will consist entirely of an OFS by existing shareholders, with no fresh issue of shares
- » In January, the Sebi granted an NOC, allowing the exchange to move ahead with its listing plans after over a decade of delays

With the completion of this process, the mandate of Rothschild & Co India as process advisor for the selection and appointment of NSE's IPO intermediaries has concluded.

In January, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) granted a no-objection certificate (NOC), allowing the exchange to move ahead with its listing plans after more than a decade of delays.

NSE had first filed draft offer documents in 2016 to raise about Rs 10,000 crore through an offer-for-sale by existing shareholders. However, Sebi had withheld approval following governance concerns and the co-location case. Since then, the exchange approached the regulator multiple times seeking clearance.

'Govt clears 104 projects worth ₹271 cr for 6G tech research'

NEW DELHI: The government has approved 104 projects worth Rs 271 crore for research and development of 6G Technology under the Telecom Technology Development Fund, Parliament was informed on Thursday.

In a written reply to the Rajya Sabha, Minister of State for Telecom Chandra Sekhar Pemmasani said the government released the Bharat 6G Vision Document in March 2023, outlining India's roadmap for research, development and deployment of 6G technologies with the objective of positioning India among global leaders in 6G by 2030.

He said the government has taken several measures under the Bharat 6G Mission to promote indigenous innovation and participation of Indian startups.

"As of February 2026, under the Telecom Technology Development Fund (TTDF), 104 projects amounting to Rs 271 Crore have been approved for research and development of 6G technology," the minister said.

Pemmasani said the government has also established 100 5G Use Case Labs in academic institutions across the country to enable students, researchers and startups to develop and test applications, building skills and capabilities for future 6G networks.

'CAG's BSNL loss estimate from RJIL deal misinterpreted, rectified now'

'The estimate of CAG was based on misinterpretation of clause of add-on technology,' MoS Telecom said

NEW DELHI: The CAG's estimate that the government has suffered revenue loss due to non-implementation of an agreement with Reliance Jio was based on a misinterpretation of a clause, and the error has been rectified now, Minister of State for Telecom Pemmasani Chandra Sekhar said on Thursday.

The Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG), in a report last year, had said that the state-run firm BSNL failed to enforce the master service agreement (MSA) with Reliance Jio Infocomm Ltd (RJIL) and did not bill for the additional technology used on BSNL's shared passive infrastructure, resulting in loss of Rs



1,757.76 crore and penal interest thereon, between May 2014 to March 2024 to the government exchequer.

The minister, in a written reply to the Rajya Sabha, said BSNL has an MSA with RJIL for leasing of BSNL's tower infrastructure to install their equipment.

"There is no revenue loss to BSNL and the government.

The estimate of CAG was based on the misinterpretation of the clause of add-on technology, which has now been rectified in a transparent and equitable manner. BSNL has since raised the revised invoices from RJIL, Pemmasani said.

The minister's actions have been taken to recover losses, resolving the ambiguity in agreement clauses, monetisation of surplus inventory, issuance of revised demands, and preventing the recurrence of lapses in the functioning of BSNL. "Further, PSUs have been advised to timely process bills and be extra cautious while taking policy/business decisions," he said.

Mandatory gold hallmarking expanded to 7 more districts

NEW DELHI: The mandatory hallmarking of gold jewellery and gold artifacts has been expanded to seven more districts under the sixth phase, taking to 380 districts across India, the government said on Thursday.

The seven districts are: Rupnagar (Punjab), Banda (Uttar Pradesh), Beed (Maharashtra), Gomati (Tripura), Katihar (Bihar), Beawar (Rajasthan) and Neemuch (Madhya Pradesh), an official statement said.

Mandatory gold hallmarking for 14, 18, 20, 22, 23 and 24 carat gold jewellery and artefacts in India was launched by the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) on June 23, 2021, starting with 256 districts.



The roll-out has progressed in phases. Phase 2 (April 2022) added 32 districts, Phase 3 (September 2023) covered 55 more, Phase 4 (November 2024) added 18 districts, and Phase 5 (July 2025) included 12 districts, reaching 373 districts.

As of March 5 this year, 60 crore gold items were hallmarking for consumer protection, the statement added.

Silver prices gain ₹1,500 to ₹2.76L per kg amid firm global trends

NEW DELHI: Silver prices gained Rs 1,500 to Rs 2.76 lakh per kilogram in the national capital on Thursday amid firm global trends and intensifying West Asia crisis.

According to the All India Sarafa Association, the white metal climbed by Rs 1,500, or 0.54 per cent, to Rs 2,76,500 per kilogram (inclusive of all taxes). It had closed at Rs 2,75,000 per kg, down by Rs 4,275 on Wednesday.

Prices of gold of 99.9 per cent purity retreated Rs 400, ending a three-day rally, to Rs 1,65,200 per 10 grams (inclusive of all taxes) from the previous close of Rs 1,65,600 per 10 grams.

Analysts said gold and silver moved in opposite directions as investors weighed geopolitical developments and macroeconomic signals from the United States.

Gold prices slid slightly, reflecting a minor decline amid a firmer dollar and persistent inflation concerns, while silver showed resilience as traders reacted to potential buying opportunities amid geopolitical tensions related to the US-Iran situation, Gaurav Garg, Research Analyst at Lemonn Markets Desk, said.

Meanwhile, in the international markets, spot silver gained \$1.25 or 1.47 per cent to \$86.99 per ounce, and gold

traded marginally higher at \$5,178.45 per ounce.

"Spot gold continues to trade inversely to crude oil prices. The metal is trading in the narrow band of \$5,100-5,250 per ounce," Praveen Singh, Research Analyst, Mirae Asset ShareKhan, said.

According to Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, investors are awaiting cues from the US Core Personal Consumption Expenditures (PCE) price index, along with GDP numbers to be released on Friday, which could influence expectations around the Federal Reserve's rate outlook.



vivors of deceased investors.

Under the proposed framework, a verifiable death certificate may include the original document, a copy verified by the nominee, one attested by a notary public or gazetted officer, or a certificate carrying a QR code. A legal heirship certificate must be issued by a revenue authority not below the rank of a Tehsildar.

The regulator also proposed new limits for simplified processing. The STP mechanism would apply to claims of up to

WhatsApp launches new 'parent-managed' account model for under 13 children

NEW DELHI: Meta-owned WhatsApp has unveiled a new "parent-managed" account model, effectively opening the messaging platform to pre-teens (children under the age of 13) under strict guardian oversight.

The move marks a strategic shift for the messaging app, which has historically maintained a minimum age requirement of 13 (or higher in some regions). "With input from families and experts, we're rolling out new parent-managed accounts that allow parents or guardians to set

up WhatsApp for pre-teens, with new controls to limit their WhatsApp experience to messaging and calling," WhatsApp said in a blog post.

WhatsApp said that while parents can control the contact list, the content of the messages will remain protected by end-to-end encryption.

The new parental controls and settings will be gated by a parent PIN on the managed device, and only parents will be able to access and change privacy settings.

The feature is currently being rolled out in phases.

China silent on India's move to ease FDI norms, Chinese businesses say 'partial' opening

China's state-run Xinhua News Agency said India's announcement was seen as a major shift in its FDI policy after a gap of nearly six years

BEIJING: China has refrained from commenting on India's decision to ease foreign direct investment (FDI) norms for entities with minority shareholders from countries sharing land borders with it, while Chinese businesses described the move as only a "partial" opening.

India on Tuesday relaxed FDI rules by allowing overseas companies with up to 10 per cent beneficial ownership from land-bordering countries to invest in India without mandatory government approval. Earlier, even a single share held by investors from such coun-

tries required approval before investments could be made in any sector. Other FDI conditions, including sectoral caps and entry routes, will continue to apply.

China's state-run Xinhua News Agency said the move represents a major shift in India's investment policy after nearly six years. However, the Chinese Foreign Ministry declined to comment on the development. At a media briefing, spokesperson Guo Jiakun said the matter should be addressed by the relevant authorities.

China is currently grappling with overcapacity in sev-



eral manufacturing sectors, particularly in EVs and battery production, which have saturated the domestic market and increasingly depend on overseas demand. Given the size of the Indian market, there are expectations in China for

CLOSER LOOK

- » China is grappling with overcapacity in manufacturing sectors, particularly in EVs & battery production
- » There are expectations in China for broader market access for EVs, batteries and related industries
- » 'Large-scale investments and projects involving control by Chinese entities will still require government approval'

broader market access for EVs, batteries and related industries. Clarifying the policy change, Joint Secretary in the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade, Jai Prakash Shivahare, said restrictions on direct investors

from land-bordering countries remain unchanged. The relaxation applies only to overseas entities based in non-bordering countries where beneficial ownership from land-bordering nations is below 10 per cent and non-controlling.

Chinese experts and businesses told the state-run Global Times that the adjustment could allow greater Chinese investment in sectors such as solar energy and electronics, benefiting related industries in India. They also urged New Delhi to further ease investment curbs to strengthen bilateral economic cooperation, which has been gradually recovering since 2024.

The Chamber of Chinese Enterprises in India described the policy shift as a "partial optimisation" rather than comprehensive liberalisation, noting that large-scale investments and projects involving control by

Chinese entities will still require government approval.

According to the chamber, the fast-track approval mechanism allowing clearances within 60 days is limited to a few sectors such as electronic components and polysilicon and does not represent a broad relaxation across industries.

Most Chinese investments will continue to face strict scrutiny & the actual implementation of the revised policy remains uncertain. Analysts say India is seeking to expand sectors such as mobile manufacturing, semiconductors, AI and new-energy vehicles, which rely

significantly on Chinese technology and expertise.

However, the opening remains selective.

Qian Feng of Tsinghua University's National Strategy Institute said improving ties since the leaders of India and China met in Kazan in 2024 make the policy revision timely.

Relations between the two nations deteriorated sharply after the Galwan Valley clash in June 2020. Following which, India banned over 200 Chinese mobile apps, including TikTok and WeChat, and rejected a major investment proposal from EV maker BYD.

US starts Section 301 probe against India, 15 other economies: Explainer

The probe targets policies and industrial practices of 16 economies

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The US Trade Representative (USTR) on March 11 said it has launched a fresh round of Section 301 trade investigations targeting policies and industrial practices of 16 economies, including India and China.

Following a decision of the US Supreme Court striking down sweeping tariffs of the Trump administration, US President Donald Trump has announced 10 per cent tariffs on all countries for 150 days from February 24. Now, initiation of this probe marks a significant escalation in trade scrutiny. Here are a few questions and answers to understand the issue.

WHAT IS THIS INVESTIGATION?

The United States Trade Representative (USTR) has announced that it has initiated investigations against its trading partners, including India, China, Japan, and the European Union (EU), to look into and address unfair foreign practices that are adversely affecting American manufacturing.

The probe targets policies and industrial practices of 16 economies.

The probe covers sectors, including steel, aluminum, automobiles, batteries, electronics, chemicals, machinery, semi-



USTR announced that it has initiated investigations against its trading partners to look into and address unfair foreign practices that are adversely affecting American manufacturing

conductors, and solar modules. **WHICH 16 ECONOMIES ARE COVERED UNDER THE PROBE?**

There are 15 countries and the 27-nation EU bloc. The nations are China, Singapore, Switzerland, Norway, Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Thailand, South Korea, Vietnam, Taiwan, Bangladesh, Mexico, Japan, and India.

WHY THIS PROBE? After the US Supreme Court struck down tariffs imposed by

Highlights

» Under Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974, the US govt may investigate whether foreign trade practices are unreasonable or discriminatory and harm American commerce

» 'The US investigation identifies several sectors in India where structural excess capacity/export surpluses may exist'

» 'These include solar modules, petrochemicals, steel, textiles, health-related goods, construction materials & automotive products'

the Trump administration. On February 20, Trump signed a proclamation to impose a temporary import duty of 10 per cent on all countries to replace the tariffs invalidated by the Court. After that, the President had stated that the US has other alternatives to impose such levies.

On February 20, a White House Fact Sheet stated that the President has directed the Office of the USTR to use its Section 301 authority to inves-

tigate certain unreasonable and discriminatory acts, policies, and practices that burden or restrict US commerce.

WHAT IS THE INVESTIGATION PROCESS?

Under Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974, the US government may investigate whether foreign trade practices are unreasonable or discriminatory and harm American commerce. The investigations will determine whether those acts, policies, and practices are unreasonable or discriminatory and burden or restrict US commerce.

"The probe will examine whether policies such as industrial subsidies, state-supported manufacturing expansion, activities of state-owned enterprises, market-access barriers, currency practices or suppressed domestic demand have contributed to global manufacturing overcapacity that burdens US commerce, think tank GTRI said.

If such practices are confirmed, Washington may impose retaliatory trade measures, including additional tariffs, quantitative restrictions or other trade barriers.

According to the GTRI, as per a defined process, public dockets for written submissions will open on March 17, allowing companies, trade groups and

governments to submit their comments on the probe.

Written submissions and requests to participate in hearings must be filed by April 15. Public hearings will take place from May 5-8 at the US International Trade Commission in Washington.

Rebuttal submissions must be filed within seven days after the hearings conclude. After consultations with the governments concerned, the USTR will determine whether the practices under investigation warrant retaliatory action.

WHAT DOES THIS MEAN FOR INDIA?

The Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) stated that the US investigation identifies several sectors in India where structural excess capacity or export surpluses may exist. These include solar modules, petrochemicals, steel, textiles, health-related goods, construction materials and automotive products.

According to the US notice, India's solar-module manufacturing capacity is already nearly three times domestic demand, suggesting the possibility of export-driven production surpluses. Similar concerns are raised about expanding capacity in petrochemicals and steel, GTRI Founder Ajay Srivastava said.

Exporters seek priority allocation of natural gas, LPG for export units

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Exporters' body FIEO on Thursday urged the government to allocate LPG and natural gas to export-oriented manufacturing units on a priority basis, as any disruptions in the fuel availability will create problems in maintaining production schedules.

Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO) President S C Ralhan said that he has written a letter in this regard to the Commerce and Industry Ministry.

"Manufacturing exporters are facing issues. There is an urgent need for priority allocation of LPG/natural gas as fuel for export-oriented units (EOUs) and export-oriented SMEs," Ralhan said.

The West Asia crisis, triggered by the launch of a joint attack by the US and Israel on Iran, has disrupted energy supplies in several countries. The government has revised the priority order for allocating domestically produced natural gas, placing LPG production alongside CNG and piped cooking gas at the top.

He said that export-oriented manufacturing units are operating in a highly competitive global environment and are constantly competing with suppliers from countries such as China and other East Asian economies.

Large global buyers follow highly structured global sourcing models and require uninterrupted production and timely deliveries from their suppliers.



"In the event of disruption in fuel availability, Indian exporters are unable to maintain production schedules. Consequently, international buyers are compelled to shift their orders to competing countries, particularly China," FIEO said in a communication to the commerce ministry.

In this context, the availability of LPG/natural gas as an industrial fuel is critical, particularly for export-oriented SMEs and EOUs that rely on it for their manufacturing processes, it added.

"We fully appreciate that the present gas supply situation is challenging. However, even through a calibrated mechanism, a dedicated priority allocation for export-oriented industries would help ensure that production and export commitments are not adversely affected," Ralhan said.

He added that ensuring fuel availability will not only protect existing export orders but will also reinforce international confidence in India as a reliable

sourcing destination. Sharing similar views, Jalandhar-based Hand Tools Manufacturers and Exporters Association President Ashwani Kumar said that due to the present constraints in LPG supplies, production activities are facing serious disruptions.

"In this regard, we humbly request your kind approval for 425 kg LPG per day for our production line operations and 19-kg commercial LPG cylinders for factory mess and canteen to provide meals to workers and staff," Kumar said.

Considering the present policy for prioritising essential non-domestic LPG requirements, he requested the Centre to treat their requirement as urgent and grant approval for regulated supply through the nearest PSU oil marketing firms.

"An early approval will greatly help us maintain production continuity, protect employment of workers and meet our industrial commitments," he added.

DFS secretary holds meeting with NBFCs



Financial Services Secretary M Nagaraju

NEW DELHI: Financial Services Secretary M Nagaraju on Thursday chaired a meeting with major non-banking financial companies (NBFCs), the Finance Ministry said.

"The engagement with NBFCs was designed to foster an open exchange of ideas on targeted points. Detailed discussion with representatives from the Reserve Bank of India, DoR and UIDAI on issues concerning their area of operation was deliberated upon," the statement said.

The emphasis was on reaching a solution on issues being faced by NBFCs through stakeholder consultation, it added.

During the meeting, NBFCs shared their concerns and solutions.

Nagaraju emphasised that NBFCs need to be more robust, vibrant and financially sound, catering to the needs of underserved and new to credit customers, the ministry said.

He further advised holding a workshop with UIDAI and NPCI to educate NBFCs on the use of KYC effectively. PTI

About 6,600 MW nuclear capacity under construction in the country

'India's current nuclear capacity is over 8,780 MW'

NEW DELHI: Around 6,600 megawatt nuclear capacity is under construction, and another 7,000 megawatt is under various stages of planning and approval, Power Minister Manohar Lal said on Thursday.

The minister also said that 12,723.50 MW of hydroelectric projects are under construction.

Further, 4,274 megawatt (MW) of hydroelectric projects are under various stages of planning and targeted to be completed by 2031-32, he said in a written reply to the Lok Sabha.

For nuclear, Lal said 6,600 MW of nuclear capacity is under construction and targeted to be completed by 2029-30. 7,000 MW of nuclear capacity



is under various stages of planning and approval.

As per official data, India's current nuclear capacity is over 8,780 MW.

In energy storage systems, 11,620 MW/69,720 MWh Pumped Storage Projects (PSPs) are under construction.

A total of 6,580 MW/39,480 MWh capacity of Pumped Storage Projects (PSPs) is con-

cluded and yet to be taken up for construction.

Currently, 9,653.94 MW/26,729.32 MWh Battery Energy Storage System (BESS) capacity is under construction, and 19,797.65 MW/61,013.40 MWh BESS capacity are under tendering stage.

In a separate reply, Minister of State for Power Shripad Naik informed the House that India added 52,536.49 MW installed generation capacity in the current financial year, FY 2025-26 (till January 2026).

As of January 31, the total installed generation capacity is 5,20,511 MW, of which the share of renewable energy sources was 2,63,189 MW (50.6 per cent). PTI

ED attaches fresh ₹581 cr assets in case against Reliance Group

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate on Thursday said it has attached fresh assets worth more than Rs 581 crore as part of its investigation against RHFL and RCFL, companies of Reliance Group Chairman Anil Ambani.

A provisional order was issued under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) on March 11 to attach land parcels in Goa, Kerala, Karnataka, Punjab, Tamil Nadu, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Jharkhand, Maharashtra, Delhi, West Bengal, Andhra Pradesh and Rajasthan, the Enforcement Directorate (ED) said in a statement.

The properties are worth Rs 581.65 crore, and they have been attached as part of a probe related to the Reliance Home Finance Limited (RHFL) and

Reliance Commercial Finance Limited (RCFL), the agency said. "The attachment follows search operations conducted on March 6 in the case against Reliance Power Limited under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA)," it said.

The ED had attached assets of Anil Ambani's Reliance Group earlier as well.

"The cumulative Reliance Anil Ambani Group attachment has reached Rs 16,310 crore," the ED said.

The probe stems from a CBI FIR filed against RCFL and RHFL based on complaints lodged by Yes Bank, Union Bank of India and Bank of Maharashtra.

It is alleged that the two companies raised public funds from multiple banks and financial institutions, and more than

Rs 11,000 crore of these funds turned into non-performing assets, the ED said.

The agency said public funds raised by RHFL and RCFL were "diverted" to various Reliance Group companies, such as Reliance Infrastructure Limited, Reliance Power Limited, Reliance Communications Limited, Reliance Capital Limited, etc.

The funds were diverted by routing them through a large number of shell (dummy) entities controlled and managed by the Reliance Anil Ambani Group, it alleged. "These shell entities had negligible financial strength and no business operations," it said.

According to the ED, its investigation found "mala fide intent" on the part of the group promoters and key persons. PTI

Akzo Nobel India gets MCA's nod to change name to JSW Dulux

NEW DELHI: Paints and coatings maker Akzo Nobel India, in which JSW Paints has acquired majority shares, has received approval from Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) to change its name to JSW Dulux.

The MCA has approved the name change and granted a fresh Certificate of Incorporation with new name JSW Dulux, the company said in a regulatory filing.

"We wish to inform you that MCA has issued a fresh Certificate of Incorporation pursuant to change of name (dated 11th March 2026) thereby approving the change of name of the company from 'Akzo Nobel India Ltd' to 'JSW Dulux Ltd' effective 11th March 2026," it said.

Following this, the Memorandum of Association and Articles of Association of the company stand consequently amended and altered to reflect the new name of the company as "JSW Dulux Ltd", it added.

On December 10, 2025, JSW Paints, part of the \$23 billion JSW Group, acquired 60.76 per cent stake in Akzo Nobel pursuant to the share purchase agreement between JSW Paints, Imperial Chemicals Industries Ltd and Akzo Nobel Coatings International BV. Pursuant to that, JSW Paints has become Akzo Nobel's promoter & holding firm. PTI

Adani Foundation announces expansion of its flagship Swabhimaan initiative to empower 10 lakh women

First phase of expansion will focus on Maharashtra, to empower one lakh women within 1st year

MUMBAI: Adani Foundation, the social welfare arm of Adani Group, has announced a major expansion of its women's empowerment initiative Swabhimaan, aiming to enable 10 lakh women entrepreneurs across India as it approaches its 30th anniversary on August 11, 2026.

The announcement was made at the "Swabhimaan - The Rise of She" event held at the National Centre for the Performing Arts in Mumbai. The first phase of the expansion will focus on Maharash-



tra, where the programme aims to empower one lakh women

within the first year by promoting women-led micro-

enterprises and grassroots entrepreneurship.

Launched in partnership with Mahila Arthik Vikas Mahamandal (MAVIM), the state government's nodal agency for women's economic empowerment, the programme has already supported over 4,500 women from underserved communities in Mumbai through skill training, entrepreneurship development, and financial and digital literacy.

The event was attended by Dr Priti Adani and Shilini Adani of the Adani Foundation, along

with Maharashtra Women and Child Development Minister Aditi Tatkare, Mumbai Mayor Ritu Tawde and MAVIM Managing Director Nandini Awade.

The dignitaries also inaugurated Swateja Mart, a women-led marketplace providing training and sales platforms, and a cloud kitchen under the initiative.

The programme has already helped more than 800 women in Mumbai become "Lakshpati Didis", highlighting its impact on livelihoods and financial independence. MPOST

Kerala CM lays foundation stone for Marine Eco City project in Kochi

NEW DELHI/KOCHI: Pinarayi Vijayan, Chief Minister of Kerala, on Thursday virtually laid the foundation stone for the Marine Eco City Project at Marine Drive, Kochi.

The event, held at the KTDC Convention Centre, Bolgatty in Kochi, was attended by Revenue and Housing Minister K Rajan, Rajya Sabha MP P P Suneer, MLA T J Vinod, Housing Commissioner and Secretary of Kerala State Housing Board (KSHB) Geetha A, Kochi District Collector G Priyanka, Director (Commercial) of NBCC (India) Limited Dr Suman Kumar, KSHB Board Member Subhash Punjakottil and Technical Member V



Unnikrishnan, along with senior officials from KSHB and NBCC.

A memorandum of understanding for the project was signed between KSHB and NBCC in 2023. The development will come up near the BPCL housing complex at Marine Drive. NBCC is asso-

ciated with the project as the project management consultant (PMC) for implementation on an EPC basis.

Conceived as a self-sustainable urban development model, the Project is to be developed in three phases for KSHB on 17.9 acres of prime waterfront land. MPOST

Sticking to glory

WC berth secured, India now eye title triumph in women's WC qualifiers

HYDERABAD: Already assured of a World Cup berth, India would aim for the winners' trophy at the FIH Women's Hockey World Cup Qualifiers and take a step forward in that direction by winning the semifinal against Italy here on Friday.

The Indian women's hockey team finished on top of Pool B with seven points from three matches. Scotland also collected same points but finished second in the group because of India's superior goal difference.

The hosts registered two wins and one draw in the pool stage.

Italy finished second in Pool A with four points after registering one win, one draw and one loss, giving the hosts a slight psychological edge ahead of the semifinal.

India will look to build on the impressive form of forward Navneet Kaur, who is currently the joint top-scorer of the tournament with four goals. She produced a standout performance in the final pool match against Wales, scoring a brilliant hat-trick to cap off the group stage in style.

Italy, meanwhile, will rely on Federica Carta, who has been their key attacking threat and has scored three goals so far in the competition.



India hold a major advantage over the Italians in terms of their head-to-head record

FILE

On paper and form, India hold a major advantage over Italy.

In terms of head-to-head encounters, India and Italy have faced each other seven times since 2012. India have won five of those matches, while Italy have registered one victory and one game ended in a draw, giving the hosts a slight psychological edge.

India's chief coach Sjoerd Marijne, who is back at the

helm after the Tokyo Olympics, termed the achievement as a significant milestone.

"Securing qualification for the FIH Hockey Women's World Cup 2026 is an important milestone for this group, and the players deserve a lot of credit for the way they have performed so far in the tournament," he said. "They have shown good discipline, composure and attacking intent throughout the pool stage.

"At the same time, our mindset is very clear -- we are not here just to qualify. We want to keep improving with every match and aim to win the tournament. The semifinal is another big challenge and we will approach it with full focus and intensity."

The Dutchman, however, cautioned his wards to take Italy lightly. "Italy are a competitive side and they have shown in this tournament that they



“
Our mindset is very clear -- we are not here just to qualify. We want to keep improving with every match and aim to win the tournament

— Sjoerd Marijne, India's coach

can trouble strong teams. For us, the focus will be on executing our plans well, maintaining our structure, and continuing to play with the same energy and confidence," he said.

The women's World Cup will be played along side the men's in August. AGENCIES

'WANT TO BE IN THICK OF THINGS' Tough tasks? Bring it on, says Bumrah; relishes T20 WC glory

AHMEDABAD: India's pace spearhead Jasprit Bumrah said he relishes taking responsibility in pressure situations and described the T20 World Cup defence as one of the most fulfilling of his career.

Bumrah played a stellar role claiming four wickets as India handed New Zealand a crushing 96-run defeat in the final to become the only team to win the T20 World Cup three times.

"I don't want to hide behind, I want to be in the thick of things. I always wanted to do a tough job," Bumrah, who was adjudged the Player of the match, said in a video shared by BCCI after the victory.

"I've played cricket for that. I started cricket for that. When I'm able to make a difference, that gives me so much joy. No better feeling than that."

For the Gujarat-born pacer, the triumph carried added emotional significance as it came at the venue where his cricket journey began.

"I started my cricket here. I played all my cricket here, come up the ranks through playing for Gujarat over here and winning the World Cup here, winning, being Man of the Match. The last time we fell just short, this time we went over it, really happy."

Bumrah also spoke about



Jasprit Bumrah poses with the T20 WC trophy

PTI

BCCI award coming Gill's way

NEW DELHI: India's Test and ODI captain Shubman Gill is set to be named Cricketer of the Year at the BCCI's annual awards to be held here on March 15. The 26-year-old, who was not picked in the T20 side that defended the World Cup crown last month, enjoyed a stellar run in the other two formats. He amassed 983 runs in Tests, including a whopping 754 in the drawn away series against England in 2025, at average of over 70.

His ODI runs tally stood at 490, including 188 runs during India's title-winning Champions Trophy campaign. AGENCIES

the presence of his family during the title triumph, calling the moment deeply personal.

"My son came. He was there last time as well; this time, he was there. My mum came, really special.

"I don't know about full circles, but really, really happy, back-to-back World Cups never really happen. Really grateful God is really kind, and I couldn't be more thankful." AGENCIES

WORLD PARA ATHLETICS GP Antil leads another glorious day for India



Sumit Antil won the gold in the men's javelin throw

PTI

NEW DELHI: Double Paralympic Games gold medallist javelin thrower Sumit Antil lived up to his formidable reputation by clinching the top podium spot as India enjoyed another gilt-edged day in the World Para Athletics Grand Prix here on Thursday.

The main event of the day was undoubtedly the men's javelin throw (F43/F44/F64), and Antil -- winner of back-to-back gold medals at the Tokyo and Paris Paralympics -- spearheaded the Indian charge by clinching the top spot with a power-packed throw of 69.25 metres. Pushpendra Singh secured the silver medal with a throw of 56.91m, while Poonam Ram took bronze with an effort of 49.48m.

Antil said his winning throw exceeded his own expectations by a couple of metres.

"This time we have multiple tournaments lined up. I will try to perform well in the upcoming competitions. It is an off-season loading phase for me. I was not expecting such a throw; I expected around 67-68m, but the throw was good today at 69.25m. So I am happy, and my team is happy as well," said Antil, the 27-year-old three-time World Championship gold medallist from

India also swept the podium in men's long jump T42/T63, with Shaliesh Kumar winning gold

Sonipat in Haryana.

"I am not changing my technique because we know we are moving in the right direction in our training. Right now, we just need the right conditions where the throw falls perfectly in place. That is why I am participating in tournaments so I can find those conditions somewhere."

India also dominated the men's 400m T13 event, with Subodh Bhatt winning gold in 51.88 seconds, followed by Priyanshu Kaushik (53.19 seconds) and Anvil Kumar (56.91 seconds). In the men's 400m T46/T47 competition, Bhavikumar Din Bharwad secured gold with a time of 49.89 seconds, while fellow Indian Jasbeer finished close behind to take silver in 50.09 seconds. Ivan Cvetkovic of Serbia won bronze with 50.93 seconds. India also swept the podium in men's long jump T42/T63, with Shaliesh Kumar winning gold. AGENCIES

U-17 eves defeat Myanmar

YANGON: Pritika Barman struck twice as the Indian U17 women's team produced a composed performance to defeat Myanmar 2-0 in the first of two international friendly matches at the Thuvunna Stadium here on Thursday.

The friendlies are part of India's preparations for the AFC U17 Women's Asian Cup, scheduled to be held in Suzhou, China, from May 1 to May 17, 2026.

Myanmar, who have also qualified for the continental tournament, are using the fixtures as part of their build-up as well. The second friendly match will be on Saturday.

India delivered a mature and balanced display, scoring once in each half while also maintaining a clean sheet against a spirited Myanmar side.

Goalkeeper Munni played a crucial role when called upon, while the defensive line marshalled by Abhista Basnett and Elizabet Lakra remained organised and composed throughout the contest.

The Young Tigresses began brightly and attempted to assert themselves with controlled possession and measured attacking moves. AGENCIES

Women's Asian Cup: After early exit, AIFF defends India's preparations

NEW DELHI: Subrata Paul, the AIFF's director of national teams, defended the preparations for the AFC Women's Asian Cup on Thursday, describing them as "quite extensive" despite India's group-stage exit from the tournament in Australia.

The team was knocked out of the tournament after losing all three Group C matches, concluding its campaign with a 3-1 defeat to Chinese Taipei in Sydney on Tuesday.

Despite the disappointing results though, the team showed fighting spirit in their final match and in the opener against Vietnam.

"I believe the preparation was actually quite extensive. The Indian team spent around 48 days overseas for exposure. The team played six matches in Turkey and two in Australia. Prior to that, they spent six days in Dubai and played two matches, and earlier had a 13-day camp in Shillong where they played two matches as well," Paul said. "In addition, seven national team players represented East Bengal, where they played SAFF and AFC matches, and also featured in the Indian Women's League, playing six to seven matches. Altogether, the players pre-



India's Pyari Xaxa in action against Chinese Taipei

AIFF

16
The Indian team conceded a total of 16 goals and scored only 2

pared for around 67 days, playing 13 games internationally, and about 17 matches for their club side," said Paul, the former India goalkeeper.

In their first appearance in the tournament on merit, India entered with hopes of advancing, but the team instead fin-

ished bottom of their group following losses to Vietnam (1-2), Japan (0-11), and Chinese Taipei.

"In our initial plan, we had intended to complete the IWL before this tournament. However, at East Bengal's request - so that the AFC Women's Champions League and SAFF Women's Championship commitments could be completed first - the league schedule was adjusted. As a result, instead of all 14 matches, the girls played seven. Even so, the core players still got international matches, which was in the best interest of the national team. The AIFF remained flexible with the IWL schedule to support that objective," Paul said. AGENCIES

Barca's members vote for president with club buried under debt

BARCELONA: The small auditorium in a working-class neighborhood of Barcelona is packed with people listening to a middle-aged man in a suit tell them why he deserves their vote. There are campaign posters, a jingle blaring over loudspeakers, television cameras, lots of handshakes and selfies, and, of course, a stump speech full of pledges as well as barbs for the rival candidate.

But this is not about deciding the next mayor or filling a seat in a national legislature.

This election campaign is to determine who will earn the job of running FC Barcelona during one of its most turbulent periods as it struggles to emerge from a mountain of debt. Barça (pronounced "Barsa" in English) is proud of its slogan of being "more than a club" for its attractive soccer, its connection with Catalan culture, and backing humanitarian causes. But what really makes Barça stand out from other globally followed sports teams is that it is owned by 114,000 due-paying club members, not a billionaire or energy-rich Middle Eastern state like those which control Manchester City and Paris Saint-Germain.

Those Barça club members have been called to cast votes

The election will hinge on voters' views of how Laporta ran the club for the last five years under considerable financial strain

on Sunday in Barcelona and three other cities in northeastern Spain, as well as neighboring Andorra, to pick the club's next president and executive board. "I really like the elections. It makes me feel part of the club. My father was a Barça supporter since I was a little girl. I've lived and loved Barça since I was little," 96-year-old Rosa Capdevila, came in hand, said at a recent event held by incumbent Joan Laporta.

Many voters, however, believe their choice of president, who also acts as the CEO, will prove crucial to the future of Barça's rare ownership model, which is threatened by the highest debt burden of any soccer club in the world, a staggering 2 billion euros Real Madrid is also member-owned and Florentino Pérez has presided over. AGENCIES

George bows out, Mannepalli enters Rd 2

BASEL: Indian shuttler Kiran George bowed out in the men's singles pre-quarterfinals after losing to Hong Kong's Jason Gunawan, while young Tharun Mannepalli advanced to the second round after his opponent Kenta Nishimoto retired in the decider at the Swiss Open here.

George fought hard but lost 18-21, 21-16, 16-21 in a Round-of-16 match, lasting 70 minutes.

India's men's doubles pair of Hariharan Amsakarunan and M.R. Arjun also lost in the pre-quarterfinals, bowing out to Chen Cheng Kuan and Lin Bing-Wei of Chinese Taipei 17-21, 11-21 in 32 minutes.

The ace Indian men's doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty will take on Japan's Hiroki Okamura and Kyohei Yamashita in a pre-quarterfinal match later in the night.

The 24-year-old Mannepalli, ranked 43rd in the world, was leading 16-21 21-16 7-2 when the fifth-seeded Nishimoto retired from the round of 32 match on Wednesday night due to a shoulder issue.

In women's singles, Malvika Bansod failed to get past Thailand's world No. 4 Pornpawee Chochuwong, going down 11-21 15-21. AGENCIES

Champions League: Valverde shines in Real's thumping win over Man City

MADRID: Even without a host of Galacticos, Real Madrid were far too strong for Manchester City in the latest Champions League clash of these titans.

A 3-0 win at the Bernabeu on Wednesday put Madrid in control of this Round-of-16 tie at the halfway mark after a stunning first-half hat-trick by Federico Valverde. The Uruguay international took on the responsibility of inspiring the record 15-time champions in the absence of injured stars Kylian Mbappe, Jude Bellingham and Rodrygo.

"We are Real Madrid and you should never consider us dead," Madrid coach Alvaro Arbeloa told broadcaster Movistar.

The victory could have been even more commanding, but Vinicius Junior's casually taken



Federico Valverde scored his first hat-trick for Real Madrid

AP

second-half penalty was saved by Gianluigi Donnarumma. Defending champion Paris

Saint-Germain beat Chelsea 5-2 and tiny Bodo/Glimt is also in sight of the quarterfi-

5
PSG scored five goals from nine shots in this match, the joint-fewest shots by any side to score 5+ goals

nals after a 3-0 win over Sporting Lisbon. Arsenal drew 1-1 with Bayer Leverkusen.

Madrid masterclass
By fulltime at a rocking Bernabeu, the only comfort City could cling to was the fact that it could have been so much worse. When Vinicius stood

over the ball on the penalty spot shortly before the hour mark, he looked certain add to the lead. But the Brazil forward skipped in his run-up and hit a weak side-footed effort that Donnarumma pushed away.

PSG take control

After losing to Chelsea in the final of the Club World Cup last year, PSG got some revenge. A three-goal advantage after the first leg saw Luis Enrique's team take a big step toward the last eight. Chelsea had twice leveled the game, but a mistake by goalkeeper Filip Jorgensen, who gave the ball away on the edge of his box in the 74th minute, allowed Vitiha to lift a shot into the open net. PSG substitute Khvicha Kvaratskhelia scored twice more to leave Chelsea with a mountain to climb at Stamford Bridge. AGENCIES



Regional Office: Netaji Marg, Nr. Mithakhali Six Roads, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-6. Phone: + 91-79-26421671-75

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, the Authorized Officer issued demand notice to the borrower(s) on the date mentioned against the account stated hereinafter calling upon them to repay the amount within 60 days from the date of receipt of said notice. The borrower(s) having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular the borrower(s) that the undersigned has taken the symbolic possession of the property described herein below under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said Rules on the date mentioned against the account. The borrower(s) in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of the Bank for the amounts, interest, costs and charges thereon. The borrowers'/mortgagors' attention is invited to the provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Name of borrower(s) & Loan Account No.	Description of the property mortgaged (Secured Asset)	Date of Demand Notice	Date of Symbolic Possession Notice	O/s Amount as on date of Demand Notice
Mr. Munna Choudhary S/O-Abdul Mazed Kha Mrs. Reji 71170000007036	All The Piece And Parcel Plot Of 44.59 Sq Mtr Situated At Khet No-147,149 And 255/1MA, Villagekulesara, Dadri, Gautam Buddha Nagar, U.P.-201306. Owned By Munna Choudhary And Same Bounded As Under: North: Other Plot, East: Other Plot, West: 15 Feet. Wide Road, South: Other Plot	January 10, 2025	March 09, 2026	Rs.5,24,686.72
Mr. Dilip Kumar Yadav Mr. Seeta Devi 71180000003824	All The Piece And Parcel Residential Plot Khalsa No. 168, And 607, Sq. Yards 35 Means 29.26 Sq. Mtr, Village Khulsra, Pargana Dadri, Teshil And District Gautum Budh Nagar, Uttar Pradesh - 203207 Owned By Dilip Kumar Yadav And Same Bounded As Under: North: Other Plot, East: Other Plot, West: Seller Plot, South: Other Plot	March 26, 2025	March 09, 2026	Rs.3,75,756.20

Place: Gautam Buddha Nagar
Date: March 13, 2026

Authorised Officer
Bandhan Bank Limited

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice
Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement System

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001 for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

Sr. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	12255003D	Design, Supply, Installation, Testing, Commissioning and Maintenance	41 Nos	30.03.2026
02	09255016	Aar Approved Cartridge Tapered Roller Bearings Class	300 Nos	06.04.2026
03	77269011 RGC	Running Contract for WCMS Crossings (T-9843 & T-9792)	2000 Set	06.04.2026
04	07265018	Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning of IOT-Based Water	4100 C Set	13.04.2026

Note: 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No manual offer will be entertained.
Tender Notice No. 93/2025-2026
Dated: 11.03.2026



Serving Customers With A Smile

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Izhaar, S/o: Sabbir Ahamad, R/o: Village Buraka The Tauru Sohna, Gurgaon, Haryana** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 227/23, U/s: 25/54/59 Arms Act, PS: Fatehpur Beri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Izhaar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Izhaar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Izhaar of FIR No. 227/23, U/s: 25/54/59 Arms Act, PS: Fatehpur Beri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **28.04.2026**.

By Order
Ashish Kumar Meena
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01
Room No. 214
Saket Court Complex, New Delhi

DP/3076/SD/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No.- 11520252026 Date- 09.03.2026

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/North Central Railway/ Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites E-TENDERS on prescribed form for the following work to 13.30 hrs. on **09.04.2026**. The details of the Tender are as under:

S.N.1. Tender No: 258 **Name of work:** Pre and post tamping track measurement survey using Trimble Gdole Vorsys trolley system in DDU-PRYJ and CAR-CPU section under Sr. DEN/II/PRYJ

Approx Cost: ₹ 1,21,85,255.72 **Bid Security:** ₹ 2,10,900.00

Completion Period: 12 months **Date of opening of tender:** 09.04.2026

Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Engineering survey of Railway line/Roadway

S.N.2. Tender No: 259 **Name of work:** Construction of RPF Women changing rooms and short-term facilities for Divyangjan and 02 Nos Hut/Relay room for Interlocking of LCs under Sr. DEN/II/PRYJ at various stations.

Approx Cost: ₹ 1,30,61,602.23 **Bid Security:** ₹ 2,15,300.00

Completion Period: 12 months **Date of opening of tender:** 09.04.2026

Eligibility Criteria for similar work: Any Civil Engineering work

1. Tender on line can be submitted up to 13.30 hrs. of tender opening date.
2. The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders are available on Website www.ireps.gov.in up to 13.30 hrs. on the due date of tender opening.

553/26 FA

North central railways @ @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

No. T. 24-25. Upgrade, toilet, RT, Date- 11.03.2026

Corrigendum

Corrigendum to Tender Notice No. T. 24-25. Upgrade, toilet, RT, Date- 13.02.2026

Description- Tender Closing Date & Time: Published date and time: 26.03.2026, 15.30 Modified date and time: 06.04.2026, 15.30

Bidding Start Date: Published date and time: 12.03.2026 Modified date and time: 23.03.2026

Note:- All other terms and conditions remain the same. 345/26 FA

North central railways @ @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

COURT NOTICE
(U/o 5 Rule 20 CPC)
(SUCCESSION CASE)
IN THE COURT OF Sh.Rajeev
Additional Civil Judge (Senior Division) Hisar
1. Jiya, Daughter of Late Vinod Kumar
2. Master Ansh Kumar s/o Late Vinod Kumar
3. Master Gurujesh Kumar s/o Late Vinod Kumar
(all minors through their grandmother & natural guardian Bharto Devi)
4. Bharto Devi w/o Vijay Singh All R/o Village Landhi Sukhlamban District Hisar Vs.
1. Neetu w/o late Vinod Kumar R/o Kutub Hansi etc
Petition U/s 372 of the Indian Succession Act, 1925 for grant of succession certificate
CNR No. HRHS02-002925-2025
Next Date:- 21-04-2026
NOTICE TO:
General Public
In above titled case, the defendant (s)/ respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on 21-04-2026 at 10.00 am.
For details login to https://highcourtchd.gov.in?mod=distict_notice&district=Hisar
Sd/- Sh. Rajeev
Additional Civil Judge (Senior Division) dated 09.03.2026 Hisar

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN-E-TENDER NOTICE

The Sr. Divisional Engineer-II, Northern Railway, Delhi Division invites E-Tender for the following work.

1	NIT-75	Name of work:- Elimination of level crossing no. 114 at km 117-1/2 by construction of LHS (5.0 x 5.0)m under ADEN/SMQL on DSA-SMQL-TPZ Section under jurisdiction of Sr. DEN-II/DLI. Approx cost of work:- ₹ 6,39,35,018.64 Earnest Money to be deposited:- ₹ 4,69,700.00
2	NIT-76	Name of work:- Provision of new RPF barracks (SBB & Noli), upgradation of existing RPF thana & barracks (TPZ) in the section of ADEN/MUT under jurisdiction of Sr. DEN-II/DLI. Approx cost of work:- ₹ 2,20,27,903.96 Earnest Money to be deposited:- ₹ 2,60,100.00
3	NIT-77	Name of work:- Construction of RCC Over Head tank at MDNR & MUZ in the section SSEN/WMTc under ADEN/MUT under jurisdiction of Sr. DEN-II/DLI. Approx cost of work:- ₹ 2,40,38,456.51 Earnest Money to be deposited:- ₹ 2,70,200.00
4	Date & Time of opening of tender	07.04.2026 15:00 Hrs.
5	Website particulars where complete details of tender documents can be seen	www.ireps.gov.in

* The tenderer/s must be registered on the Indian Railway E-Procurement system (IREPS) site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for participating in the e-tender system. * For all terms and conditions please refer tender document. * No manual offers are acceptable. * Cost of tender document and Earnest money will be acceptable through net banking or payment gateway only.

No.: 128-W/280/eTender Notice/NIT-75, 76 & 77-25-26-W-II Dated: 10.03.2026 836/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTHERN RAILWAY
NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Name of Work and its location 63-SRDEE-G-DLI-2025-26
Electrical work in connection with provision of wooden flooring, false ceiling, tiles, doors, painting etc. in rooms/halls at fourth floor and fifth floor at Rail Bhawan.

Approx. Cost of the works in Rs. 1,02,48,551.00/-

Address of the office Sr. Div. Elect. Engineer/General, New Delhi.

Earnest Money Rs 201300.00/-

Last Date & time of submission of tender 02.04.2026, 16.00 Hrs.

Opening of tender 02.04.2026, 16.00 Hrs.

Website & notice board www.ireps.gov.in & Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer/General, New Delhi

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 813/26

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Pushkar S/o Late Sushil Kumar R/o 7/71, Old Geeta Colony, Delhi-110031** Also at: 7/71, Block-5, Geeta Colony, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence FIR No. 145/2018 u/s 186/353/333 IPC at P.S. Barakhamba Road, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Pushkar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Pushkar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding u/s 82 Cr.P.C. has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Pushkar** accused of FIR No. 145/2018 u/s 186/353/333 IPC at P.S. Barakhamba Road, New Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on **14.04.2026**.

By Order: **Ms. Vijayshree Rathore,**
Judicial Magistrate, First Class-05,
Room No. 13, First Floor, Main Building,
Patiala House Courts, New Delhi.

DP/3184/NDD/2026

BSES
BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, New Delhi
TENDER NOTICE Date: 13.03.2026
Tender under two parts (Un-priced & priced) are invited for the supply of following materials from all bidders:-

NIT No.	Brief Item Description	Estimated Cost (₹)	Cost of EMD (₹)	Due Date & Time of Submission	Date & Time of Opening
CMC/BR/26-27/FK/PR/RJ/1345	RATE CONTRACT FOR SUPPLY OF VARIOUS RATINGS OF DRY TYPE DISTRIBUTION TRANSFORMER IN BRPL	11.40 Crores	11,40,000/-	03.04.2026 15:00 HRS	03.04.2026 15:30 HRS

Cost of each Tender Document: ₹ 1180/-
For any query call on 011-49107235 or e-mail on Brpl.Eaution@reliancegroupindia.com
For details in respect of Equipment/BOM/Services, Qualifying requirements, Terms & conditions, purchase/submission of tender documents etc. please visit our website www.bsesdelhi.com

Head (Contracts & Materials)
Regd. Off. : BSES Rajdhani Power Limited, BSES Bhawan, Nehru Place, New Delhi-110019 | Corporate Identification No.: U40109DL2001PLC111527
Telephone No. : +91 11 4910 7235 | Website : www.bsesdelhi.com

ICICI Bank
Branch Office: ICICI Bank Ltd. Regional Office Jsel Building, Malviya Nagar JLN Marg-Jaipur 302017
PUBLIC NOTICE-TENDER CUM E-AUCTION FOR SALE OF SECURED ASSET

[See proviso to Rule 8(6)]
Notice for sale of immovable asset(s)

E-Auction Sale Notice for the sale of immovable asset(s) under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8 (6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

This notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property mortgaged/ charged to the Secured Creditor, the Physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of ICICI Bank Limited will be sold on 'As is where is', 'As is what is' and 'Whatever there is' as per the brief particulars given hereunder:

Sr. No.	Name of Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrowers/ Guarantors/ Loan Account No.	Details of the Secured asset(s) with known encumbrances, if any	Amount Outstanding.	Reserve Price/ Earnest Money Deposit	Date and Time of Property Inspection	Date & Time of E-Auction
(A)	(B)	(C)	(D)	(E)	(F)	(G)
1.	Kripa Shankar Sharma (Applicant) Rekha Sharma (Co-Applicant) A/c No. LBDUA00005692625, LBDUA00005692624	Unit No. S-3, 2nd Floor (Without Roof Rights), Plot No. C-36, Manglam City, Block- C, Village Hathoj, Kalwar Road, Jaipur, Rajasthan- 302012. Area- 750 Sq.ft.	Rs. 12,63,194/- As on March 06, 2026.	Rs. 15,80,000/- To Rs. 1,58,000/-	March 20, 2026 From 11:00 A.M To 2:00 P.M	April 20, 2026 From 11:00 A.M To 12:00 Noon

The online auction will be conducted on the website (URL Link-<https://disposalhub.com>), of our auction agency NexXen Solutions Private Limited. The Mortgagors/ Notices are given a last chance to pay the total dues with further interest by April 18, 2026 before 05:00 PM, else the secured asset(s) will be sold as per schedule. The prospective bidder(s) must submit the Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) Demand Draft (DD) (Refer Column E) at ICICI Bank Ltd. Regional Office Jsel Building, Malviya Nagar JLN Marg-Jaipur 302017 on or before April 18, 2026 before 05:00 PM. Thereafter, they have to submit their offer through the website mentioned above on or before April 18, 2026 before 05:00 PM along with the scanned image of the Bank acknowledged DD towards proof of payment of EMD. In case the prospective bidder(s) is/ are unable to submit his/ her/ their offer through the website, then the signed copy of tender documents may be submitted at ICICI Bank Ltd. Regional Office JSEL Building, Malviya Nagar JLN Marg-Jaipur 302017 on or before April 18, 2026 before 05:00 PM. Earnest Money Deposit DD/PO should be from a Nationalised/ Scheduled Bank in favour of "ICICI Bank Limited" payable at Jaipur.

For any further clarifications in terms of inspection, Terms and Conditions of the E-Auction or submission of tenders, contact ICICI Bank Employee Phone No. 9252097970.

Please note that Marketing agencies 1. Ms NexXen Solutions Private Limited, 2. Augoe Assets Management Private Limited 3. Motex Net Pvt. Ltd. 4. Finwin Estate Dept Technologies Pvt Ltd 5. Ginnorsoft Pvt Ltd 6. Hecto Prop Tech Pvt Ltd 7. Arca Emart Pvt Ltd 8. Novel Asset Service Pvt Ltd 9. Nobroker Technologies Solutions Pvt Ltd 10. Navodayan Proptech Private Limited (XpertARC), have also been engaged for facilitating the sale of this property.

The Authorised Officer reserves the right to reject any or all the bids without furnishing any further reasons. For detailed Terms and Conditions of the sale, please visit www.icicibank.com 4p4s

Date: March 13, 2026
Place: New Delhi

Authorized Officer,
ICICI Bank Limited

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Tender Notice

Cleaning of fresh air & Return air filters, AC grills and cooling/condenser coils of AC coaches during maintenance works at Washing Line/Sick Line and On-Board Electrical Escorting Duties in Primary-Base Shatabdi/Tejas/Shatabdi-Type/AC Express (Chair Car) type Trains under SSE/PC/STB/New Delhi depot over Delhi Division for Three years.

Tender No.	30-Elect-8-T-Chg-2025-26
Approx cost of the work in (Rs.)	Rs.7,19,76,808.06/-
Cost of tender form	Rs. 0.00
Address of the Office	Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer/Chg/Northern Railway New Delhi
Earnest Money	Rs.5,09,900/-
Period of completion of work	36 Months
Last date & time of submission of tender	02.04.2026 up to 15.00 hrs.
and opening of tender	02.04.2026 up to 15.01 hrs.
Website & notice board	www.ireps.gov.in & Sr. DEE/Chg/DLI 826/2026

Serving Customers With A Smile

APPENDIX IV-A
Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property

E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) and Rule 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable Property mortgaged to Sammaan Capital Limited (formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.) [CIN : L65922DL2005PLC136029] ("Secured Creditor"), the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "as is where is", "as is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on 30.03.2026 from 05.00 P.M. to 06.00 P.M., for recovery of Rs. 40,88,710/- (Rupees Forty Lakh Eighty Eight Thousand Seven Hundred Ten only) pending towards Loan Account No. HHLNOI00303982, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till 11.03.2026 with applicable future interest in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document(s) w.e.f. 12.03.2026 along with legal expenses and other charges due to the Secured Creditor from AMIT KUMAR and REENA BALIYAN.

The Reserve Price of the Immovable Property will be Rs. 16,45,000/- (Rupees Sixteen Lakh Forty Five Thousand only) and the Earnest Money Deposit ("EMD") will be Rs. 1,64,500/- (Rupees One Lakh Sixty Four Thousand Five Hundred only) i.e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
FLAT NO. S - 4, MIG, 2ND FLOOR, REAR RIGHT HAND SIDE, PLOT NO. C1/103, DLF DILSHAD EXTN. - II, GHAZIABAD - 201010, UTTAR PRADESH.

For detailed terms and conditions of sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. www.sammaancapital.com; Contact No : 0124 - 6910910, +91 7065451024; E-mail id : auctionhelpline@sammaancapital.com. For bidding, log on to www.auctionfocus.in.

Sd/-
AUTHORISED OFFICER
SAMMAAN CAPITAL LIMITED
(Formerly known as)
INDIABULLS HOUSING FINANCE LTD.)

Date : 11.03.2026
Place : GHAZIABAD

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE (Through e-tendering)

Name of work with its location	Comprehensive Annual maintenance Contract of SSDAC of CEL make for three years over Delhi Division.		
App. Cost of the work	₹4,75,02,443.52/-	Bid Security	₹3,87,500.00/-
Address of the office	Senior Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer-C, Northern Railway, 3rd Floor, Annex-1, DRM Office, New Delhi-110055.		
Date & Time for uploading the tender/ closing of the tender	Tender uploading 11.03.2026/ closing date & time - 06.04.2026 up to 15.00 hrs.		
Website particular & notice board location where complete details of the tender can be seen etc.	See the Northern Railway website www.ireps.gov.in & Notice board at the S&T branch, 3rd Floor, DRM office, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055.		

Tender No. 558-Sig-16-M-T-AMC-095 Dated: 11.03.2026

SERVING CUSTOMER WITH A SMILE 831/2026

UJVN Ltd.
(An Uttarakhnad Govt. Enterprises)
H.O. "UJJWAL" Maharani Bagh, GMS Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone-0135-2735909 Fax 0135-2735909
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvn.com

RO No. 211 **SHORT TERM TENDER NOTICE** Date: 12.03.2026
Office of the Executive Engineer (M&G) Kulhal Power Station, Kulhal, invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:
Tender No. 16/UJVNL/EE (M&G)/KPS/2025-26 "Operation and cleaning work of 33/11 KV Kulhal Substation, under Kulhal power House for Six months"
Estimated cost : Rs. 9,57,655/- GST Extra
Date of availability of bid document on website: 13/03/2026 11:00 Hrs
Last date for submission of tender: 28/03/2026 13:00 Hrs
For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website. The tender documents can be downloaded from the Nigam's website "www.ujvn.com"
Executive Engineer (M&G) Kulhal

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Saheeb Khan @ Bunty R/o H. No. 160, Masjid Wali Gali, Akbar Pur Majra, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 243/2017 U/s 302/120B/201/380/411/341 IPC Act, PS Burari, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Saheeb Khan @ Bunty** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Saheeb Khan @ Bunty** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Saheeb Khan @ Bunty** of case **FIR No. 243/2017 U/s 302/120B/201/380/411/341 IPC Act, PS Burari, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **16.04.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Bhupinder Singh
Additional Sessions Judge-05
Central Dist., Room No. 209
Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi

OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER (CIVIL), CSPGCL,
Shed No. 11, Dangania, Raipur-492013 Phone No. 0771-2574562, website www.cspc.co.in E-mail:- civilprojectcmg@gmail.com
No.04-04/W/2545 Raipur, Date 11.03.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Online bids are invited through CSPCL e-bidding system (SAP SRM) from contractors registered in appropriate class in CSPGCL in three-part tendering system. The unregistered contractor having experience in Govt./Public Sector Undertaking/Local bodies/Power Generating Companies in India only may be considered on submission of experience certificate for following work as mentioned below:-

Tender	Name of Work	NIT value
Specifi. No. CEC/ABVT PS-MRW/ W/2025/ 206	Annual repair & maintenance of load line, return line and oil siding line including MGR loop and pre-monsoon work of CSPGCL, Railway siding line of 2x500MW ABVTPS, CSPGCL, Janjgir-Champa E-Comp. No.- 241299	151.20 Lacs

Note:- (i) The detailed NIT, Eligibility Criteria, Tender document & other details can be viewed and downloaded online from our e-bidding portal <https://ebidding.cspcl.co.in:50724/irj/portal>, (ii) NIT value is inclusive of GST @ 18%.
SAVE ELECTRICITY samvad 47172/1 Chief Engineer (Civil) CSPGCL, Raipur

GOVERNMENT OF WEST BENGAL
NEW TOWN KOLKATA DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
Administrative Building,
Plot No. DG/13, Premises No. 04-3333, Action Area-ID, New Town, Kolkata-700156
Inviting Proposal for the following Advertisement Rights on monthly license basis:
1. Allotment of Digital Advertising Rights at the Cricket Stadium, New Town.
2. Allotment of Digital Advertising Rights at Food Truck Zone, near Clock Tower, New Town.
3. Allotment of Digital Advertising Rights at Zero Shop, First Rotary, New Town.
4. Allotment of Digital Advertising Rights on Different Community Markets of NKDA.
For details, please visit: <http://nkdamar.org>
Sd/- Administrative Officer (EM)
New Town Kolkata Development Authority



The South Indian Bank Ltd
Regional Office - Delhi, 3rd Floor, Plot No. 21, 21/1, Pusa Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi -110005,
Phone - 011 4233 1664/ 011 4512 8661
email- ro1008@sib.co.in

Ref: DEL/CRD/SAR/76/2025-26 Date : 12-03-2026

E - AUCTION SALE NOTICE

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) and 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.

- M/s. Shri Gangadas Textile Industries Limited, 7098 Shop no. 1, Jain Market, Guru Nanak Gali, Gandhi Nagar, Delhi- 110 031, Also at: F 224, Focal Point, Phase VIII, Chandigarh Road, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 010, Also at: Ground & First Floor, Property no. 465, Near Sabzi Mandi, Jheel Khurana, Delhi 110 051
- M/S GG Fabrics under proprietorship of Mr. Nitin Dawar at F 224, Focal Point, Phase VIII, Chandigarh Road, Ludhiana Punjab- 141 010
- Mr. Pankaj Ahuja 4181, 04 Duragpuri Haibowal Kalan, Ludhiana, Punjab- 141 001
- Mrs. Hema Ahuja 4181, 04 Duragpuri Haibowal Kalan, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 001
- Mr. Rakesh Kumar 74/2, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi 110 051
- Mr. Suresh Kumar 74/2, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi 110 051
- Mr. Vinay Dawar House No. 267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 012
- Mr. Nitin Dawar, House No. 267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141 012 (Personal guarantor and legal heir of late Ramesh Kumar)
- Mrs. Shivani Kochar, 74/2, Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi 110 051, also at, House No.267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141012.(Legal heir of late Ramesh Kumar)
- Mrs. Savita Dawar, House No. 267, Block A, Rajguru Nagar, Ludhiana, Punjab 141012, also at, House 504 Block GG BRS Nagar Extension, Opposite Verka Milk Plant, Ferozpur Road, Ludhiana-141012, also at 74/2 Ram Nagar Extension, Krishna Nagar, Delhi-110051

Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the borrower/guarantor/ Legal heirs that the below described immovable properties mortgaged to the South Indian Bank Ltd, Branch Vasundhara (Secured Creditor), the Physical Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of The South Indian Bank Limited (Secured Creditor), will be sold on "as is where is" basis, "as is what is" and "whatever there is" condition on 02-04-2026 for recovery of an amount of Rs.16,92,38,143.26/- (Rupees Sixteen Crore Ninety Two Lakh Thirty Eight Thousand One Hundred Forty Three and Twenty Six Paise Only) as on 16-02-2026, with future interest, costs and expenses etc. thereon due to The South Indian Bank Limited, Branch Vasundhara (Secured Creditor), from the above mentioned Borrower(s) and guarantor(s).

ITEM NO.1	
Name of Property Owner	Late Mr.Ramesh Kumar(Now represented by legal heirs Mrs. Savita Dawar, Mr. Vinay Dawar, Mr. Nitin Dawar and Mrs. Shivani Kochar), Mr. Rakesh Kumar and Mr. Suresh Kumar
Description of property	All that Part and Parcel of Freehold Residential Property admeasuring 50 square yards out of area measuring 100 sq. yds. out of total area measuring 218 sq. yds. out of Khalsa no. 464/202 along with Residential Buildings constructed upon it bearing No. MP/ 783/18-A/5 (old), New No. UO/17712 along with all other constructions, improvements, Easementary Rights existing and appurtenant thereon situated at Gaur Nanak Gali, Gandhi Nagar, Village Seelampur, Illaga Shahdara, Delhi 110 031 owned by Late Ramesh Kumar Dawar (since expired and represented by his legal heirs; Mrs. Savita Dawar, Mr. Vinay Dawar, Mr. Nitin Dawar and Mrs Shivani Kochar), Mr. Rakesh Kumar and Mr. Suresh Kumar more particularly described under Sale Deed No. 1287 dated 09-05-1989 at SRO -IV, New Delhi/ Delhi and Will dated 02-06-1997 bounded on North by Common Passage, South by Other's property, East by Common wall & Shop No.7 and west by common wall and shop No.5
Reserve Price (Item No.1)	Rs. 1,70,00,000/- (Rupees One Crore Seventy Lakh Only)
Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) (Item No. 1)	Rs. 17,00,000/- (Rupees Seventeen Lakhs Only) EMD shall be deposited on or before 01.04.2026 till 02.00 PM
Bid Increment amount Item No. 1	Rs. 10,000/- (Rupees Ten Thousand Only)
Date and time of E-auction Item No.1	02.04.2026 from 11:00 AM to 11:30 AM (with 5 minute unlimited auto extensions till sale is concluded)
Encumbrances known to the Bank (Item No.1)	Nil/ Encumbrances from 01.01.2018 to 22.11.2022
For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in web portal of South Indian Bank Ltd. (Secured Creditor) website i.e. www.southindianbank.com . Details also available at https://bankauctions.in . For any further clarification with regards to inspection of property, terms and conditions of the e-auction or submission of bids, kindly contact South Indian Bank Ltd on 9818-772-322 / 7309-655-552 / 9007-046-006 (contact number).	

Sd/- AUTHORISED OFFICER

CFM ASSET RECONSTRUCTION PRIVATE LIMITED
REGISTERED OFFICE: "Block no. A/1003, West Gate, Near YMCA Club, Sur No. 835/1+3, S. G. Highway, Makarba, Ahmedabad-380051 Gujarat"
CORPORATE OFFICE: 1st Floor, Wakefield House, Spurt Road, Ballard

NO ROOM FOR ‘I’ IN FILMMAKING: SAURABH

The actor-director credits actors Pankaj Kapur and Dimple Kapadia for making the shoot of ‘Jab Khuli Kitaab’ smooth

ANINDITA ACHARYA

Saurabh Shukla never believes in blowing his own trumpet. So, despite playing the pivotal role in his play ‘Jab Khuli Kitaab’ for years, when he decided to adapt it on ‘Zee5’, the actor-director chose to cast Pankaj Kapur.

“The beauty of filmmaking is that it is not I, me or myself. It is a group of people coming together to brainstorm ideas. In my mind, I never wanted to cast myself as Gopal ji. Rather, I always wanted Pankaj ji to play the role,” he said.

Known as one of the most powerful actors in Indian cinema, Shukla commands attention whenever he appears on screen. Be it his iconic roles in ‘Satya’, ‘Lage Raho Munna Bhai’, ‘Barfi!’ or ‘Jolly LLB’, here’s an actor par excellence who shines in any character. Apart from acting, he also channels his creative intent through direction. ‘Jab Khuli Kitaab’ took more than two years of his life, but he isn’t complaining. It’s a labour of love and he has managed a casting coup with Kapur and Dimple Kapadia playing the leads. Interestingly, it wasn’t Shukla’s idea to get Dimple on board. Naren Kumar, one

of his producers, nudged him.

“I didn’t have the courage to even think about her. I thought, ‘She is such a huge star and would be busy’. But Naren convinced me. So, I sent the script with no hope that this would materialise. But then, on the third day, Dimple ma’am called me and said she would play the character of Anusuya. She was a breeze

to work with,” said the director of films like ‘Dry Day’, ‘I M 24’ and ‘Raati Gayi Baat Gayi’.

Many actors find it difficult to separate acting from directing when they take up the megaphone, but Shukla said that he has been lucky to have been spoiled by filmmakers like Shekhar Kapoor, Sudhir Mishra, Ram Gopal Varma and Kamal Haasan.

“Whenever I have

worked with Kamal Haasan, he has never tried to show me or enact the scene. This creative process is common among good artistes. As an actor, I draw a lot of things from my own life and the way I have understood life. So, when Pankaj ji or Dimple ma’am played the parts, they brought in several nuances from their own experiences, which made the characters blossom,” said the ‘Subedaar’

actor.

‘Jab Khuli Kitaab’ is a take on long-term marriages and how an elderly couple decides to seek a divorce after 50 years of togetherness. Shukla has seen such couples in real life and through his film, he asks whether a long relationship can stand the acid test of truth.

“This story says that everything looks good in a long relationship until the truth penetrates. Once the truth enters the relationship, there’s nothing to hide. If the relationship still survives, you know it’s everlasting,” he said.

Shukla’s film is streaming on ‘Zee5’ and hasn’t been released in theatres. According to the veteran actor-director, OTT has opened avenues for many. “I never had a doubt that OTT has been a wonderful development. This is because the market can ultimately take on only a certain number of films. So, there is another outlet. At the end of the day, a filmmaker wants the product to reach the maximum audience and OTT does that,” he said.



“Whenever I have worked with Kamal Haasan, he has never tried to show me or enact the scene. This creative process is common among good artistes”

‘Education makes society better’

Viineet Kumar Singh headlines Netflix’s ‘Hello Bachhon’

Viineet Kumar Singh, who headlines Netflix’s new real-life inspired drama around a teacher in ‘Hello Bachhon’, said he resonates with the theme of the show of making quality education accessible to all.

Created by Abhishek Yadav, the education-themed drama series is inspired by the true story of Alakh Pandey, founder of ‘Physics Wallah’, an educational technology company. Pratish Mehta helms the show.

“This entire journey of Alakh Pandey sir is such that he has touched every corner of India. Education is a fundamental need right now. A dialogue in a show says, ‘Education shouldn’t be a luxury. It’s a birthright’. When an educated person has been taught under the guidance of a good teacher, that person becomes a better human being. Society is made up of you and me combined. So, our society also becomes better. Education doesn’t just change your life; it makes our society better as well,” Singh told PTI.

Known for his performances in films such as ‘Mukka-baaz’, ‘Superboys of Malegaon’, ‘Jaat’

The education-themed drama series is inspired by the true story of Alakh Pandey, founder of ‘Physics Wallah’

and ‘Chhaava’, Singh clarified the show isn’t a biopic despite being inspired by a true story. “You feel the responsibility when you are living such a character in a show with whom a lot of people, millions of people, have feelings attached. So, you can’t do anything right or left. This isn’t a biopic. There’s a lot,” he said.

The Varanasi-born actor, who was pursuing medicine to fulfil his father’s dream before he changed paths, said he has a first-hand understanding of the dynamic between a student and a teacher. He called it destiny to be part of this educational show.

“I was studying to become a doctor so that I could enter the film industry. I fulfilled that commitment. I promised my father that I wouldn’t stop studying,” he added. PTI



LORD OF THE RINGS: THE HUNT FOR GOLLUM

KATE WINSLET IN TALKS TO STAR IN THE FILM

The actress will join Andy Serkis in the movie

Hollywood star Kate Winslet is moving from one fantasy land to another. The actress, who just recently reunited with her ‘Titanic’ director James Cameron for ‘Avatar: Fire and Ash’, is in talks to star in ‘Lord of the Rings: The Hunt for Gollum’.

Winslet will join Andy Serkis in the movie, who is directing and reprising his popular role from the original Peter Jackson trilogy, reported ‘Variety’.

‘Warner Bros.’ hasn’t confirmed who will appear in the upcoming film, but Elijah Wood and Ian McKellen are reportedly reprising their roles as Frodo Baggins and Gandalf, respectively.

Jackson, who originally adapted J R R Tolkien’s novel for the big screen, is producing the film with his creative partners Fran Walsh and Philippa Boyens. ‘The Hunt for Gollum’ also reunites Winslet with Jackson after they last worked together in 1994’s ‘Heavenly Creatures’.

The film is slated to be released in theatres on December 17, 2027. The story details aren’t out yet, but it is most likely set between the events of ‘The Hobbit’ and ‘The Fellowship of the Ring’.

Both ‘Lord of the Rings’ and its prequel series ‘The Hobbit’ were major box office hits. PTI



MOST WATCHED INDIAN ‘ORIGINAL’ MOVIE

‘Subedaar’ breaks records in its opening weekend

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video’ announced the record-breaking performance of its latest Prime Original Hindi movie, ‘Subedaar’, which premiered worldwide on March 5 and trended in the ‘Top 10’ on ‘Prime Video’ across 31 countries during the opening weekend, highlighting the growing global reach of Indian storytelling. The emotionally charged action drama became the most-watched Indian Original movie on the service in its opening weekend.

In India, during its launch window on the service, ‘Subedaar’ garnered record viewership across 91 per cent of the country’s pin codes, underscoring its strong resonance with audiences. The film’s performance underscores the increasing appetite for compelling, rooted Indian stories that blend powerful storytelling with high-octane action, further reinforcing Prime Video’s position as the home for bold, character-driven Indian stories that resonate with audiences in India and around the world.

“Subedaar’s success is a reflection of the growing scale and global



The film has struck a chord with audiences through its gritty action, emotional storytelling and cinematic scale

resonance of Indian storytelling. We are delighted that it has become the most-watched Indian original

movie on the service. The film’s emotionally rooted portrayal of a soldier confronting his toughest battles beyond the battlefield has struck a chord. Anil Kapoor delivers an acting masterclass, while Suresh Triveni’s solid direction and great performances from the ensemble cast have resulted in love and appreciation from customers across the world,” said Nikhil Madhok, director and head of ‘Originals’, ‘Prime Video, India’.

Five thrillers worth adding to your binge list right now

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Thrillers work best when they make you uneasy. Not because something jumps out at you, but because something feels slightly off. A character pauses too long before answering a question. A lie begins to crack. A past mistake refuses to stay buried. The most addictive thrillers thrive in that tension, where every conversation feels loaded, every character seems to be hiding something and every reveal shifts the ground beneath your feet. This streaming slate brings exactly that kind of storytelling. From forensic investigations and murder mysteries to psychological mind games and survival thrill rides, these stories lean into suspense in very different ways. If you are in the mood for twists that arrive when you least expect them, here are five thrillers that deserve a spot on your watchlist.

Thrillers work best when they make you uneasy. Not because something jumps out at you, but because something feels slightly off. A character pauses too long before answering a question. A lie begins to crack. A past mistake refuses to stay buried. The most addictive thrillers thrive in that tension, where every conversation feels loaded, every character seems to be hiding something and every reveal shifts the ground beneath your feet. This streaming slate brings exactly that kind of storytelling. From forensic investigations and murder mysteries to psychological mind games and survival thrill rides, these stories lean into suspense in very different ways. If you are in the mood for twists that arrive when you least expect them, here are five thrillers that deserve a spot on your watchlist.

Scarpetta

Patricia Cornwell’s legendary forensic investigator finally makes her leap to stream on Prime Video’s ‘Scarpetta’. Nicole Kidman leads this highly anticipated thriller series as Dr Kay Scarpetta, a brilliant medical examiner who uses forensic science to speak for the dead. When a chilling serial killer case lands on her desk, Kay is forced to confront a career-defining investigation from 28 years ago that could threaten everything she’s built. As past and



Patricia Cornwell’s legendary forensic investigator finally makes her leap to stream on ‘Scarpetta’

present collide, ‘Scarpetta’ must confront old ghosts while racing to stop a killer who always seems one step ahead.

Accused

Boasting Konkana Sen Sharma and Pratibha Ranta in the lead, Netflix’s ‘Accused’ follows a renowned gynaecologist, whose

carefully built life begins to unravel when a series of serious allegations surface against her. As the accusations threaten to destroy both her professional reputation and personal life, the situation grows even more complicated when her wife begins investigating the truth herself, uncovering secrets that blur the line between innocence and guilt. What follows is a gripping psychological thriller about trust, power and the consequences of buried truths.

The Housemaid

Based on Freida McFadden’s wildly popular novel, Apple TV+’s ‘The Housemaid’ is a riveting

mystery thriller starring Sydney Sweeney, Amanda Seyfried and Brandon Sklenar. Directed by Paul Feig, the film follows Millie, who takes a job as a live-in housemaid for the wealthy Winchester couple, hoping for a fresh start. But what begins as the perfect opportunity soon spirals into a dangerous web of secrets, scandal and shifting power, as the truth behind the mansion’s closed doors proves far darker than it seems.

Kohrra 2

After the haunting first season, Netflix’s ‘Kohrra’ returned to the fields and towns of rural Punjab with another unsettling murder investigation. As Sub-inspector

Dhanwant Kaur (Mona Singh) and Assistant Sub-inspector Amarpal Jasjit Garundi (Barun Sobti) join forces to dig deeper into the case, they uncover family tensions, buried resentment and personal secrets that stretch far beyond the crime itself. What makes this crime thriller enthralling is its slow-burning storytelling, where the emotional lives of the investigators become just as complicated as the case they are trying to solve.

Pretty Lethal

‘Pretty Lethal’ is an action-packed thriller that follows five rival ballerinas en route to a prestigious dance competition when their bus breaks down in a remote forest. Forced to take shelter at an eerie roadside inn run by the mysterious former ballet prodigy Devora Kasimer, played by Uma Thurman, the dancers soon realise that something is unsettlingly wrong. As danger closes in, they must put aside their rivalries and rely on years of relentless training, turning their precision, discipline and even pointe shoes into unexpected weapons in a fight for survival. The film is set to premiere on March 18 on ‘Prime Video’.

Whether you’re drawn to mind-bending mysteries, high-stakes investigations or stories where every secret carries deadly consequences, these thrillers promise the kind of suspense that keeps you hooked!

